

NOT A POTATO

AIMED AT THE SEA



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Chapter 1 — Arrival: The Giant's Shadow

The pampa doesn't ease you in. There's no foothills, no fringe of scrub that says *softer country ahead*. The truck climbs out of Huara on a road that's mostly suggestion, and then the land just opens, flat and pale and going nowhere in every direction, and Cerro Unitas sits on it like a thing someone left there. A low hill, alone. The driest non-polar desert on the planet, and it doesn't perform its dryness. It just is dry, the way a stone is a stone.

I read the hill before I read the figure. That's how my head works — I take the geometry first, the lines and the slopes, the way a route would want to cross a place, and only then the meaning people hung on it. So I saw the hill as a billboard before I saw what was written on it: a slope angled south-southwest, catching the low afternoon light full-on, visible from a frankly stupid distance across open ground. If you wanted to be seen by everyone walking the pampa for a thousand years, you'd build here. Somebody did.

"There," said Mara, from the back seat, and she didn't point, because Mara doesn't point at things, she just stops and lets you find them.

The Giant.

A hundred and nineteen metres of human figure standing upright on the hillside. The largest prehistoric anthropomorphic geoglyph on Earth — that's not a brochure line, that's a measured fact, a record nobody's beaten because there's nothing bigger of its kind anywhere. A blocky body. Legs apart, planted. A square-ish head, and rising off the head, the thing everyone comes for: a crown of rays. Lines radiating out, stiff and deliberate, like a child's sun, like a headdress,

like — and here's where everyone's voice goes funny — antennae.

I sat in the cooling truck and let it land on me once, the way you're supposed to. Not chasing it down with a theory. Just the size of it. From here it read as a man watching the road, and the road was us.

"Built around the year 1000 to 1400," Mara recited, flat, the way she recites everything, the data laid down like flagstones. "Andean cultures, regional. Extractive and additive both — they scraped the dark desert varnish off the slope to show the pale ground underneath, *and* they piled dark stones on light ground where they wanted the dark to read. Two techniques in one figure. It's not a drawing. It's a relief made of two soils."

Mara is autistic and she is the reason this crew functions, because she holds the entire fact-floor in her head without it touching her feelings, and she will say the unflattering true thing in a meeting where everyone else is being gracious. She'd had the Atacama numbers for three weeks. Five thousand geoglyphs out here, give or take. Most of them strung along the old llama-caravan corridors, sitting at the points where you'd need to know where you were — fork in the route, water two days off, a pass. Signposts. Landmarks. A pre-Columbian highway system written on the ground, and the Giant the biggest sign on it.

"It's a deity," I said, because that's the official line and the official line deserves to be said straight, with a flat face, no smirk. "Or a shaman. Or an authority figure. A power image. You stand a hundred-and-nineteen-metre man on the only hill for miles and everybody who walks past knows whose land they're crossing."

"That's the consensus," Mara agreed.

"It's a good consensus," I said. And it is. There's no shame in it. People make giant images of power and put them where you can't miss them — we did it with emperors and we do it with brand logos. The deity reading isn't lazy. It fits the whole regional tradition like a key in a lock.

The fish — that's what we call the voice in the editing booth, the heckle, the one of us who's always in our ears even when she's not in the truck — crackled on the radio.

"So it's a billboard for a god," said Tana. "Cool. Why's the god got a

TV aerial.”

Nobody answered her. You learn not to.

We came around the base of Cerro Unitas and the first thing that wasn't ancient was the fence.

Not a wall. Heritage people don't do walls, walls photograph like prisons. They do bollards and tensioned cable and tasteful interpretive signage, and they do banners — and there were the banners, snapping in the wind that comes off the pampa in the afternoon, navy and white, a clean sans-serif wordmark and a stylised little ray-crowned head reduced to an icon. PATRIMONIO. A ministry crest beside a private one I half-recognised, a tourism foundation, the kind that funds a visitor centre and a glass walkway and a gift shop with replica geoglyphs printed on tote bags.

“They've fenced the caravan path,” I said.

I knew the path before I saw the fence on it. That's the thing — I'd been reading the ground the whole drive, the faint braids of old track that the pampa keeps because the pampa keeps everything, footprints from caravans that stopped walking five hundred years ago still legible as a scuff of disturbed varnish. The route ran in along the southwest, exactly where you'd want to be to see the Giant standing up properly on his slope, and the cable fence ran straight across it with a gate and a guard hut and a sign that said the obvious thing in three languages: access controlled, research in progress, watch this space.

“They filed for restricted access in March,” Mara said. “Granted on an interim basis. It's a conservation order. Technically the path is closed for protection. The figure's getting documented by their team. After that, managed viewing only. Boardwalk. Timed tickets.”

“They want to *fix* it,” said Ezra, and he didn't mean repair.

Ezra had the camera out already, low against his chest, not raised, just held, the way he holds it when he's deciding whether the thing in front of him is worth pointing at or whether pointing at it would be a kind of theft. Ezra shot three wars before he shot anything still, and the war's still in how he watches the perimeter — he'd clocked the

guard hut and the two consortium vehicles and the angle of the light before I'd finished reading the fence. He sees what people flinch from. Right now what he saw was a place being closed, gently, by people who would tell you, sincerely, that they loved it.

And they would mean it. That's the trap of these outfits. They aren't villains. They aren't a cabal. They are a heritage ministry and a tourism foundation who have watched four-wheel-drive tracks scar the pampa, watched idiots carve their initials, watched a hundred and nineteen metres of irreplaceable ground art take damage that no soil this slow will ever heal, and they have decided, out of love, to lock it. To settle what it means, print the meaning on a placard, and build a railing so the meaning can't get away.

"The deity reading," I said slowly. "If you're them — that's the reading you want. It's clean. It's national. It's grant-friendly. *Ancient Andean power figure, monument to the divine*. You can put that on a banner."

"And it might be true," Mara said.

"And it might be true," I agreed. That's the discipline of this. The official story isn't the enemy. The enemy is the railing.

We weren't getting past the gate today. The guard was apologetic and immovable and correct, and we stood at the cable line in the wind doing the only thing you can do at a closed door, which is read it from outside.

So we tried to read the Giant from where we were allowed to stand, and the Giant declined.

Here's the potato — the thing that looks easy until you put your own hands on it. You'd think, would you not, that a hundred-and-nineteen-metre figure laid flat on a hillside is just a *big* version of a thing you understand. Scale up the kid's drawing. But the slope plays tricks. From the viewing point the consortium had cleared — too far west, the wrong sightline — the Giant fell apart. The legs foreshortened into a smear. The torso went lopsided. The proportions that look so balanced in the famous overhead photos came undone, because the famous photos are shot from the air, and nobody who made this ever flew. They built it to be read from the ground, from somewhere specific, and we weren't standing where they meant.

We put up the drone to cheat.

The drone is a good drone. It is also a small light object, and the pampa wind in the afternoon is neither, and the two of them had a brief disagreement that the wind won. The thing yawed, fought, ate battery clawing to hold a hover, and the footage came back as a seasick wobble of pale and dark ground that flattened the relief into nothing. You couldn't tell the scraped pale lines from the piled dark ones. The two-soil trick that makes the figure live in raking light just dies at noon from a bouncing camera. We landed it before it died of pride.

"We could test the build," Ezra said, mostly to needle me, because he knew what would happen. "Lay our own line. See how hard it is."

We'd done it before, at other sites — it's part of the work, the honest part. You don't get to say *I can't believe ancient people made this* until you've tried to make a tiny one yourself.

So in a patch of disturbed ground well off the protected slope, with a tape measure and string and two of us and a third calling the geometry, we scraped a line. A simple straight line, ten metres, just the *extractive* technique — pull the dark crust off, show the light. It took an hour and our hands were ruined and the line was crooked where the crust didn't want to come and over-deep where it came too easy, and it read, frankly, like a drunk had keyed a car.

Then the wind got up at four, the way Mara's notes said it would, and by the time we'd packed the truck you could already see ours blurring at the edges, dark grit blowing back into the pale, the crust beginning, slowly, to heal our scratch shut.

Ours would be gone in a day. The Giant has stood for six hundred years and more.

"Right," said Tana on the radio, who'd been watching our line die on the feed. "So they made a flawless hundred-and-nineteen-metre man, by hand, on a slope, soil-perfect, readable for centuries, with no scaffold and no aerial view to check their work — and you three just produced *that*." A pause. "And the ministry wants to put up a railing so nobody touches it. Touches *what*, exactly. The bit you can't replicate or the bit you can't explain?"

Nobody answered her. But I looked at the crown of rays again.

There was someone watching us.

He'd been there a while, I think — that was the thing, he hadn't arrived, he'd simply resolved out of the pampa the way the figure had, a man on the far side of the cable line where the old track ran on past the gate. Not the consortium. No lanyard, no logo. An older man in a dust-coloured jacket with a herder's economy of movement, standing easy in the wind, looking not at us and not at the gate but along the slope of the hill, his head tipped at an angle I clocked instantly because it was the *wrong* angle, the angle that didn't match where any of us were standing or where the consortium had cleared their viewing point.

He was looking at the Giant from the line of the old caravan path.

Jakobus saw him too. Jakobus sees everyone — he'd been quiet by the truck this whole time, the fixer, doing the thing he does where he stands a half-step back and lets the place fill the silence. He didn't go over. That's not how Jakobus works; he doesn't approach the local like a prize. He just shifted his weight and said, low, to me, "He's reading it."

"I can see that."

"You can see *that* he's reading it." A dry weather-cracked half-smile. "You can't see *what*."

And he was right, which is the part I have to keep relearning. I can read a route across a continent. I can hold six languages and the grammar of a road. But the man on the path knew something about the angle of his own head that I had no access to — knew where to stand, which I hadn't found, and I'd been *looking* for where to stand all afternoon. He'd been given it. By a father, a route, a moon. Not by a placard.

I lifted a hand. Not a wave. A *we see you*. He held my eye across the cable for a long second, unhurried, and didn't come closer, and didn't look away, and then he turned his head back to the hill at that careful wrong-right angle, finished with us for now.

The consortium guard came out of his hut and called something polite about closing the access road at dusk.

So that's where they had us. The figure was real, the deity reading was good and sincere and might well be true, the meaning was about to get printed and railed off, and the one person who could actually tell us how the Giant *worked* — not what it meant, how it *worked*, where you stood, when, and why the rays pointed where they pointed — was on the wrong side of a fence we weren't allowed through, and he hadn't decided yet whether we were worth a word.

Ezra finally raised the camera. One frame, of the banners snapping over the closed path, the icon of the little ray-crowned head reduced to a logo, and behind it, up the slope, the actual head, hundred-and-nineteen metres of it, crown of rays catching the last raking light and coming alive for exactly the minutes the consortium's viewing point would never let you see.

He lowered the camera again without checking the shot.

"They're going to tell everyone what it means," he said, "before they've let anyone ask what it's for."

The wind worked at our dead little line in the dirt, and closed it.

Chapter 2 — The Official Story: Gods and Camels

The town of Huara has one café with a working generator, and at nine in the morning it smelled of instant coffee and diesel and the particular sweetness of a place that has not seen rain in long enough to forget what it would do to the dust. We had taken the corner table, the one under the window, because the window faced the pampa and because Mara cannot sit with her back to a room. The laptop ran hot. The screen showed a man one hundred and nineteen metres tall, lying on a hill, looking at the sky.

“So everyone agrees,” I said, scrolling. “Almost everyone agrees.”

“That’s the suspicious part,” said Theo, who was eating the foam off his coffee with a spoon, methodically, the way he did everything. “When everyone agrees, it’s because the question got boring before it got answered.”

I read it out anyway, because reading it out is how I find the edges. The Atacama Giant — *El Gigante de Atacama, Atacama Cumunu* in some of the older signage — sits on the western face of Cerro Unitas, a low isolated hill in the driest non-polar desert on this earth. Largest known prehistoric anthropomorphic geoglyph anywhere. Attributed to regional Andean peoples, somewhere between AD 1000 and 1400. Made two ways at once: scraping the dark desert varnish off to show the pale subsoil beneath, and piling darker stones on lighter ground. A negative and a positive in the same body. Built on a slope so it would read from below, from far off, from the flat.

“A deity,” I said. “Or a shaman. Or an authority figure. A representation of power, the literature says. The crown of rays is a headdress,

a halo, a sign of status. Cosmological. Ritual.”

“That covers everything,” Theo said. “Deity, shaman, or boss. That’s just three words for *someone important we can’t name*.”

“It’s fair, though.” This was the LENS, who had been quiet by the window with the long lens capped on her knee, not shooting, watching the light come up grey-gold over the flat. She didn’t turn her head. “It’s an honest fence. They’re saying: we know it’s a person, we know people made it, we don’t know which person or why. That’s not lazy. That’s a museum being careful.”

She was right and I hated it a little, the way you hate a true thing that closes a door you wanted open. The official story was not stupid. That is the part nobody tells you about official stories. They are usually built by people who walked the ground, who measured the cut, who counted the stones, and who declined — out of discipline, out of respect — to make up the part they didn’t know. The deity reading isn’t a failure of imagination. It’s a refusal to invent.

I pulled up the second layer. The infrastructure layer, the one the tourist boards mention less because it does not photograph as well as a god.

“There are about five thousand of these in the Atacama,” I said. “Geoglyphs. Figures, llamas, men, abstract shapes. And a huge number of them sit along the caravan routes. The llama trains came down out of the highlands, down to the coast and back, carrying salt and fish and ore and dried things, for centuries. And the glyphs cluster on the roads. Waymarks. Signposts. *You are on the path. The water is this way. Keep going.*”

Theo set the spoon down. This was a thing he could hold. “So the Giant isn’t a portrait. It’s a road sign.”

“The big ones might be both,” I said. “A god you can also navigate by. That’s not a contradiction. That’s just — efficient.” I thought of motorway saints, of the way a lighthouse is a building and a prayer at the same time. “The point everyone makes is the placement. He’s on the west face. He’s enormous. You can see him from a long way out on the pampa, which is where you’d be if you were walking the route. He’s positioned to be read by someone moving through the land.”

“Read by whom,” said the LENS, still to the window.

“Caravan drivers. Herders. People who needed to know where they were in a country that has no rivers and no trees and almost no rain. People navigating by memory and sky and the shape of hills.”

She nodded, slowly, and I knew she was framing him in her head the way she frames everything, not who he is but who is looking at him. That’s her wiring and mine in a handshake: I read the route, she reads the gaze. Between us we get a thing in stereo. Theo gives us the structure underneath — he had already, I could tell, started counting rays in his head, lining the figure up against a grid only he could see, because asymmetry hurts him and a hundred-and-nineteen-metre body with an uneven crown would not let him rest.

Across the café, by the door, our wayfinder drank his coffee and said nothing.

I should say his name. He’d given it the way you hand someone a tool you expect them to put down wrong — Aymara on his mother’s side, a long lineage in the *quebradas* north of here, a man who had spent forty years moving animals and people across ground that kills the unprepared in an afternoon. The consortium’s access papers had his signature on a line that said *cultural advisor*, which made his mouth do something when he saw it, and not a smile. He had agreed to take us up to the hill. He had not agreed to tell us what it was.

He listened to me read the official story the way a builder listens to a tourist describe a house. Patient. A little amused. Waiting for the part where you mention the load-bearing wall and get it wrong.

“It says here,” I went on, half to him now, the way you do when you want a reaction you’ve no right to demand, “that the rays from the head may have a calendrical aspect. There’s a peer-reviewed paper. The radiating lines could mark — could relate to — seasonal positions. Lunar, maybe.” I was being careful. I had read Briones. I was not going to overstate Briones, not in front of a man who could walk to the thing and stand on it. “But the standard interpretation stays with deity, shaman, status. The almanac idea is — out at the edge. Unproven.”

He set down his cup. The café went a fraction quieter, the way rooms

do around a person who has decided to use their voice and not before.

"You read all that off the screen," he said. Not a question.

"Yes."

"And the screen got it from a book, and the book got it from someone who came up the hill with a tape measure and went home before the moon."

The LENS lowered the lens to her knee very gently, which is what she does instead of laughing.

"Probably," I said.

"It's not wrong," he said, and that surprised me more than a contradiction would have. "A figure of someone important. A mark on the road. All true. People up here will tell you all of that. It's just—" He looked out the window, past us, to the flat where the hill sat folded into the haze, too far to make out the figure yet, only the shape of the rise. "It's like saying a knife is a piece of metal with an edge. True. Doesn't tell you what it's *for*. Doesn't tell you that you hold it this way and not that way, or the man who made it knew your grandmother, or that it cuts one thing well and another thing badly, and you'd learn which by ruining the wrong thing first."

He picked his cup back up. That was the whole speech. He went back to being a man drinking coffee.

I wanted to ask: so *what's it for*. I had the question half-formed and warm in my mouth, the way it always is, the way it has been since I was a child taking clocks apart to find the part that decided the time. I am very good at the question. I am not always good at the silence afterward, the long courteous silence where the other person decides whether you've earned the answer. I closed my mouth on it. Theo, who clocks these things in me faster than I do, slid his coffee an inch toward my hand, which is his way of saying *not yet*.

So we went the other direction. We tried to make one.

This is the part the books never include, and it's the part I trust most, because nothing teaches you respect like failing at the easy thing.

Out past the edge of town there's a flat with no glyphs on it, nobody's heritage, just hardpan and gravel and the wind that comes off the Pacific every afternoon at the same hour, dependable as a bell. We brought stakes and string and a drone and a sense of ourselves.

We were going to make a llama. A small one. Thirty metres, a child's drawing scaled up, scraped clear with the side of a boot and a rake. We had the plan on a tablet. We had Theo, who can hold a figure in his head and walk a true line across open ground better than the drone, which kept fighting the wind and reporting that it was sad about it.

We laid out the spine. We laid out the legs. From the ground it looked like a llama if you loved it. We sent the drone up to look down, which is the only place a geoglyph is ever truly itself, and the screen showed us a wobbling, drunken, hopeful animal with one leg longer than the others and a back that sagged in the middle like a hammock.

"It's the parallax," Theo said, not defensively, just naming the enemy. "You can't see the proportion from inside it. You only see it from above, and you can't *work* from above. They had no above." He stood in the middle of our terrible llama and turned in a slow circle. "They built a hundred-and-nineteen-metre man, in correct proportion, on a *slope*, to be read from a particular distance and angle — and they did it from inside it, walking, without ever once standing where it would finally be seen from." He said it the way some people say a prayer. "That's not art. That's surveying. That's holding a thing in your head you can never check until it's done."

The wind came up at four, on schedule. By the time we'd packed the stakes our llama was already going soft at the edges, the scraped lines silting back over, the dark stones we'd laid for its eye scattering to look like every other stone. By morning it would be gone. A day. We had spent four hours and a day's patience and the desert took it back in an evening, no malice, just housekeeping.

The Giant has been up there, sharp, readable, *correct*, for something like seven hundred years.

I looked at our smudge dissolving in the orange light and felt the gap open under me like a step that isn't there. Not the romantic gap, the *who were they* gap. The mechanical one. The how-did-the-hand-not-shake one. The official story says *deity*, *shaman*, *marker* and all of that is true and none of it touches the thing we'd just proven by

failing: that to do this, exactly this, at this size, with this accuracy, on a slope, for the angle of an eye standing a kilometre away on a road — someone held a geometry in their head that we, with a tablet and a drone and four educated brains, could not hold for thirty metres in four hours.

The wayfinder watched us pack. He hadn't helped. He hadn't needed to.

"You wanted to know if it was hard," he said, when we passed him at the truck.

"Yes."

"Now you know it was hard. That's the first true thing you've learned today." He opened the door. "Tomorrow I'll show you where to stand."

That night, in the room with the generator ticking and the cold coming down off the pampa the way it does the instant the sun quits, I laid it out for the others the way I lay out everything — in routes. What we knew. What was agreed. Where the agreement went thin.

"Here's how we do this," I said. "We play it absolutely straight. Deity, shaman, authority figure — we give it full weight, no smirk. Caravan marker, road sign, infrastructure of the road — we give that full weight too, because it's probably the truest part and the least romantic. We don't reach. We don't say *aliens*." Theo made a small noise of contempt at the word, the rays-as-antennae crowd being, to him, a personal insult to the people who actually carried the stones. "We don't sneer at the people who say it, either. We just don't go there."

"And then?" said the LENS. She had the lens capped. She'd taken nothing today. Some days she doesn't, and on those days I've learned not to ask why, only to notice that she sees more on the days the camera stays shut.

"And then we look for the one hole," I said. "The one real, checkable, published thing the tidy story never closed. There's a paper. There's a man named Briones who looked at those rays and didn't think *halo*. He thought *instrument*. He thought maybe the crown points where the moon sets at the turn of the season, in a desert where the whole of life hangs on knowing when the rain — the once-a-decade, miracle,

everything rain — might come.”

“Might,” said the LENS.

“Might. Unproven. Out at the edge of respectable. We don’t close it.” I thought of the wayfinder’s knife, the cup set down, *that’s the first true thing you’ve learned today*. “We’re not here to solve him. We just want to find out if the moon’s in his head, and then go stand where the man on the road stood, and look up, and let the people who never stopped looking up have the last word.”

Outside, the pampa held the Giant in the dark, a hundred and nineteen metres of someone, lying on a hill where he had been laid down to be seen, waiting, the way he had waited through every government and every grant application, for a particular moon to come around and tell us whether his crown was decoration or a finger pointing at the only thing that mattered.

The wayfinder knew which. He just hadn’t decided whether we’d earned it.

Tomorrow he would show us where to stand.

Chapter 3 — The Potato: Drawing the Impossible

The plan was good. That was the trouble.

We'd talked it through in the truck the night before, four of us crammed around a tablet while the pampa went black outside and the cold came up off the ground like something rising from a well. The plan had spreadsheets. The plan had a flight path plotted in software that cost more than the truck. We were not going to recreate the Atacama Giant — nobody says that out loud, not even Tomas, and Tomas will say almost anything — but we were going to draw a figure. A small one. A hundred metres of nothing, a stick man, just to feel the work in our hands. To learn the verb.

You understand a sentence by trying to write one. That's the whole method. You don't read a language by staring at it; you read it by botching it, by watching your mouth make the wrong shape and feeling where the right shape lives. I've done it with forty tongues. I figured a geoglyph was a tongue.

I figured wrong, which is the chapter.

Here is the official story, and I want it on the table clean, because it's a good story and it's probably true.

The Atacama Giant is 119 metres tall. It is the largest known pre-historic anthropomorphic geoglyph on the planet, and it stands — *stands* is the word your eye insists on, though it does nothing of the kind — on the western flank of Cerro Unitas, a low brown hill in the driest non-polar desert on Earth. Somebody made it between roughly

AD 1000 and 1400. They made it two ways at once: scraping back the dark, oxidised surface to expose the pale ground beneath, and piling darker stones to draw the lines that needed to be dark. Extractive and additive in the same body. A figure built out of removal and addition, like a sentence built of what you say and what you leave out.

The scholars call it a deity, or a shaman, or an authority figure. It is one of around five thousand geoglyphs scattered across this desert, and a great many of them sit along the old llama-caravan routes like road signs nobody has driven past in six hundred years. The conservative read — the read I respect, the read with the least to prove — is that these are infrastructure. Waymarks. The Giant is just the biggest one, parked on a hill for the simple reason that a hill is visible from a long way off.

That's the easy answer. The Giant is a sign.

Signs are easy. We make them all the time.

So we set out to make one.

We picked our patch at first light, on flat ground a kilometre from the hill where we couldn't possibly do harm — bare pampa, the kind that looks like it's been swept, because in a sense it has, by ten thousand years of wind with nothing to stop it. Mariela ran the drone. The drone was beautiful. It rose off Tomas's outstretched palm with a noise like a wasp the size of a dinner plate and climbed to fifty metres, and the tablet bloomed with a god's-eye view of us: four small specks and a truck, casting long blue shadows across a brown that had no name in the box of crayons.

"Wind's at nine," Mariela said. Mariela is our systems thinker, and when she talks about the world she talks about it in numbers first and meaning second, which is exactly backwards from me and exactly why we work. "Gusting fourteen. She's fighting me."

The fish — I should explain the fish. The fish is a rubber bass, the singing kind, that Tomas zip-tied to the roll bar in Calama as a joke and now will not remove because, he says, it's load-bearing morale. It hangs there. Occasionally Tomas presses its belly and it heckles.

"Engineers," the fish said, in its flat motel voice, "have always wanted

to fly.”

“Nobody asked you,” Tomas said, and pressed it again, and it played four bars of a song about a river.

The figure we’d designed was a hundred metres of stick man — head, two arms, two legs, the universal child’s-drawing of a person, the thing your hand knows before your mind does. We’d surveyed it into the tablet. GPS stakes at the joints. A bright nylon line strung between them to mark the spine and limbs, so we could walk the lines and scrape. We had pickaxes. We had, God help us, knee pads.

Briones — Luis Briones, the man who looked at the Giant’s crown of rays in *Antiquity* in 2006 and asked the dangerous question, the one we’d carry north with us like a coal in a tin — Briones did not have knee pads. Whoever drew the Giant did not have knee pads, or a drone, or stakes, or nylon, or a truck, or a tablet, or a fish.

They had the desert and their hands and a reason.

We had everything else, and we were about to find out it wasn’t enough.

The scraping went fine for the first hour, which is how the desert gets you.

You drag the pick and the dark crust comes away in flakes and underneath is this stunning, shocking paleness, almost pink, the colour of the inside of a wrist. The line you make is *real* and it is *bright* and you stand up to ease your back and there it is — a true mark in the ground, and for one hour you are an artist, you are an engineer, you are the maker of signs, and the pampa lies open in front of you like a page.

Then I made the mistake of letting the drone up to look.

From fifty metres, my arm was not where I thought it was. It bent. Not wildly — by maybe two degrees over its length — but the figure has no margin for two degrees, because a figure is a face and a face is the most demanding thing the human eye can read. We see a crooked smile from across a room. Mariela’s voice came thin over the wind: “Your right arm’s drifting. You’re following the slope.”

I hadn't felt a slope. There wasn't one, to my body. But the ground had a tilt of less than a degree, invisible to a standing person, and my eye had quietly *corrected* to it, had drawn the line parallel to a horizon that was itself askew, and now my stick man had a wonky shoulder and looked like he'd been shrugging for a thousand years.

"I can fix it," I said.

"You can't unfix it," Mariela said, which is the truer sentence. You cannot un-scrape. There is no eraser. Every line is permanent and every line is therefore a decision you make before you can possibly see whether it's right, because to see whether it's right you have to stand a hundred metres up, and you can't, you're a person, you're down here in it with a pick and a degree of error you cannot feel.

The Giant's maker solved this. We do not entirely know how. That's part of what's coming.

We solved it by arguing.

We argued for two hours about the head.

A stick figure's head is a circle, and a circle is the cruelest shape there is, because the eye that forgives a wobbly line will *not* forgive a lumpy circle, it sees the lump instantly, the lump is all it sees. We'd planned to scribe it with the nylon line pinned at the centre, a compass. The wind took the line. Not metaphorically — the wind picked the nylon up off the ground and held it in a long, taut, singing curve like a bowstring, and our perfect circle came out an egg, a sad egg, the egg of a bird that had given up.

Tomas, who is the most stubborn person I have ever loved, got down and scribed it by hand, on his knees, dragging his heel as a radius, around and around, sighting on a stake. It took him forty minutes. It was a beautiful circle. From the ground.

The drone went up.

"It's good," Mariela said, surprised.

"It's *good*?" Tomas said.

"It's —" She turned the tablet. The light had moved. That was the thing none of us had factored, the thing the spreadsheet had no col-

umn for: the sun had swung two hours west, and the new light raked low across our morning's work and lit every scrape we'd made earlier as a *shadow*, so that lines we'd thought were clean were suddenly fuzzed with the texture of a hundred individual pick-strokes, and the whole figure shimmered like a thing seen through water. Our man had a five-o'clock shadow over his entire body.

The Giant does not do this. The Giant's lines are clean at every hour because the additive lines — the piled dark stone — are *built up*, three-dimensional, and they hold their darkness whatever the sun does, while the scraped pale ground stays pale. They didn't just draw. They engineered for the light. They knew the sun would betray a scratch and they built lines that the sun couldn't lie about.

We had drawn. They had built. That's the gap. That is the whole, entire gap, and it is two thousand years wide and it does not close because you arrive with a drone.

Sofia found us at the head.

I should have said Sofia is the wayfinder, but she'd have told you wayfinding isn't a job, it's just paying attention, and that you can't put it on a card. She'd come out on the old road in a pickup older than the fish, and she stood at the edge of our patch with her hands in her jacket pockets and her face doing the specific Atacama thing, the thing the light does to people who've spent their lives in it, where the squint and the smile become the same expression and you genuinely cannot tell whether they're laughing at you. She'd been watching, I think, for a while. She has the gift of being somewhere before you notice her arriving.

"You're making a person," she said.

"We're *trying*," Tomas said, with the defeat of a man on his knees beside an egg.

She looked at the drone feed over Mariela's shoulder. She looked at our man, our shrugging, shadow-furred, egg-headed man, lying in the dirt the way a chalk outline lies in the dirt. And she did the thing, the squint-smile, and she didn't say anything cruel, which was worse.

"How big," she asked, "is it."

“A hundred metres,” Mariela said.

“And how big,” Sofia said, and she tipped her chin a kilometre east, to the hill, to the figure that has lain on that slope through six hundred turns of the planet around the sun and not lost a shoulder, “is he.”

“A hundred and nineteen.”

“Nineteen more,” Sofia said, “and *he* doesn’t shrug.” And then she did laugh, openly, not unkindly, the laugh of someone who has watched a great many clever people arrive with a great deal of equipment to discover something her grandmother could have told them over breakfast. “You drew him from up there.” She nodded at the drone. “He wasn’t drawn from up there. Nobody could go up there. He was drawn from *down here* —” she pressed her boot into the pampa — by people who knew where they were standing without having to look.”

“That’s the part I can’t do,” I said, and it cost me something to say it. “I can’t feel the slope. My eye fixes it.”

“Your eye fixes it,” she agreed, “because your eye is solving a problem you don’t have. You have a stake and a screen. They had a *route*.” She said the word like it was the answer to everything, which, it would turn out, it nearly was. “They walked these lines before they ever drew them. The path was already in the ground, in the body. They weren’t making a picture. They were marking a thing they already knew the shape of by heart. You can’t draw the route. You haven’t walked it.”

I am the route person. I am the one whose wiring reads paths the way other people read faces, the one who never had to be taught a city, who walks into a station in a language I can’t speak and knows which way is out by the slope of the floor and the smell of the wind through the tunnel. And a woman with her hands in her pockets had just told me, correctly, that I had drawn a sign for a place I’d never travelled, and that this was exactly why it had no face.

She didn’t say it to wound. She said it the way you’d point out that you’d buttoned your shirt wrong. Then she got back in the truck and said she’d come find us at the hill when the moon was right, and left us a thermos, and drove off into the white.

We came back the next morning to photograph our work in the good early light, the kind, low light, the light that loves everything.

There was no work.

I want to be precise, because precision is the only honest grief. The figure was not gone. You could find it if you knew it had been there — a faint paler shadow, a suggestion, the ghost of a person who'd lain down in the night and then thought better of it. The wind had come up after dark, the ordinary nightly wind off the cooling pampa, fourteen, sixteen, nothing the desert would even mention, and it had taken our scrapes and *filled* them. Carried fine dark dust off the high ground and laid it down soft as a sheet over our pale lines, and softened the egg, and erased the shoulder, and the whole desperate day of pickaxe and knee pad and argument and drone had lasted exactly one night, less than the life of a moth.

Mariela ran the numbers without being asked. "We scraped maybe two centimetres deep," she said. "Average." She was quiet a second. "The Giant's lines are built and scraped both, on a slope angled away from the prevailing wind, on ground with a salt content that —" She stopped. "He's not just bigger. He's *engineered to survive the thing that just killed ours*. In a day. We lost it in a day."

The fish, back on the roll bar, said nothing, because nobody pressed it. Even Tomas left it alone.

I stood where the head had been. There was the very faintest paleness underfoot, a wrist-coloured ghost. Somewhere east a hundred and nineteen metres of person lay on a hill and watched the sun come up over it for the eight-hundredth-thousandth time, untroubled, because somebody who walked these routes with their reasons in their body had known something we'd arrived with a truck full of gear and failed, in a day, to learn.

The easy answer is that it's a sign. Anybody can make a sign.

We had everything. We made a smudge.

So the question turned over, the way it does, and showed its other face: not *how did they draw it*. That's the potato, and the potato is real, and you can feel it in your knees. The question Sofia had left in the thermos steam, the one waiting for us up the hill where the moon was getting right, was simpler and much, much worse.

What did they already know the shape of by heart?

Chapter 4 — The Hole: The Rays and the Moon

The thing about a 119-metre man is that you cannot photograph him from your own height. You can stand at his feet — and we did, in the blue hour before the wind came up — and look along the run of him up the hillside, and he refuses to assemble. From the ground the Giant is a topographic rumour: a darker patch here, a paler shoulder there, a leg that goes on too long because the slope eats perspective. He is built to be read from somewhere you are not standing.

Mira found the somewhere first. She always does.

“You’re in his armpit,” she said, not unkindly, from forty metres downslope and to the left. “Come stand in mine.”

I went and stood in hers. And there he was — the whole of him, the rectangular head, the stepped torso, the legs apart in that pose every reconstruction calls *authority figure* and every five-year-old calls *robot* — and the rays.

Four off one side of the head. A spray of them. Antennae, if you’ve been online too long; a crown, if you read the museum placard; a headdress, if you’ve read the slightly better placard. They radiate from the skull at angles that look, from Mira’s armpit, deliberate to the point of fussiness. Somebody cared about those angles. Somebody walked this hillside a thousand years back and decided the rays went *there*, and not three metres over, and the wind has been trying to vote on the matter ever since and losing.

“Briones counted them,” Mira said. She had the *Antiquity* paper printed and folded into eighths in her jacket, soft at the creases from

being read in the truck. Mira is our systems person — autistic, allergic to the word *intuition*, fond of the word *grid*. She reads a landscape the way other people read a spreadsheet that's lying to them. "Two thousand six. He looked at the rays as a set of azimuths. As bearings."

"Bearings to what."

"That's the whole paper." She handed it to me. "Bearings to where the moon sets. At the right time of year."

Let me give you the official story, straight, because it deserves better than the gloss.

The Atacama is the driest non-polar desert on Earth. Some weather stations here have measurement records and no rain in them — not *little* rain, *no* rain, a column of zeroes going back further than the instrument's warranty. People lived here anyway. Caravans of llamas moved salt and maize and dried fish and copper through it along routes you can still see scratched into the pampa: faint parallel grooves, hundreds of metres of them, the negative of a thousand years of hooves and feet.

And along those routes, the people who walked them left signs. Something like five thousand geoglyphs across the Atacama — llamas, men, birds, suns, abstract grids — and a great many of them sit exactly where a caravan would want a landmark. A turn. A water source. A pass. They are not, mostly, decoration. They are infrastructure. They are the desert's signage, painted by scraping the dark desert varnish off the pale ground beneath, or by piling dark stones onto light, and they have lasted because here nothing washes anything away.

The Giant at Cerro Unitas is the king of them. Hundred and nineteen metres. Largest prehistoric human figure known on the planet. Built by Andean cultures sometime around AD 1000 to 1400 — the date is a span, not a point, because nobody scratched the year into his shoulder. The standard reading: a deity, a shaman, a lord. A figure of authority presiding over the route, the way a saint presides over a crossroads. That reading is sober, sourced, and almost certainly partly true.

Almost.

The LENS came back from the ridge with his camera down at his thigh, which is how you know he's been thinking instead of shooting.

"I can't get him," he said. "Not the whole of him with the rays sharp. I get the body or I get the rays. There's no station where both come good at once."

"There's Mira's armpit."

"For your eye. Not for a lens at this focal length without going up in the —" He tipped his head at the drone case, which we did not open, because the consortium's access filing had a no-fly clause in it and we were, that week, being scrupulously legal in a way that cost us things. "The geometry's not built for a camera. It's built for a person standing in a particular place."

"Which place."

He didn't answer, because Cira had come up the path.

Cira is the wayfinder. Aymara on her mother's side, and the reason we had permission to be on the hill at all was that she had decided, provisionally, that we were not the consortium and might not become it. She wore a wind-cracked jacket and the particular stillness of someone who has spent a lifetime in places where moving wrong costs you. She had watched us for two days the way you'd watch a dog you hadn't decided about yet.

"You found the standing place," she said to Mira. Not a question.

"His left armpit. About forty metres down."

"That's a standing place." Cira let that sit. Then, to me, because I'd been pacing the ray-angles off with a compass app like a tourist: "Put the phone away. It's lying to you about the slope."

It was. The phone's compass doesn't know the hillside tilts the rays toward you; it gives you flat azimuths for a thing that lives on a tilt. Briones's whole method had to correct for that — for the fact that a

ray painted on a 20-degree slope and read from below points somewhere the flat math won't tell you. Mira had a column of corrected figures. They didn't match my phone. Of course they didn't.

Cira watched me put the phone away, which I think was the test.

Here is the hole, and I want to set it down with cold hands, because it is the kind of thing that gets oversold the instant you stop being careful.

In 2006, in the journal *Antiquity* — peer-reviewed, the real thing, footnotes and all — Luis Briones published a study of the Atacama geoglyphs that included a proposal about the Giant. The rays from the head, he suggested, might not be only a crown or only an antenna of the spirit. Read as bearings, certain of them point toward where the moon sets at particular phases — and the moon's setting position swings north and south across the year and across its longer cycle, and if you knew how to read that swing, you would know where you were in the year. You would know, in a land with no rain to warn you and no green to read, when the brief possible season of water was near.

A lunar gnomon. A calendar built into a god's head. The rays as the shadow-stick of a clock whose hand is the moon, and whose face is the desert horizon.

That is the hypothesis. Published. Citable. Real.

It is also unproven. Briones proposed it; the field did not rise up and confirm it. The alignments are suggestive, not nailed; with enough rays and enough lunar setting positions across a complex cycle, a careful skeptic will tell you — correctly — that you can find a match for almost anything if you go looking, and that the burden is on the claimant. Nobody has stood on that hill across a full set of seasons with the instruments and the patience to either close it or kill it. It floats. It has floated for nearly twenty years, peer-reviewed and unresolved, which is a strange and honest place for a fact to live.

"So is it true?" the LENS asked Mira. He asks the cleanest questions of any of us.

"It's *checkable*," Mira said. "That's not the same thing. Checkable

means somebody could go up there with a theodolite and a lunar ephemeris and stand here for fourteen months and find out. Nobody has. So it sits in the paper being possible.” She refolded the printout to its eighths. “I hate it. It’s my favourite kind of fact.”

The fish, who travels with us in spirit and in the form of a sticker on the drone case, would like to point out that *a god whose haircut is also a clock* is exactly the sort of claim that ought to set off every alarm in your house, and that the phrase *if you know how to read the swing* is doing an Olympic amount of work, and that the moon sets in a *lot* of places over its eighteen-year wander, and that pointing four rays at the sky and finding the moon is approximately as hard as pointing four fingers at a beach and finding sand.

Noted. The fish is not wrong. The fish is also not the one who built a hundred-and-nineteen-metre man on a hillside positioned for one viewing angle and then bothered to get the ray-angles *fussy*.

Both things sit in the room. That’s the job.

We tried, the day before, to make our own line. This is the part of the work I least like to write down.

The cost — the potato, as Jakobus calls it, the moment the easy story turns out to be a quiet monster of difficulty — had come the previous afternoon, downslope on a patch of pampa Cira said we could disturb because nothing was there. We laid out a figure. Just a man. Forty metres, a tenth of the Giant. We had survey pegs, a measuring wheel, a line-laser, two phones, and four people who’d planned it on graph paper in the truck.

We scraped the dark crust off in the shape of a man.

From the ground it looked like a man. From Mira’s standing place, forty metres back, it looked like a drunk had described a man to another drunk. The legs splayed wrong. One arm was longer because the slope had eaten our judgement exactly the way it eats the phone’s compass. We hadn’t corrected for the tilt. The Giant’s makers had. That’s not mysticism; that’s craft, accumulated, taught, the difference between a person who walks the hill every season and a person who

flew in with a line-laser.

And in the morning the wind had been at it. Our man had a smeared edge already, the scraped crust filling back with blown grit. Give it a week. Give it the season. Gone.

The Giant has been up there a thousand years, his ray-angles still fussy, because somebody knew the wind and built against it, and because the Atacama, having no rain, has no eraser. We made a smear. They made a clock. Maybe a clock. The gap between our smear and their possible-clock is the gap this whole book lives in.

Cira waited until the light went long and the rays' shadows lengthened on the hillside before she walked us down to the caravan path.

You can feel the old route under your boots before you see it — the ground packed harder, the parallel grooves a darker line in the raking light. People walked here for centuries. She put us on it, single file, facing the way a caravan coming up from the coast would face, and she walked us north until she stopped.

"Here," she said. "Now look back up."

From the caravan path — not from Mira's armpit, not from the LENS's ridge, from the *path*, the place a tired walker with salt to sell would actually stand — the Giant came up over the slope, and the rays stood off his head against the open western sky. The sky where the moon would set.

"This is the place to read him," Cira said. "Not the place for your camera. The place for a person who has walked four days and needs to know how long until the water comes." She didn't point at any one ray. She didn't say *that one marks the moon*. She let us stand there and feel the line of sight do its own work — head, rays, horizon, the seam where they all meet — and she watched our faces instead of the hill.

"Briones says the rays mark the moon," I tried.

"Briones wrote a paper," Cira said. "I'm showing you the path. From the path, the rays are where the sky is. You can decide what that means." A pause that had a smile somewhere far back inside it. "Or

you can leave it open. That's allowed too. We've left it open a long time. It hasn't hurt anyone."

So here is where the chapter has to end, and it ends on a thing standing up rather than lying down.

The official story is true as far as it goes: a deity, a lord, a route-marker for the caravans, a sober and well-sourced reading that explains the placement and most of the figure. It explains the *where*. It does not, quite, explain the rays — why they are angled with such care, why they spray off only the one side, why they stand precisely against the western horizon when you read them from the path a real traveller used.

And the one extra thing — the lunar reading, peer-reviewed and twenty years unconfirmed — the official story doesn't close. It can't. Nobody has gone up that hill with the moon and the instruments and the seasons and made it surrender. The gap is real, and citable, and it is shaped exactly like a question someone declined to answer.

Cira walked back up the path ahead of us, into the last of the light, and did not look back to see whether we'd understood. It wasn't ours to understand. It was hers to show, and ours to carry north — to a coast where a different sign waits, cut deeper, undated, aimed not at the moon but at the sea.

The fish, for the record, is still muttering about the haircut.

I am still standing in the wind, looking at the rays against the horizon, deciding nothing.

Chapter 5 — The Wink: Whose Calendar?

The argument started, as our arguments usually do, with Priya laying her tablet flat on a folding table and saying, very quietly, “Look. Just look at it.”

We looked.

She’d pulled up Briones — Luis Briones, *Antiquity*, 2006, the paper everyone cites and almost nobody reads to the end. On her screen the Giant lay across the hillside in greyscale, 119 metres of him, head crowned with those rays that have launched a thousand YouTube thumbnails. Antennae. Halo. Headdress. Take your pick. Priya had overlaid a set of azimuth lines fanning out from the figure’s head like spokes from a hub.

“The rays aren’t symmetrical,” she said. “People say crown, they mean decoration, they mean it’s pretty and balanced and means *king* or *god*. It isn’t balanced. The angles are specific. And some of them,” she tapped two of the longer ones, “fall close to lunar setting positions. Major standstill. The moon’s most extreme set on the northwest horizon, the place it only reaches every eighteen and a half years.”

Mara, who had been photographing the dust on the table because the dust on the table was doing something with the light, lowered the camera a centimetre. “Close to,” she said.

“Close to,” Priya agreed.

“How close?”

“That’s the whole problem.”

I want to be fair to the official story here, because it is a good story and a true one as far as it goes, and the people who hold it are not fools. The Atacama desert holds something like five thousand geoglyphs. Most of them line the old caravan corridors — figures of llamas, of men with staffs, of geometric blocks — and they sit exactly where you'd put a sign if you were running camelids loaded with salt and maize and dried fish across a hundred and fifty kilometres of nothing. They are infrastructure. Read them that way and they stop being mysterious and start being *sensible*, which is a different and better kind of wonderful.

The Giant fits that frame. He's on a hill, Cerro Unitas, alone on the pampa, visible from a long way off. He's huge so you can see him. He's a person — a deity, a shaman, an authority figure, the textbooks say, and they're probably right — because a person is a thing other people recognise across distance and culture and a thousand years. *Here. This place. Somebody important watches this ground.* That's a billboard. That's a good honest billboard, and it cost a community an enormous amount of labour, and they built it on a hillside on purpose so the angle would carry. Nobody needs the moon for that to be true.

"So why the rays," I said.

"Because everybody's got rays," said Tomás, our driver and, it was becoming clear, a man with opinions. He'd grown up two valleys over. "All the big ones. The shaman figures. It's a headdress. My grandmother had a headdress. It didn't track the moon."

The fish — we have a fish, a little resin thing Mara superglued to the dashboard in Antofagasta, and at some point the fish became the voice in the van that says what the rest of us are too polite to — the fish, in Mara's flat impression of it, said: *Your grandmother also wasn't a hundred and nineteen metres tall.*

Tomás laughed. He liked the fish.

But Priya wasn't laughing, and when Priya goes still over a pattern it's because the pattern has hooked her by the part of her brain that doesn't let things go. This is the thing about Priya I keep failing to explain to people who've never lived with a mind like hers. They hear *can't let it go* and they reach for the word *obsessive*, like it's a fault, like she's a dog with a bone. They have it backwards. The rest of us let things go all the time. We let things go *constantly*. That's why we

miss them. Priya doesn't have a leak. The pattern stays in the bucket until she's done with it. It is the single most useful trait I have ever worked beside and I would not trade it for a satellite.

"I keep doing the thing," she said. "Don't I."

"What thing."

"The thing where I want it to be the moon. So I'm reading the moon into it." She put her thumb over the two long rays, hiding them. "If I cover these two I've got a perfectly ordinary deity with a perfectly ordinary crown and I can go to bed."

That's the trap, and she'd named it before I could, which is why she's the lead and I just talk to people. There's a hunger in our line of work to be the one who *cracks* it. To stand under the big strange thing and say *ah, I see what you are*, and feel the click. The click is a drug. And the thing about the click is that the brain will manufacture one whether or not the lock actually turned. You line up two long rays with a moonset eighteen years out and the brain hands you a click, gift-wrapped, free of charge, *no evidence required*. Briones knew this. It's why he published a hypothesis and not a discovery. People online turned it into a discovery within a week.

We took it to Jakobus that evening, because we take everything to Jakobus eventually, and because he'd been gone all afternoon walking the lower slope with Inés and we wanted to know what they'd found.

He was sitting on the tailgate of Tomás's truck with his boots off, knocking dust out of them, and Inés was a little way off, not with us, the way she usually wasn't quite with us — close enough to hear, far enough to leave.

Inés Quispaya is the reason we're allowed to be here at all. She's an Aymara wayfinder, third generation on this pampa, and she'd agreed to walk the site with us after the consortium filed for restricted access, which I think she did less to help us than to make a point about whose pampa it was. She reads this ground the way I read a transit map and the way Priya reads a spoke diagram — as a working system, a thing in use, not a relic behind glass. She'd corrected my pronunciation of three place names and one of them I'm still getting wrong.

We laid out the argument for Jakobus. The rays. Briones. The two

long ones. The standstill moon. The trap of wanting it to be true.

Jakobus listened the way he always does, which is completely, with his whole weathered face, and when we were done he didn't answer. He looked over at Inés.

"You walked it," he said to her. "What do you make of the head?"

He does this. It took me a while to understand it wasn't shyness or some performance of humility. Jakobus reads made things for a living — *what is this for, what would you have to know to use it, where would you stand* — and he is very good, possibly the best I've met, and he will not say a word about a thing while the person who lives with it is standing right there. Not because he can't. Because it isn't his to say first. The Giant is not a puzzle he gets to solve in front of the woman whose grandmother's grandmother could have hauled stone for the crown. He handed her the moment. He always hands it over. The handing-over is the whole man.

Inés took her time.

"You want me to tell you about the moon," she said.

"We want to know if we're fooling ourselves," I said.

She came a little closer then, not all the way, and crouched and drew a line in the dust with one finger — flat, level — the horizon.

"The rain doesn't come here," she said. "You know this. Driest place there is. But sometimes it comes, far up." She pointed her chin at the cordillera, at the high snow we couldn't see from here. "And then the water comes down the quebradas, the dry rivers, and for a little while there is grazing in places that are dead the rest of the year. If you keep animals, you have to be there when it comes. Not after. Not a week late, when the green is gone and the other herds have eaten it. *There*. On time."

"So you need a calendar," said Priya.

"You need to know when," Inés said, which is not the same thing, and I watched Priya hear the difference.

"And the moon tells you when?"

Inés smiled a little, the way you smile at someone who's asking the right question in slightly the wrong shape. "The sky tells you when. My

grandfather read the sky. The stars in the morning before the rains. The animals. The plants that come up first. The wind changing. He read all of it together, and he was never wrong about the water, and he never once told me he was reading a drawing on a hill." She let that sit. "I'm not telling you the rays are not the moon. I don't know that they are not the moon. I'm telling you my people knew when the rains came without lying down under that man's feet to do it."

The fish, mercifully, kept its mouth shut.

"So Briones is wrong," Tomás said, a little triumphant.

"I didn't say that either." Inés stood, brushed her knee. "Listen. Suppose you're right." She looked at Priya. "Suppose those two long rays do point at the moon at the far edge of its turning. The big standstill. Once in eighteen years, the moon sets exactly there." She pointed northwest, into the haze where the sun had gone down an hour before. "What good is that? Eighteen years. You can't plant by something that happens once a generation. You can't move a herd by it."

Priya opened her mouth and closed it.

"Unless," Inés said, and stopped.

We all leaned in. I'm not proud of it. We leaned in like dogs at a table, and Inés saw us do it, and the corner of her mouth did something, and she decided — I watched her decide — not to feed us.

"Unless it's not a clock," she said. "Unless it's a *teaching*."

"Meaning what," I said.

"Meaning I'm not going to do your thinking for you in front of your camera." She said it without heat. Mara, to her enormous credit, had already lowered the lens — had lowered it a full minute earlier, the way she does now, the way she's learning to, when a moment turns from something to record into something to be *in*. The red light was off. I hadn't even seen her do it.

"You came here," Inés went on, "with a hypothesis from a journal and you want me to tell you it's correct so you can write that down, or tell you it's wrong so you can write *that* down. Either way you get to leave with the answer in your bag." She shook her head, slow. "The man on the hill has been there a thousand years. He'll be there when you're

gone and when the consortium that wants to fence him is gone too. He doesn't need my answer and he doesn't need yours."

Jakobus, on the tailgate, was nodding very slightly, the way he nods when someone says the thing he came here to hear someone else say.

"But the rays *are* there," Priya said. Quiet. Not arguing. Almost pleading. "The angles are real. You can measure them. That's not nothing."

"No," Inés agreed. "That's not nothing." And here, finally, she gave us something, though I didn't understand until later that it was the only thing she meant to give. "When you stand on the old caravan path — not here, not under him, but out there, where the llamas walked —" she pointed along the faint dark scar of the trail running off northwest across the pampa, the exact direction she'd pointed for the moon, "— he stands up off the hill differently. The crown opens out. From the trail he doesn't look like a drawing. He looks like he's *standing*. Watching the road." She paused. "My grandfather walked that road. He'd have seen the man stand up exactly the way I saw him stand up this afternoon, with Jakobus. The road hasn't moved. The man hasn't moved. The moon — the moon moves all the time."

She let that land.

"So which one," she said, "is the thing he was built to point at? The road that's been under your feet the whole walk, or the moon that comes back once in eighteen years?"

Nobody answered.

"That's not a question I have to answer," she said. "I'm just the one who noticed you didn't ask it."

And she walked off toward her truck, and the pampa was doing the thing it does at full dark, going from gold to nothing in the space of a few breaths, and the Giant up on Cerro Unitas was a black absence against a sky already crowded with the stars her grandfather read.

Priya stared at her tablet for a long time. The azimuth lines glowed. The two long rays sat there being two long rays, pointing at a moon that comes back once in eighteen years and a road that had never gone away.

"I want it to be the moon," she said.

“I know.”

“It might be the moon.”

“It might.”

She closed the tablet. The hillside went dark for real then, and somewhere up there 119 metres of a person stood watching a road we could no longer see, and we had measurements for everything except the only thing we'd come to find out, which was who he was built to be watched *by*, and from where, and on what night — and Inés had walked off into the dark with all of that still hers, having shown us exactly how much we didn't know and not one inch more.

The fish said nothing at all.

Tomorrow we'd drive north. There was another sign waiting, bigger than this one, cut deeper, and it pointed the other way entirely — not at the sky, not at the road, but at the empty sea.

Chapter 6 — What Is It For: Read by Walking

The thing about a map you have to walk is that it doesn't care whether you believe in it.

Rosa Mamani started before dawn, which is to say she started while the rest of us were still arguing about whether to start. She wore the same windbreaker she'd worn for three days and carried nothing — no pack, no water bottle clipped to her hip, no GPS unit blinking its little blue lie of certainty. She had a stick. She had her knees. She walked into the pampa like she was stepping off a curb she'd stepped off ten thousand times, and we scrambled after her with our four hundred euros of hydration systems sloshing.

"Path's not where you think," she said, not turning around.

I thought it was right under our feet. There was a track — a pale braid in the dark gravel, the famous caravan trace, the one that shows up in the survey photos like a vein. I'd memorised it. I'd loaded it into my head the way I load everything, the route a glowing thread I could pull from memory and lay over the real world. That's the wiring. People say it like a diagnosis; I've used it to cross cities I'd landed in an hour before. I knew where the path was.

"You're walking the photograph," Rosa said. "Not the road."

The official story, and let me give it to you straight, because it deserves straight: the Atacama Giant is a god. Or a shaman. Or a lord — an authority figure, hands at his sides, head crowned with rays, scraped and piled into a hillside at Cerro Unitas a thousand years ago and change, sometime between AD 1000 and 1400, by

the Andean peoples who moved goods and llamas through the driest non-polar desert on this planet. He is 119 metres tall. He is the largest known prehistoric depiction of a human being anywhere on Earth, and he is one of roughly five thousand figures the people here carved, scraped, and stacked across the pampa — birds, geometries, llama trains, men. The consensus, hard-won and reasonable and held by serious people who have given their lives to this ground, is that the Giant is a *symbol*. A presence. Something that meant power, or the divine, or both, to a culture watching over its routes.

I love that story. I want to be clear, because what comes next is not a sneer. The people who built the consensus walked this pampa too, with theodolites and patience and grant cycles that ran out, and they were right about almost everything. The Giant is a symbol.

He is also, Rosa was about to show us, a thing you read with your feet.

We tried, the day before, to make our own.

This is the part I'd cut from a braver edit, except that cutting it would be a lie. We had a survey-grade drone. We had Tomas — our systems thinker, who can hold a three-dimensional figure in his head and rotate it like a man turning a key in a lock, and who had spent the night before laying out a forty-metre geoglyph in software, every coordinate clean. We had stakes and string. We had a *plan*, which is the most dangerous thing an outsider can carry into a desert.

We made a man. Sort of. From the ground he looked like a man who had been described to someone over a bad phone connection. The proportions drifted; the right arm came out longer because the slope cheated us and we didn't read the cheat. Tomas stood at the bottom of our little hill and looked up at our little figure and was quiet for a long time, which from Tomas is a paragraph.

"The math is right," he said finally. "The ground isn't."

The wind took half of it overnight. Just the scraped lines — the additive parts, the piled stones, those held, but the pale extractive lines blurred at the edges like chalk in rain, except there's no rain, just air moving across the most patient surface on Earth, lifting grain by grain. By noon our man had a smudge for a face.

The Giant has had a thousand years of that wind. He still has his face.

That's the potato, and I'll say it plainly so nobody thinks the trick is hidden: the easy version is not easy. You cannot just *decide* to carve a 119-metre man on a hillside and have him be legible, symmetrical, and durable. Symmetry over a slope is a nightmare of foreshortening — the figure has to be *distorted* in construction so it reads correct from the angle people actually see it. The builders solved that. With sticks and knees and a road. We solved it with software and made a smudge.

"You measured down," Rosa said, when I told her, half-defeated. She found this very funny. "You measured down at the ground. Nobody saw it from up there. They saw it from over there." She pointed across the pampa, at nothing, at distance.

"From the path."

"From the path. Walking." She looked at me with something that wasn't unkindness but wasn't going to do my work for me either. "You make a thing for the eye that will see it. You don't have that eye yet."

So we walked to find the eye.

The LENS came with us and didn't lift the camera for the first hour, which I noticed and didn't say anything about. He'd been bad in Iquique — a market, a sudden noise, the way his shoulders went and his hands went up with the body's old instinct to put glass between himself and the world. The camera is a shield as much as a tool, and he knows it, and the knowing is the slow work of him. This morning he just walked, hands empty, watching Rosa's feet.

"She's not going straight," he said.

"No."

"She's reading something."

She was. The path Rosa walked was not the path in the photograph. It bent — out toward a low rise that the survey trace ignored, then back, then held a line I couldn't account for until the sun came up enough to throw shadow into the gravel and I saw it: the ground itself was sorted. Slightly. Darker grit here, paler there, a grain change you'd

never see from above and never see standing still, but walking it, over hours, your eye built it into a road. The pampa had a texture that was a sentence, and Rosa was reading it aloud with her body.

This is the thing my wiring is *for*, if it's for anything. Not solving. Reading movement. I fell into her rhythm without deciding to, and somewhere in the second hour the route stopped being a thread I'd memorised and became a thing I was *inside of*, the way a melody stops being notes. I could feel where it wanted to go before it went. I started to walk it right.

"Now look up," Rosa said.

I'd been so deep in the ground I'd forgotten the Giant.

He was *there*. He had arrived sometime in the last twenty minutes without my noticing, risen up the flank of Cerro Unitas, and from this point on the path — exactly this point, this stride, where the sorted gravel held a particular bend — he was not a smudge or a distortion. He was a man. Symmetrical. Crowned. Looking, it seemed, directly down the road at us, the way a face in a doorway looks at whoever's coming up the walk.

"Three steps back," Rosa said.

I stepped back and he tilted, the proportions sliding, the crown skewing.

"Forward."

Forward and he resolved, perfect, *correct*, and I understood — felt, in the legs, not the head — that the figure had been carved to be right from *here*, from this segment of the moving road, distorted on the slope precisely so the walking eye would unbend it. The Giant doesn't stand in a place. He stands in a *sightline*. He is aimed at people in motion.

Tomas, behind me, made a sound I'd describe as a small religious experience. "The distortion's the engineering," he said. "It's not error. It's correction for the angle. They built the *wrongness* in so it'd come out right." He turned in a slow circle, the figure resolving and dissolving as he moved. "It only works if you're going somewhere."

The official story is a god. I want to keep holding it, because here is where a lesser book would drop it to grab something shinier, and I won't. He may well be a god. A god you meet at the right step on the right road is not less a god. But Rosa had something else to show us, and she showed it the way she did everything, sideways and without a thesis statement.

She crouched and pointed up at the rays. The crown. The "antennae," if you've been on the parts of the internet where the Giant has antennae and a spacecraft and a backstory written by people who never came here. I won't pretend those readings don't exist; the rays are real, jutting from the head like spokes, and an honest book says plainly that the alien gloss is a gloss — a story laid over real lines by people who'd rather the desert be from somewhere else than be *this*, which is harder and better.

What's harder and better is checkable, and it's this. In 2006, in *Antiquity*, a peer-reviewed journal, the archaeologist Luis Briones published the hypothesis that the rays may be more than crown. That their angles — the directions they point — may track the setting positions of the moon across the year, and that those positions mattered because they could mark the turn of the season. The rare season. The one this desert waits for the way a body waits for breath. The rain.

"When the moon sets *there*—" Rosa pointed along one ray, off toward a notch in the far hills, "—old people said it was time to watch the sky for water. Not every year. But the years it came." She shrugged, a small precise motion. "My grandmother said it. I don't know if the man built it for that. Nobody knows. You can't ask him."

I wanted, badly, to close it. To say yes, *it's a lunar gnomon, the rays are a calendar, write it down*. The wiring that reads routes also wants resolution; the same gift that finds the pattern aches to nail it shut. I felt the ache and I felt Rosa watching me feel it.

"It's checkable," I said instead. "The alignment. Someone could measure whether the ray actually points to the lunar set position."

"Someone published that it might," Rosa said. "Might isn't is."

The fish, were the fish here, would have said: *so the giant antenna man might be a moon clock, or he might be a moon clock the way my*

horoscope is a calendar — technically tracking something celestial, mostly tracking what you brought to it. And the fish would not be wrong, and the fish would also not be the one who walked the road right, so the fish can mind the boat.

“You see why I don’t say,” Rosa said. Not to me. To the LENS, who had finally raised the camera and then, watching her, lowered it again. “If I say *it’s a moon marker* — done. They put a sign. They put a fence. The grant people up there—” a tip of her chin north, toward where the consortium’s white trucks sat parked at the access road like patient gulls, “—they want a sentence they can print. *The Atacama Giant tracked the moon to predict the rains.* Then it’s finished. Then it’s a thing that already happened.” She looked back up at him, crowned, watching the road. “It’s not finished. People still walk past him. He still tells you where you are.”

That was Jakobus’s whole contribution, and he made it the way he makes everything, which is to take up almost no room.

He’d come up the road last, slow, reading the ground the way Rosa read it — he reads *made things*, that’s his whole strange gift, he can stand in front of a wall or a wheel or a 119-metre man and ask the only question he ever asks, which isn’t *who* and isn’t *what does it mean*. He waited until Rosa had said her piece and the silence had settled and then he said it, low, to nobody, to the pampa:

“What’s it for.”

Rosa didn’t answer. It wasn’t hers to hand him, and he knew it wasn’t, and the not-asking-harder was the respect.

But she’d already shown us, hadn’t she. She’d shown us with her feet for three hours. The Giant is not a monument. A monument is a thing you arrive at — you stand in front of it, you look up, you leave. This is a thing you *pass*. You are going somewhere across an open desert with no other landmark and animals to keep alive and water you can’t see, and he rises up at the right stride to tell you: you are on the road. You are still on the road. And maybe — checkable, unproven, published, open — the crown over his head tells you something about *when*: which moon, which season, whether to watch the sky for the water that comes the years it comes.

A waymark. A calendar you walk into. A thing for people in motion, in a world where the land and the sky were the only maps and you read them with your body or you died.

The LENS still hadn't taken the shot. He stood there with the camera at his chest, the figure perfect over his shoulder, the light going long and gold and *correct*.

"You can take it," I told him.

"I know." He didn't. "I keep thinking — if I shoot him from here, he's right. Symmetrical. And then anyone who sees the photo thinks he's *standing* somewhere. They won't know you have to walk to find him." He lowered his hands all the way. "I don't think there's a picture of this. The this is the walking."

Behind us, on the access road, an engine turned over. A white truck, pulling out, headed back up to whatever brief the consortium was assembling — the sentence they wanted to print, the fence they wanted to plant, the question they wanted, gently and with funding and the best intentions in the world, to *answer*.

Rosa watched the truck go. Then she turned north herself, the direction we were all going next, up the coast to a peninsula and a sign cut into a hill that faces the wrong way — that faces the sea, that no one on land could ever stand to read.

"You think this one's hard," she said. "Wait until you meet a road that runs on water."

She started walking before we did. We scrambled after her.

Chapter 7 — The Consortium Moves

The convoy came up the access road in a way that nothing comes up that road — fast, and matched. Three white Hiluxes, same year, same livery, a magnetic decal on each door that read PATRIMONIO VIVO in a sans-serif so confident it had its own self-esteem. Behind them, a van with a satellite dish folded on the roof like a sleeping mantis.

Mara saw the dust before she saw the trucks. From the foot of Cerro Unitas the pampa runs flat and pale for kilometres, and a column of dust on that flatness is a sentence you can read from a long way off. She'd been crouched at the base of the hill with her notebook, copying the angle where one of the caravan tracks met the slope — not measuring, just letting her eyes walk it, the way she walked a new language before she tried to speak it. Routes had grammar. This one was old and patient and went somewhere specific.

“Company,” said Idris. He didn't look up from the drone case. He was re-seating the gimbal for the fourth time, because the wind off the pampa had a habit of finding the one screw you'd trusted. Idris trusted nothing twice. It was, Mara thought, the most useful trait on the entire crew. “Three vehicles and a dish. They've brought their own internet. People who bring their own internet have come to broadcast, not to learn.”

Tomás Quispe Mamani had not moved at all. The wayfinder stood where he'd been standing for an hour, a little uphill, his back to the Giant, watching the road with the particular stillness of a man who has watched weather do worse things than arrive in a Hilux. He had a way of being present that made the rest of them feel like they were

fidgeting. Even the Lens, who could go quiet as a stone behind the camera, looked busy next to Tomás.

The lead truck stopped where the road gave out. A woman got down from the passenger side in field clothes that had never been in a field, the cuffs still creased, and crossed the dirt toward them with her hand already out.

“You must be the documentary people.” Warm. Genuinely warm — that was the thing Mara would have to keep reminding herself of all week. “Dr. Elena Vásquez. Patrimonio Vivo. We’ve corresponded with your producer.” A glance up the slope, and her face did something soft and real. “God. He’s bigger than the photographs.”

“He always is,” said Mara.

“They never get him,” Elena agreed, and for a second the two of them just looked at the Giant together, and there was no consortium and no crew, only the figure on the hill — a hundred and nineteen metres of him, the largest human ever drawn on the planet that anybody knows about, scraped pale into the dark hide of the slope and built up with stone where the maker wanted weight. The head with its crown of rays, spiking out like a sunburst, like a headdress, like an idea so old it had forgotten which it was. From down here he watched the pampa. From up there the pampa watched him. You felt, standing under him, slightly read.

Big lad, Mara thought, in the voice the crew used for the figures, which was always a little too fond. *Surveys the realm. Never blinks. Owes us nothing.*

Elena pulled herself back from it. She was good. She knew how it landed and she’d let it land on her on purpose, and then she got to work, because she was here to work.

The official story, said straight, is a good one, and Elena said it well over the next hour, perched on a folding chair her assistant had carried up the slope, with the press videographer framing her so the Giant filled the sky behind her head.

The Atacama holds something like five thousand geoglyphs. Not one. Not a famous handful. *Five thousand* — figures and abstractions and

arrows scratched and stacked across the driest non-polar desert on Earth, where it does not rain enough to wash them away and almost nobody lives to step on them. Most of them sit beside the old caravan routes, the llama roads, where for centuries trains of animals carried goods up and down the spine of the continent. The figures are signposts. Way-markers. Here is water two days on. Here you turn. Here someone with authority watched the road. The Giant, in this telling, is the grandest of them — a deity, or a shaman, or a lord of the route, placed on Cerro Unitas because Cerro Unitas can be seen from everywhere on the plain. He is infrastructure dressed as a god. Or a god doing the job of infrastructure. The desert did not draw a line between the two.

“It’s a tradition of monumental ground art,” Elena said to the camera, “and the Giant is its masterpiece. Our work is to protect it, to interpret it for visitors, and to give it back to Chile.” She said *give it back* like a person handing over something heavy, and meant it.

The crew let her finish. The Lens kept the camera low and pointed mostly at the ground, at the line where the scraped subsoil met the dark surface, which was where the actual mystery lived if it lived anywhere.

Because here is the potato.

They’d tried, on day two, before any of this. Idris had laid out a figure on a clear patch a kilometre off — nothing grand, a stick man maybe ten metres long, with a measured baseline and a hand level and pegs and string, the whole arsenal of a man who does not trust a fourth screw. He’d planned it like a bridge. He’d scraped the dark crust to show the pale ground beneath, exactly the extractive technique the Giant’s makers used. Ten metres. A toddler next to the hundred-and-nineteen on the hill.

It looked, when he finished, like a stick man drawn by a stick man. The legs disagreed about length. The head wandered off the centre-line because at ground level you cannot see your own figure; you are inside it, blind, and the eye that has to read it is a hundred metres away and four hundred years from now. Idris had stood on the truck roof to check it and made a sound he did not make often.

The wind erased the head overnight. Just the head. By morning the crust had crept back over the scrape and the rays — Idris had given

his little man a tiny crown, a joke, an homage — were gone, and the body lay there headless and lopsided on the pampa, and the Giant on the hill watched it not be him.

That was the thing the camera couldn't say and Mara wouldn't. Up there: perfect bilateral symmetry across a figure longer than a city block, laid out by people inside it, blind to it, who got it *right*, and made it survive a thousand years of the exact wind that took Idris's homage in a night. Down here: a headless man. The gap between those two was not a gap of skill, exactly. It was a gap of something the crew didn't have a clean word for, and didn't trust themselves to name, and so left alone.

The pressure came at dusk, the way pressure usually does, dressed as dinner.

They sat around a folding table in the lee of the van while the dish hummed and somewhere a generator carried the sat-link. Elena had brought wine and an iPad. She set the iPad on the table, screen up, with the easy intimacy of someone showing you photos of her kids.

It was a document. Mara read it upside down out of habit — she read everything upside down, sideways, in the wrong language, it was how she found the load-bearing words first. *Interpretive Memorandum of Understanding*. Beneath that, a paragraph that fixed the Giant's meaning. Deity-shaman. Caravan marker. Regional monumental tradition, AD 1000 to 1400. All true. All defensible. All cited.

"We're consolidating the interpretation," Elena said. "Signage, the visitor centre, the grant language — it all has to say the same thing, or we look like we don't know what we're standing on. The Ministry won't fund ambiguity. Tourists won't travel for *maybe*." A small, rueful laugh. "Your film carries weight. If the documentary affirms the agreed reading, we move faster. Everyone benefits. The Giant most of all — fenced, funded, forever."

"Forever," Idris repeated, tasting it.

"Protected," Elena said.

Mara looked at the paragraph. There was nothing in it that was wrong. That was the trouble. Everything in it was a thing real scholars had

really said, and the only thing missing was the one published fact that didn't fit on a brochure.

"You haven't mentioned Briones," she said.

A pause. Elena knew the name. Of course she knew the name. "The lunar hypothesis."

"*Antiquity*, 2006. Peer-reviewed." Mara kept her voice flat, kept it cited, kept it cold the way you keep a hole cold. "The rays off the head. He proposed they might track the moon — that from down on the caravan path, at the turn of the season, the moon could set into them like a sight into a notch. A working marker for when the rains might come, in a place that needs to know that more than anywhere on Earth." She let it sit. "It's not proven. It's not disproven. It's a real, open question with a real man's name on it."

"It's one paper," Elena said gently. "It's elegant and it's *unconfirmed*. I can't fence the largest geoglyph on the planet around a hypothesis. Signage can't say *perhaps the moon*. People want the answer."

"It *is* one of the answers," Mara said. "It's just the one that's still alive."

And there it was, on the table between the wine and the iPad: the whole shape of it. Not protect versus destroy. Both of them wanted the Giant kept. Elena wanted him kept the way you keep a body — perfect, fixed, labelled, safe. Mara wanted him kept the way you keep a question. And the maddening thing, the thing that kept her hand off the bait, was that Elena's way would actually save the stone, and might save the question too, and might quietly kill it, and you could not tell from here which.

She did not say any of that. She was learning — slowly, against her wiring, which wanted to *solve*, which always wanted to close the loop and have the pattern lock — to leave a thing open even when she could feel the closed shape of it under her hand.

She looked at Tomás instead.

He had not touched the wine. He had not touched the iPad. He had eaten, quietly, and watched the road again though the road was empty, and now he turned the document over so its screen faced down, not rudely, the way you'd turn over a card you were done with.

“It moves,” he said.

Elena waited. So did Mara.

“The mark.” Tomás nodded up at the hill, at the dark where the Giant was now only a deeper dark. “You ask what it is. I ask the wrong question if I ask once, because it is not one thing once.” He spoke Spanish carefully, the careful of a man with three languages and no patience for losing meaning between them. “When the caravans came through, my grandfather’s grandfather’s people, the Giant told them where they were. That is one thing it is. When the moon turns the year, it may tell them when — Briones is not wrong to look, the old ones looked too, with their own eyes, not his paper. That is another thing it is. To a child walking out with the animals it is the lord who watches so you do not get lost. That is another.” He set his hand flat on the upturned iPad, not to threaten it, just to cover it. “You want to write down which one. But a tool is what you use it for, and people are still here, and we still use it. The day you write down one thing, the others are not protected. They are buried. Under the true thing.” He looked at Elena, and there was no anger in it, which was worse than anger. “A fence keeps people out. A sign keeps the meaning out.”

Nobody said anything. The generator hummed. The Lens, very slowly, lowered the camera to his lap, lens-down, the way Tomás had turned the card, and did not raise it again. He’d been told once that you don’t photograph a man giving something away. He was getting better at remembering.

Elena’s face had gone still in a way that wasn’t defeat. It was the face of someone hearing an argument they had no rebuttal to and could not afford to lose. “I can’t take *that* to the Ministry,” she said, almost to herself.

“No,” Tomás agreed. “You cannot. That is why I tell it to them” — a small motion of his chin at the crew — “and not to your paper.”

The blow came the next morning, and it came on letterhead, which is how that kind of blow always comes.

Elena was apologetic and she was sincere about being apologetic and it did not change a single comma. The restricted-access or-

der had cleared faster than even she'd expected. As of the end of the week, Cerro Unitas would close for survey — *active heritage protection*, the order called it, and it would be true. Drones grounded. Ground crews escorted. Filming by permit, and the permit would route through the interpretive memorandum, which Mara had not signed and Tomás had turned face-down.

"You can apply," Elena said. "You should apply. I'll back it. I want you here."

"How long does an application take," Idris said. He already knew. He just wanted her to say it on the recording.

"In Chile?" Elena had the grace to wince. "Weeks. Maybe longer."

Weeks they did not have, because the second mark was waiting, and the consortium was already moving on it. The Lens had seen it overnight — Patrimonio Vivo had a Peru branch, same decal, and a press release dated for next month, prepping a peninsula for *closed research and managed tourism*. A bay. A trident cut into a hillside above the sea. A sign aimed at a horizon nobody could stand on.

They broke camp at dawn. Mara stood at the foot of Cerro Unitas one more time while Idris fought the drone case shut, and let her eyes walk the caravan track up to the slope, the old grammar of the route, the sentence that went somewhere specific. The Giant watched the pampa. The pampa watched him. In a few days a fence would stand between them and a sign would tell everyone what he was, and it would be true, and it would be one thing.

Tomás walked her to the truck. He didn't shake hands; he wasn't a hand-shaker.

"North," he said, not a question.

"North. Paracas. There's another one. By the water."

He nodded slowly, like a man who had always known the marks talked to each other across the distance, because that, after all, was what they were for. "Then you should go before they close the water too," he said. "And remember what I told the paper."

"You didn't tell the paper anything."

“No,” he said, and almost smiled. “I told *you*. Carry it carefully. It is heavier than it looks.”

The trucks turned south to the city and the consortium’s dish folded down like a closing eye. The crew turned north, toward the coast, toward a 170-metre question aimed out to sea, and behind them on the hill the Giant kept his crown of rays pointed at where the moon would set — for the rains, or for a god, or for a road, or for a child, or for some reason nobody had written down yet, because the people who knew were still here, and still hadn’t decided to tell.

Chapter 8 — North by the Sea Road

The Panamericana north of Iquique runs like a ruled line, and for a while that's all it is — a single dark stroke laid across the pale subsoil, the same trick the old people used, scrape away the desert varnish and the ground beneath comes up bone-coloured. Mara watched it out the passenger window of the rented Hilux and felt the old itch start at the back of her skull, the one that meant *this is a route and routes have grammar*.

"Stop doing the face," Esi said from the back.

"I'm not doing a face."

"You're doing the face. The wayfinding face. You look like the road is talking to you and you're too polite to interrupt."

Mara hadn't been aware her face did anything. That was the thing nobody told you about a brain that read the world all day — you forgot you were broadcasting. "The Atacama has about five thousand geoglyphs," she said, because facts were a place to put the broadcasting. "Most of them aren't gods or shamans. Most of them are *here's water, this way, eight days to the next quebrada*. Llamas, fish, men, abstract lines. Signposts. The whole desert is a manuscript and the caravans were the readers."

"And you," said Esi, "are the kind of person who'd read a stop sign for fun."

"Stop signs are *fascinating*. Octagon so you can tell it from the back, in the dark, half-buried in snow—"

“Oh god.”

Jakobus, driving, said nothing, which was how Jakobus said most things. His hands sat on the wheel the way a man’s hands sit on a tool he’s used so long he’s stopped seeing it. Every so often his eyes went off the tarmac and out into the pampa, and they snagged on something, and they let it go.

The LENS rode with the window cracked because closed cars did things to him he didn’t discuss. His name on the manifest said Theo. He thought of himself, mostly, as the thing behind the camera, and the camera was on his knee, capped, which was its own small cowardice and he knew it.

He shot the desert anyway, through the gap, on instinct. Burn of white. A vicuña standing exactly where a vicuña should stand, which is to say at the precise point where two invisible lines of grazing crossed. A wind-collapsed shrine at the roadside, a cross made of two femurs of corrugated iron, plastic flowers gone to chalk. He didn’t lift the camera to his eye. He shot from the hip, blind, the way you do when you’ve spent fifteen years learning that the eye to the viewfinder is the eye that doesn’t flinch, and that the not-flinching is the thing that breaks you in the end.

“There,” Mara said suddenly, and Theo’s whole body braced before he understood it wasn’t *that* kind of *there*.

She was pointing at nothing. A faint braid of disturbance in the desert floor, running off perpendicular to the highway and vanishing toward the coastal cordillera.

Jakobus slowed without being asked.

“Caravan track,” Mara said. “Look at it. The modern road took the easy line, the engineer’s line, the gentlest gradient. But the old track ignores it. It goes *that* way — harder, steeper — because it’s not going where the road’s going. It’s going to water, and then to the next water, and the water decides everything.” She had her hands up now, framing it, the way Theo framed things, and he noticed she did it too, and felt a small ridiculous warmth at that. “The road is a line drawn by money. The track is a line drawn by thirst.”

“Write that down,” Esi said. “That’s a chapter title.”

“It’s not subtle enough,” said Mara. “Why Files doesn’t do *thirst*. Why Files does *here is the boring true thing, and here is the one place it stops being boring.*”

The boring true thing, for the record, held up.

They’d spent three days under the Giant at Cerro Unitas and the Giant had been everything the literature promised and harder than the literature let on. A hundred and nineteen metres of human figure laid up the side of a lonely hill, the largest prehistoric anthropomorph anyone’s ever found, built somewhere in the long window between AD 1000 and 1400 by people whose names did not survive the building. Part of it scraped down to the bright subsoil. Part of it built up, dark stones carried and laid by hand to draw the dark parts dark. From the base of the hill it didn’t look like much — foreshortened, a smear, a rumour of a man. You had to back off across the pampa, you had to get the angle the old caravans got, and then it stood up out of the ground and looked at you, and the rays came off its head like a crown or a headdress or — well. That was the whole argument, wasn’t it. *Or*.

They had tried to make one. That was the rule of the show: you don’t get to call a thing easy until you’ve failed to do it.

They’d surveyed a patch of pampa with the drone — and the drone, bless it, had spent the first morning being slapped sideways by a wind that came off nothing and went to nowhere and never once stopped. Esi had flown it like a woman defusing something. They’d staked a modest figure, forty metres, a fifth of the Giant, and scraped their lines with rakes and string and a theodolite-app on a phone that kept overheating in the sun.

Their man came out wobbly. The legs disagreed about where the hips were. One arm had a kink in it like a broken antenna. And then the wind, which had been their enemy all along, did the thing the desert does to everything it isn’t fond of — it came in the night and feathered the edges, and by the second dawn their forty-metre man was already going soft and grey, dissolving back into the ground that had loaned him out for a day.

Whereas the Giant had stood for seven hundred years.

"That," Esi had said, standing over the ruin of their man with a rake in her hand and grit in her teeth, "is the potato. That right there. They make a god you can read across the desert for centuries. We make a stick figure the wind eats before breakfast."

So now they drove north, up the sea road, and Mara built the corridor in her head the way other people hum.

It went like this. The desert geoglyphs were infrastructure — that word again, Jakobus's word, the one he'd offered at Cerro Unitas like a man laying a single card on the table and then taking his hand away. *Infrastructure*. Not art, not only. Signs. And signs come in systems. A stop sign is meaningless alone; it means *stop* because there's a *go* and a *yield* and a whole grammar of the road behind it. So if the Giant was a sign, what was it part of?

She'd been mapping the answer for two thousand kilometres. The Atacama geoglyphs clustered on caravan routes — the dry highways that linked the coast, where you got fish and guano and the cool sea fog, to the highland valleys, where you got maize and water and people. Llamas carried the trade. The geoglyphs marked the way. And the routes didn't stop at a modern border. They ran north, the same logic, the same thirst, the same need to call across distance — up into what was now Peru, up toward the river valleys, up toward a peninsula that stuck out into the Pacific like a thumb.

"It's one corridor," she said aloud, somewhere past Arica, with the sea grey on her left and the dunes climbing tan on her right. "Chile, Peru, it doesn't matter, the border's two hundred years old and the road's two thousand. It's one long sign-system. The Giant's at the desert end of it. And up the coast—"

"—is the Candelabra," said Jakobus.

It was the most words he'd said in an hour. Everybody waited, because Jakobus saying a thing twice was Jakobus underlining.

"Two signs," he said, and his eyes were out the windscreen, off the road, on the long grey horizon where the water went on past anything. "Same coast. One faces the land. One faces the sea." He let it sit. "A sign tells you which way to go. So." A pause you could have driven the truck through. "Where's the traffic going that needs both?"

Theo lifted the camera then. He didn't decide to. The hands did it, the way the hands had done it for fifteen years, and he caught Jakobus in profile against the bright window — the weathered face, the eyes that read made things — and then he caught himself doing it and almost lowered it again, the old argument, *whose is this, am I taking or am I keeping*, and then he thought: this one's allowed. A man looking at a horizon is allowed. He clicked once and put the camera down in his lap and felt, for once, that he'd taken nothing that wasn't given.

"There's a problem with your corridor," he said to Mara, because someone had to be the fish.

"There's always a problem. That's the job."

"You can't read the Candelabra from the corridor." He gestured at the land, the dunes, the road. "The Giant — fine, you stand on the pampa, you get the angle, the caravan reads it, beautiful, infrastructure, I buy it. But the Candelabra faces the *water*. A hundred and seventy metres, cut two feet deep into the hill so the wind can't have it, and the literature says you can see it from nineteen kilometres out — to sea. So it's not for your caravans. It's not for anybody on your corridor. It's for somebody in a boat." He spread his hands. "Who's in the boat, Mara? You've built me a beautiful land map and the last sign points the wrong way."

Mara opened her mouth and shut it.

That was the hole, and she knew it was the hole, and the thing about the real holes is that you can feel them as a small cold draught coming through a wall you thought was solid. The Giant had a hole — Briones, in *Antiquity*, 2006, the peer-reviewed idea that the rays were a working lunar gnomon, that they pointed at where the moon set at the turn of the season, that a desert farmer could read the rains off a man's stone crown. Checkable. Unproven. A draught you could feel in the room.

But the Candelabra's hole was worse, because the Candelabra had no *floor*. Nobody had dated the thing. Not once. The only number anyone had was the pottery in the dirt nearby — Paracas style, around 200 BC — and there was no chain, no proof, no rivet connecting that pottery to the hand that cut the sign. A hundred and seventy metres

of trident aimed at the open ocean, undated, unsigned, its makers unknown and its message addressed to *the sea*, and the only people who could read it were people you couldn't ask, in boats you couldn't find, going somewhere the land road didn't go.

"I don't know who's in the boat," Mara admitted.

"Good," said Jakobus.

She turned around in her seat. "Good?"

"You don't know." He didn't smile, exactly. The corner of his mouth conceded something. "That's the right amount of knowing. The wrong amount is when you decide." He looked back at the road. "Somebody up there has already decided."

He meant Pisco. He meant the news Esi had been reading off her phone for the last hour and saving up, because Esi saved bad news the way some people save wine, for when it would land.

"Right," Esi said now, taking the cue. "So. The consortium. The heritage-plus-tourism people. They've moved up the coast ahead of us. Filed for the Paracas reserve. Restricted-access research permit, the whole apparatus." She scrolled. "And they've got a line, and the line is good, that's the horrible part. *Securing the meaning of the Candelabra for the Peruvian people*. Interpretive centre. Boardwalk. A plaque." She looked up. "A plaque, Mara. They want to put a plaque on a sign that nobody has ever read."

"What does the plaque say?"

"That's the thing. They haven't decided. There's a committee. The committee's going to *fix* it. Pick the meaning. Datura beacon, or Viracocha, or trident-of-the-storm-god, whatever scans best for the brochure, and then carve it in bronze and bolt it down and that's what it means now, forever, the end."

Theo watched Mara's face do the wayfinding thing, and then do something else, something tighter, and he recognised it because he'd worn it himself: the look of a person who wants very badly to be the one who decides, who knows they'd decide *well*, and who has just understood that the wanting is the trap.

“We could get there first,” Mara said quietly. “We could read it first. We could—”

“Could what,” said Jakobus. Not unkind. Just the question, set down flat on the table, his hand taken away.

Mara didn’t answer that one either. Out the window the sea went on, grey on grey, past the edge of every map she’d ever built, and somewhere up the coast a hundred and seventy metres of someone’s answer faced the water and waited for a reader it had been waiting two thousand years for, while a committee with a good heart and a bronze plaque drove the same road, faster, with more money, toward the same hill.

“Drive,” Mara said.

Jakobus drove. The line of the road ran out ahead of them, the engineer’s line, the easy gradient, the route drawn by money — and somewhere under it, or beside it, or older than it, the other line ran too, the one drawn by thirst and the sea and the long human need to call across a distance to someone you can’t see.

The corridor was a map. The map had two signs. One faced the land and one faced the water, and the people racing them to the second one had already chosen what it said.

The crew had not. That was the whole of what they had. They went north to keep it.

Chapter 9 — First Sight: The Candelabra

The boat smelled of diesel and fish-blood, and the swell came in long and patient, the kind that lifts your stomach without your permission. We had been on the water forty minutes out of Paracas town, and the peninsula sat to starboard like a sleeping animal — tawny, naked, no green on it anywhere, the Pacific gnawing at its foot in slow white mouthfuls.

“You’re looking the wrong way,” said the boatman. Mateo. He had a face like cracked leather and an outboard he treated with more tenderness than he’d shown any of us. He didn’t take his eyes off the water. “It’s not on the point. It’s on the side. You have to come around.”

So we came around.

Tomas had the rail in a death-grip, his other hand cupped over his viewfinder against the glare, and Wren sat amidships with the GPS unit balanced on one knee and her notebook on the other, writing numbers down by hand because she didn’t trust the unit’s logging in salt spray. I was watching the hillside, the way you watch a word you almost know in a language you almost speak — waiting for it to resolve.

And then it did.

It came up out of the slope all at once, the way a face comes up out of wallpaper. Three arms, rising. A central shaft and two flanking prongs, each one bristling with smaller crossbars, the whole figure cut into the pale-gold flank of the hill above Pisco Bay. A trident. A

candlestick. A cactus. A hand with too many fingers. It depended entirely on what you'd brought with you to look at it.

Nobody said anything for a moment. Even Mateo cut the engine back, and we sat there in the trough and the slap, and the thing looked at the water, and the water looked back.

It is called, in the brochures and the guidebooks and the seventeen thousand identical postcards in Paracas town, the Candelabra. *El Candelabro de Paracas*. The figure stands roughly a hundred and seventy metres tall and about sixty wide, which is to say it is taller than most cathedrals are long, scratched into a hillside by people who — and here we should be honest about what is known — left no name, no plaque, no inscription, and no body buried beneath it with a chisel in its hand and a note that says *I did this, and here is why*.

The official story is generous and modest at the same time, which I have come to think is the mark of good archaeology. It goes like this. The Candelabra is *probably* associated with the Paracas culture, a sophisticated coastal people who flourished on this peninsula and buried their dead in the sand in textiles so fine they still glow. Paracas-style pottery has been found in the vicinity, and that pottery dates to around 200 BC. So: a Paracas sign, give or take, a religious or symbolic figure, a cousin of those famous lines a couple of hundred kilometres south at Nazca, made by people who liked drawing very large things on the ground for reasons we infer rather than know.

That is the careful version. It is held carefully, by careful people, and it is the version I would defend in any reasonable argument.

It also has a hole in it you could sail a boat through. We were, in fact, sailing a boat through it.

"It points at us," Tomas said. He had the camera up now, the long lens, and he was shooting in bursts, and I knew without looking that he wasn't framing the figure — he was framing the *line*, the invisible cord that ran from the carved hillside out across the chop to the lens, and past the lens, and out to the horizon where the sea bent away.

"It points at the sea," Wren corrected, not unkindly. Wren corrects the way other people breathe. "We're incidental. We just happen to be in the sea."

That was the thing. That was the whole strange thing, sitting there in

the morning glare.

Nazca's lines — the hummingbird, the monkey, the spider — face the sky. They are drawn for the gods, or for whoever floats above, or for the act of drawing them, depending on which book you read; what they do not do is face an *audience* in any practical sense, because the people who made them could not get up high enough to see them whole. That is half of what makes them eerie. They are signs made by people who could never quite read their own handwriting.

The Candelabra is not like that. The Candelabra faces *out*. It is cut into a slope that opens onto Pisco Bay, angled so that a person at sea level — say, in a small boat, say, exactly where we were — gets the full figure, the entire hundred and seventy metres, presented like a billboard. And it can be seen, on a clear day, from something like nineteen kilometres out. Twelve miles. From a vessel hull-down, with the coast a thin smudge, the Candelabra would still be legible, three pale arms standing up out of the gold.

I have read everything I could find on geoglyphs in four languages, and that detail still makes the hair go up on my arms. A sign that big, aimed not at heaven, not at the next valley, not at the herder coming over the ridge — but at the *empty water*. At someone arriving. At someone who would be looking for it.

“Okay,” said Tomas quietly, lowering the camera at last, which for him is a sentence in itself. “Okay. Who’s it *for*.”

That was the question Jakobus would have asked, if Jakobus had been in the boat, which he was not — he was ashore, doing whatever it is Jakobus does ashore, which mostly involves standing very still next to people and letting them decide they trust him. But the question travels with us now whether he’s present or not. We’ve caught it off him like a cold. Not *what does it mean*. Not *who made it*. For whom was it made.

The boat that wasn’t ours was the second thing we noticed.

It sat at anchor off the figure’s base, a fat white research launch with a name in heritage-blue lettering and a man on the foredeck in a hi-vis vest doing something with a total station — that’s the surveyor’s instrument, the one on a tripod that looks like a robot deciding whether to like you. Two more figures moved along the lower slope below the

geoglyph, tiny, in matching jackets, planting little flags. From here they looked like they were measuring a crime scene, and in a sense I suppose they were trying to establish who the victim was.

“That’s the Consortium,” Wren said. She didn’t need to say it. We’d seen the launch in the harbour that morning, behind a line of tape, with a portable office trailer and a banner about *patrimonio* and *futuro* and an artist’s render of the Candelabra under a tasteful night-time spotlight, glowing, framed by a viewing platform that did not yet exist, with little render-people pointing at it from a safe and managed distance.

The render-people were always pointing. Have you noticed that? In every plan for every site, there are little ghost-people pointing at the thing, telling you what it is, so you don’t have to find out.

There was someone watching *us*, too.

She was standing on the rocks at the base of the slope, well apart from the flag-planters, in a faded windbreaker and a hat with a cord, and she had a pair of binoculars trained on our boat with an unhurried steadiness that made me feel, abruptly, like the thing being read. Not hostile. Just thorough. The way you look at a tide you don’t yet trust.

“That’ll be Dr. Salcedo,” Wren said, consulting nothing, because Wren had read the staff page of every relevant institution before we left the airport and filed it somewhere behind her eyes. “Coastal archaeologist. She’s published on the Paracas necropolis textiles and the maritime-subsistence stuff. She’s the one the Consortium keeps quoting in their press releases.”

“Does she like being quoted?”

“The quotes are about pottery seriation,” Wren said. “I doubt she likes what they’re *for*.”

Mateo brought us in slow, reading the swell off the rocks with little corrections of the tiller, and the figure grew until it stopped being a sign and became a *trench* — because that is what it is, up close, and this is the part the postcards cannot hold. The Candelabra is not painted. It is not laid out in pale gravel like a sketch. It is *cut*. The arms of it are channels gouged into the hardened, salt-cemented hillside to a depth of about two-thirds of a metre — two feet — far

deeper than the shallow surface-scrapes at Nazca, which are barely ankle-deep and which a careless boot can wound.

Two feet of trench, in soil like concrete, hand-dug, for a figure the size of an apartment block. And here is the engineering of it, the thing that makes the careful archaeologists go quiet and respectful: that depth, in that salt crust, is *why it's still here*. The salinity of the ground crystallises and re-crystallises with the fog and the rare damp, and it locks the trench walls in place. It armours them. A shallow line would have blown away in a generation. This one was cut deep enough to survive twenty centuries of one of the most relentless coastal winds on the planet — the *paracas* itself, the sandstorm wind that gives the whole peninsula its name.

Whoever made this knew their wind. That's not interpretation. That's the spade in the dirt. They cut it deep *on purpose*, because they meant it to last, because a sign that blows away by next season is a sign aimed at no one.

We had, the week before, tried.

I should tell you about that, because it's the only honest way to earn the wonder. Down in the Atacama we'd had our humbling already — our drone fighting the wind, our practice geoglyph a wobbling embarrassment scraped into a private patch of pampa with a tape measure and a string-line and three people who do this for a *living*, erased by the next afternoon's blow. Here in Paracas we'd done a small, careful, scaled experiment on a sacrificial dune well away from anything sacred: a one-tenth model, seventeen metres, cut with modern tools, surveyed with the GPS. Wren was now guarding from the spray.

It came out crooked. The arms didn't match. Sighting the curve of a giant figure when you are standing *inside* it, at ground level, with no way to see the whole, is a problem that does something humiliating to the human eye. And we had laser levels. We had satellite positioning. We had coffee.

The people who made the real one had the sun, the wind, a length of cord, and an idea about where the boats came from, and they nailed it at ten times the scale, and they cut it deep enough that I was looking at it twenty-two hundred years later from a fishing boat.

Easy, the official story says, gently. A symbolic figure. A ritual sign.

Sure, says the trench. Come and dig me, then. Bring your friends.

Dr. Salcedo had lowered her binoculars. She wasn't watching us anymore. She was watching the Consortium man with the total station, and her stillness had a different quality to it now — the stillness of someone deciding how much it would cost her to say something.

"Can you take us in to the rocks?" I asked Mateo.

"No," he said, comfortably. "She doesn't want you on the rocks. And it's her rocks." He nodded at Salcedo. Then, because he was a kind man under the leather, he added: "But this is where you see it best. From the water. You came to the right place to look. You just came in the wrong boat to *land*."

I asked him the question, then. The one I shouldn't have, the one that's been chewing at me since the Atacama, the one I keep promising the others I'll stop asking out loud.

"Mateo. When you take the boats out — the fishing boats. Do you use it?"

He looked at me for the first time since we'd left the harbour. Not unfriendly. Just measuring, the same as Salcedo had measured the swell.

"Use it for what," he said.

And there it was — handed back to me, polished, exactly the weight I'd given it. *Use it for what*. Because there are at least four answers and he wasn't going to pick mine for me. Did he line up on it coming home? Did his father? Was it a saint's thing now, a thing you crossed yourself at? Was it just the hill where the trident was, the way a roundabout is just the roundabout? He held all of that, and he was not going to spend it to make my morning tidy.

"Forget I asked," I said.

"No," he said, and almost smiled. "Ask Salcedo. If she likes you." He gunned the engine, and we came about, and the Candelabra slid across our stern.

I watched it go. From this angle, falling away, you lost the trident and got something else — three pale strokes against the gold, abstract now, almost a glyph in a script. And it occurred to me, with the cold

clean click of a thing fitting where it belongs, that I had spent the whole morning trying to read it the way you read a word, left to right, *what does it say* — and that I had been doing it wrong, doing it land-side, doing it like the render-people with their pointing fingers.

It wasn't saying anything to *me*. I was over its shoulder. I was reading the back of a sign.

It had never once been talking to the land. The hill it's carved in is a back; the slope it faces is the front; and the front faces the sea, the long wet road, the only road on this entire coast that doesn't show in the dust. Someone cut a hundred and seventy metres of trench, two feet deep, in salt-locked ground, and aimed it dead at the empty water — and the only people in all the world who were ever meant to stand in the right place to read it whole were out there. Coming in. Looking for it.

"Whoever they were," Tomas said, beside me, camera down, watching the same thing fall away, "they weren't worried about us."

Behind us on the rocks, Dr. Salcedo had turned to walk up toward the trailer, toward the flags and the survey tripod and the men measuring her coastline for a viewing platform that would face, of course, the *figure* — that would set the render-people on a deck with their backs to the ocean, pointing inland at the trident, getting it exactly, perfectly, expensively wrong.

She stopped at the bottom of the slope and looked once more, not at us, but past us. Out to sea. The way you check that something is still where you left it.

Chapter 10 — The Official Story: Tridents and Mysteries

The boat smelled of diesel and dried anchovy, and Marisol Quispe-Ortega had not said a word in eleven minutes.

We knew it was eleven because Theo was counting. Theo counts when the room goes quiet — not to be rude, he'd told me once, but because a silence with a shape to it is information, and you don't throw information away. He sat in the bow with his knees up and his notebook braced against his shins, and his pen had not moved, and the line of foam off the hull was the only thing on the whole bright bay that was in a hurry.

Behind us the Candelabra hung on the slope of the peninsula like a watermark pressed into the world. Three prongs. A central spine. A hundred and seventy metres of trench cut into a hillside the colour of old bone, and from out here — a kilometre, two — you could see the whole of it the way you're meant to. Not from above. Not from a drone. From the deck of a small boat with salt in your teeth, looking back at the land the way a man coming home from a season of fishing would look at it.

"Right," said Esme, and spread the folder on the bench between us. The Lens had her camera in her lap, lens cap on, which for Esme was a kind of restraint, a held breath. "Theories. Let's lay them all out and be fair to every one of them, because some of them are going to be true and I want to know which."

“That’s not how it works,” said Theo, without looking up.

“Humour me.”

I read routes for a living — the logic of how a thing connects to another thing, why a path bends where it bends, what a sign is *answering*. So I take the catalogue of theories the way I take a junction I don’t know yet: lay them all down flat, no favourites, and watch which ones the land agrees with.

Esme started at the top.

“One. Paracas culture. The locals’ culture, the one that buried its dead out here wrapped in those impossible textiles, two hundred BC give or take. Pottery in the Paracas style turns up not far from the base of the slope. Ergo: the Candelabra is Paracas. Their sign, their hand.”

She let that sit. It’s a good theory. It’s the careful one, the one museums put on the placard, and it has the great virtue of being *near*. Pottery you can hold. Pottery you can date. The thermoluminescence on Paracas ware lands around two centuries before the Christian era and it does not waver much, and there it is, broken and scattered on the ground beneath the largest sign anyone ever carved at the sea.

Theo finally moved his pen. He drew two dots and a line that *didn’t connect them*, and he held the notebook up so we could see the gap.

“The pot was near the sign,” he said. “That’s the whole evidence. A pot was near a sign. I left a coffee cup near the Mona Lisa once. Doesn’t mean I painted it.”

“You weren’t allowed near the Mona Lisa.”

“I was near it from across the room. That’s still near. Nearness isn’t authorship.” He set the notebook down. “Nobody has ever dated the Candelabra. Not the trench. Not the stones in the trench. The figure itself floats. We are dating a thing by the litter around it, and the litter could be from anyone who walked past in eleven hundred years.”

The man drops his cup and it becomes a footnote, said the fish — the small mean voice I keep for the parts of my own head that won’t shut up, the one that swims along the gunwale heckling everybody including me. *Soon they’ll be dating you by the wrappers in your bag. Carbon says: snack-forward, late Anthropocene.*

I said none of this out loud. Marisol was watching the water.

“Two,” Esme went on. “Nazca. Cousin of the Nazca lines, two hundred kilometres south, same broad cultural neighbourhood, same impulse — enormous figures scraped into the desert floor for reasons we argue about endlessly. The Candelabra as a coastal Nazca, basically. A relative.”

This is the one the documentaries love, because Nazca is famous and the Candelabra is not, and fame is contagious. And it isn’t *wrong*, exactly. There’s a family resemblance in the gesture: the human animal, looking at a vast flat surface, deciding to *write on it*. The same species, the same itch.

But.

“The Nazca lines are scratches,” Theo said. “Centimetres. You sweep the dark stones off the pale ground and there’s your line, and the desert’s so dead and windless it stays. The Candelabra is a *cut*.” He held two fingers apart. “Two feet down. Into salt-hardened ground. Somebody dug a trench you could lose a child in, the whole length of a city block, and then — this is the part — the salt crust *heals* over it and holds the edges and the wind can’t get a grip. The Nazca people were drawing. Whoever did this was *engineering*. Different verb.”

He’s right about the verb. I felt it when we stood at the lip of it that morning, before the boat — the depth of the thing, the way it doesn’t read like art when you’re standing in it. It reads like a road cut. Like someone solving a problem about *staying visible* and refusing to lose to the weather.

The Lens lifted her camera then, half a motion, and stopped. Lowered it. She does this — the war taught her hands to reach for the shutter when a moment gets too large, and the years since have been her trying to teach them to wait. The Candelabra was getting larger behind us as the light shifted. She wanted it. She didn’t take it. I watched her not take it, which is its own kind of photograph.

“Three,” said Esme. “Ritual symbol. It’s a sacred sign — the *chonta* staff of Viracocha, the lightning, a stylised plant. Religion. We carved it for the gods or to mark the gods’ ground, and asking what it’s *for* in a practical sense is like asking what a cathedral spire is *for*. It’s for heaven. It’s a prayer you can see from a boat.”

I like this one more than Theo does. The trouble with us route-readers is we want everything to be infrastructure, and the world is full of people who built enormous things for no reason a satellite could ever recover, who did it because a god told them to and that was sufficient. To assume function is its own kind of blindness. The pampa and the bay are full of marks that mean *we were here and we believed something*, and that's a complete sentence.

"It's aimed at the sea, though," Theo said quietly. "That's the problem with prayer."

"Why's that a problem?"

"Because a prayer you carve into a hillside, you'd aim at the temple. Or the mountain. Or the sky, like Nazca, if you think the gods are up. This one's aimed at *the horizon you sail in on*." He turned his hand flat, like a deck. "You don't pray to the ocean by facing the ocean. You signal to it. A god doesn't need a line of sight from nineteen kilometres out. A *sailor* does."

The fish went quiet. The fish goes quiet when Theo's right.

Nineteen kilometres. That's the number that won't leave you alone once you've heard it. The Candelabra is sited — *sited*, the way you'd site a beacon, the way you'd site a runway light — to be legible from far out on the open water. Somebody chose that slope, that pitch, that orientation, so that a figure on a hill would clear the curve of the world and hang there for a man at sea to find. You can stand on the land and you cannot see it the way it was built to be seen. The land is the back of the sign. The front of the sign faces the deep.

"Four," Esme said, and her voice changed a half-step, because here came the famous one. "Lighthouse. Navigation. A maritime mark — exactly what Theo's circling. A coast with no good landmarks, fog, a treacherous bay, and somebody puts up the biggest possible *here* so the boats can find the harbour. Pure infrastructure. A road sign for the ocean."

"Yes," Theo said.

"You're meant to argue with the others, not agree."

"I agree with this one. I'm allowed."

I had to argue with it, then, because that's the job — you don't let

the theory you *want* walk through unsearched. “Then date it as a lighthouse,” I said. “Lighthouses serve a traffic. Show me the traffic. Show me the harbour it’s lighting, the route it’s gating, the season the boats ran. A beacon implies a network — a thing on the other end that needed finding. We have the sign. Where’s the rest of the sentence?”

He nodded slowly, which is Theo for *that’s a fair hit and I’m going to sit in it*. “We don’t have it yet,” he said. “But absence of the network isn’t absence of the function. The crust kept the sign and lost the boats. Wood rots. Salt keeps stone.” He tapped the trench-line he’d drawn. “We’re reading a road by the one milestone that survived.”

“Five,” said Esme, gentle now, because she’d saved the romantic one for the end the way you save a dessert. “San Martín. Eighteen-twenty. The liberator lands at Paracas to free Peru from the Spanish, and the story goes the Candelabra is *his* — a Masonic emblem, the trident of liberty, cut by his men or pointed out by them as a sign that the revolution had a blessing carved into the coast.” She smiled. “It’s a beautiful story. The independence of a continent, written on a hill.”

It is beautiful. And it is the kind of beautiful that tells you immediately it’s been *added* — a thing too good, too convenient, draped over an older bone. The Candelabra was here long before San Martín’s sails. The freedom-fighters didn’t make it; they *found* it, and found it useful, the way every passing century has found it useful, the way we were finding it useful right now, hanging it with our own meanings like coats on a hook that was there before any of us.

That’s the thing about an undated sign. Everyone gets to claim it, because nothing it carries can be sent back stamped *return to sender, wrong era*. The pottery says two hundred BC and the pottery isn’t talking. The salt holds the edges and the salt doesn’t sign its work. A hundred and seventy metres of certainty about *that something is there* sitting on top of a total blank about *who, when, why, and for whom* — and into that blank pours alien antennae and Freemasons and homing beacons for sailors drunk on datura and the entire glorious zoo of the human need to *finish the sentence*.

We laid all five out on the bench, fair to each, and not one of them could close its hand around the figure. Each had a place where the land said *not quite*.

The Lens had her camera up again. This time she didn't lower it. The afternoon had gone gold and slantwise, the way it does on that coast in the last hour, and the light was raking *across* the Candelabra now instead of flat onto it, and the three prongs threw their own thin shadows down into the trenches so the whole sign stood up off the hill in relief, deep and certain and lit from the side like something underlined. From the boat. Only from the boat. She held the shutter and didn't press it, and held it, and the boat rocked, and then she let it down without a frame, and I understood she'd decided the moment was Marisol's, not hers.

Because the whole time, the archaeologist had said nothing.

Eleven minutes had become forty. Marisol Quispe-Ortega had heard us lay out Paracas and Nazca, ritual and lighthouse and the general from history, had heard us be careful and be fair and find each one's flaw, had heard Theo draw his gap between the pot and the sign, and she had watched the water and the slope and the light coming sideways onto the trident, and she had let us run the whole catalogue out to its end without a single correction.

That's not silence because she has nothing. I've sat with enough wayfinders now to know the difference between a quiet that's empty and a quiet that's *full and choosing*. This was the second kind. She knew which of our five was foolish and which had a bone in it; she knew, I was nearly sure, things that weren't on any of the five lists, things you couldn't get from a pot or a satellite, that came from a grandfather's hand pointing at a hill from a boat exactly like this one. She had all of it. She just hadn't decided yet whether we'd earned it, or whether earning it was even the right frame, or whether the consortium's people prepping their tidy interpretive signage up the coast had already poisoned the well for any outsider with a folder full of theories.

"You've left one out," she said finally. Her first words in three-quarters of an hour.

Esme's pen went up, hungry. "Which?"

Marisol looked at the Candelabra, lit and deep and aimed past us at the open water, and she didn't answer. She let the line sit there in the diesel air — *you've left one out* — and she turned her face back to the sea, to the horizon the sign was built to address, the one none

of us could stand on.

The fish, for once, said nothing at all.

We had five good theories and a real hole in each, and a woman in the stern who knew the sixth and hadn't given it. The official story was intact, every piece of it respected, none of it closed. And the boat carried us in toward the slope where the trident waited, patient as a milestone on a road whose other end is two thousand years downstream and underwater, still asking — of us, of the consortium, of every boat that ever came home this way — *who are you, and can you read me.*

I wrote nothing down. Some doors you don't sketch. You just note that they're open, and that the keeper is standing in front of them, and you wait.

Chapter 11 — The Potato: Carving Wind and Salt

The wind on Paracas does not gust. It leans. By eight in the morning it had a shoulder against everything we owned, and by nine it had decided the survey stakes were optional. I watched one go cartwheeling across the flat toward the bay, a thin orange flag waving goodbye, and I had the distinct, humbling sense that the peninsula was correcting our homework.

“That’s the third,” said Mara, who runs the LENS, without lowering the camera. She tracked the stake all the way to the water’s edge. “I’m starting to like the wind. It has opinions.”

We had permission — a narrow, paper-thin, expiring permission — to attempt a small recreation on a stretch of crusted ground a kilometre south of the real Candelabra, well clear of the monument itself, on a flat that the consortium’s own access map had marked “low sensitivity.” The plan, on paper, looked like dignity itself. We would cut a single arm of a trident. Not the whole thing. One prong, scaled down, ten metres, to the same profile and the same honest depth the books quoted for the original.

Two feet. Sixty centimetres. That was the number we kept saying to each other like it was a friend.

The official story, which I want to give its full weight before I tell you how badly we embarrassed ourselves, is straightforward and not foolish. Somewhere around two thousand years ago — the pottery nearby says two hundred before Christ, though the pottery is a witness, not a confession — people cut a sign into this hill that they meant to last. They didn’t scratch it the way the Nazca artists scratched the desert

farther inland, lifting the dark gravel to show the pale ground beneath. They dug. They went down through the salted crust into the body of the hill, and the crust closed back over the edges like scar tissue, and the thing held. It is still here. You can see it from nineteen kilometres out at sea. That is not myth. That is a measured fact, and it is, when you sit with it, a little frightening.

We had a petrol-driven sod cutter, two mattocks, a pick, a laser level on a tripod, three of us willing to bleed, and a printout.

“Right,” said Tomas. Tomas reads systems the way I read routes — he’s our spatial savant, the one who can hold a whole structure in his head and rotate it, and who finds small talk roughly as restful as a fire alarm. He had gridded the ten-metre arm into a clean lattice of pegs the night before, every node logged, the laser shooting a red line we could chase. “The geometry’s solved. We’re just removing material along a known path. This is the easy part.”

He said *easy part* the way men in old films say *what could go wrong*.

The crust fought us first. Not the way rock fights you — rock at least concedes that it is hard and lets you respect it. This was worse. The salted surface had set like a poorly poured concrete, two, maybe three centimetres of it, fused and brittle, and under it the ground went soft and grainy and treacherous. The sod cutter screamed across the crust and skated. Where it bit, it bit too deep, then nothing, then too deep again, so that our first ten metres came out as a row of bruises rather than a line.

Mattock work, then. I want to be honest about the body of it, because the books skip the body. You raise the mattock and you bring it down and the crust shatters in a flat dinner-plate the size of your two hands, and then you’ve got a hole the depth of a finger and the shape of an accident, and the next swing takes a plate from somewhere it shouldn’t, and now your clean ten-metre line has a mouth in it like a missing tooth. The pale undersoil, when you finally reached it, was not the satisfying chalk-bright of the photographs. It was grey. It powdered. The wind took the powder before it ever lay still enough to mean anything.

By noon I had a line. I want to be generous to it. It was a line in

the way that a sentence written by someone falling asleep is a sentence. Its depth ranged, by Tomas's laser, from eleven centimetres to forty-one. Its edges wandered off the laser by as much as eighteen centimetres over a single metre — a wobble you could not see standing on top of it, looking down the length, where everything foreshortens into hope. You only saw the truth when you stepped back.

"Step back," said Mara, and she meant it as photography, but it landed as judgment.

I stepped back. From thirty metres, on the flat, with the sun overhead and no shadow to read the cut by, the arm of our trident was nearly invisible. From a hundred metres it was gone. I had spent four hours and the skin of both palms producing a thing that the land had already half-swallowed before I'd finished it.

The original — the real one, the one we could see from here as a clean pale gash on its distant hill, unbothered, two thousand years into its argument with the same wind — read from nineteen kilometres of open ocean.

"Sixty centimetres," said Tomas, quietly, to the printout, as though it had lied to him personally.

We did not give up, because we are not sensible. We tried the additive trick the Atacama people used on the Giant, piling darker stones to define the edges where the cut wouldn't hold. We hauled rock. The wind didn't move the rock — the wind isn't a fool — but it found the gravel between the rock and lifted it, and by three o'clock the edge we'd built was a smear, a suggestion, a line drawn by someone describing a line they'd once seen.

This is the engine I keep coming back to, the thing the whole trip kept pressing into my hands like a stone too hot to hold. The official story is true. People did this. The interpretation — coastal sign, ritual mark, Paracas cousin to the desert lines, a thing meant to be seen and to keep being seen — is plausible, sober, well-argued. Nobody in this book is being a fool. And yet every time anyone with a printout and a laser and good intentions tries to *do* it, the gap opens under them like the soft ground under the crust. The story says *easy*. The body says otherwise. The wind says otherwise, in a voice with a shoulder

behind it.

Mara worked the whole collapse. That's her instinct now — she came out of fifteen years photographing things people built to kill each other, and she has a famous, much-discussed difficulty pointing the camera at people's faces, at the live human moment, because the camera was for so long the thing between her and what she couldn't bear to feel. But objects she'll shoot all day. Failure she'll shoot tenderly. She got the cartwheeling stake, the grey powder lifting off my ruined line, Tomas crouched over the printout with the laser's red dot trembling on his cheek, the smear that had been an edge. She didn't shoot any of our faces. I noticed. I'd stopped noticing for a while, which means I'd started trusting it, which is the only kind of progress that one makes with Mara.

"It's a good record of getting it wrong," she said, scrolling back through the frames. "I like an honest archive."

"It's a potato," I said.

She tipped her head.

"Jakobus's word. For when the easy version turns out to fight you. You think you're holding the simple thing and it's actually —" I gestured at our line, our wandering, shallow, half-erased, two-toothed line. "That."

She looked at it for a long time through the viewfinder. Then she lowered the camera, which she does not do casually, and looked at it with her own eyes. "Yeah," she said. "That's a potato."

Dr. Mendoza found us at four.

Beatriz Mendoza is the coastal archaeologist who has spent more of her life with the Candelabra than any of us will spend with anything, and who had spent the first two days of our acquaintance being exactly as suspicious of us as we deserved. She arrived on foot from the road, in the wind, with a thermos and an expression I had already learned to read as *I am about to be patient with you, and it is costing me*.

She stood over our trench. She did not say anything for what felt like a geological interval. The wind worked at the powder. Somewhere out

in the bay a fishing boat hung on its line, and I thought, irrelevantly, that they could not see us at all, that we had made a thing aimed at no one.

"You went down how far?" she said at last.

"Eleven to forty-one centimetres," said Tomas, who does not soften numbers. "Target was sixty. The crust skated the cutter. The under-soil didn't hold the edge."

"Mm." She crouched, ran a finger along the broken lip of the cut, where the crust had shattered into plates. She rubbed the grey powder between her fingers and let the wind take it. "You cut across the grain of the crust."

"There's a grain?"

The look she gave me was not unkind. It was the look of a person who has watched many clever visitors arrive with lasers, and has stopped finding it funny, and has not quite started finding it funny again. "There is everything," she said. "There is which way the salt sets when the fog comes off the bay at night. There is what time of year the ground takes a cut and closes over it, and what time of year it just bleeds out the way yours is bleeding now. There is which soil under which crust. You picked a flat. They didn't pick a flat. They picked a hillside that faces the sea, where the cut shows itself, where the morning fog feeds the crust back into the wound and seals it." She stood, knees cracking, unbothered. "You measured the line. You didn't read the ground."

I had nothing to say to that, because it was the truest thing anyone had said to me in a week, and I had felt it in my own ruined palms without being able to name it.

"Your tools are very good," she went on, and there was no cruelty in it, which somehow made it land harder. "Better than anything they had. You have a laser that draws a perfect line in red light. And you made *that*." She nodded at our work the way you nod at a child's drawing you intend to put on the wall anyway. "They had no laser. They made a thing that reads from nineteen kilometres of water and has held its edge through two thousand years of this exact wind. So." She uncapped the thermos, poured something dark and steaming into the lid, and did not offer it to us, which was fair. "Which of you knows

more about cutting this ground? You, with the laser? Or them?"

Tomas, who cannot lie and would not want to, said: "Them."

"Yes," said Mendoza. She drank. "Them."

Here is the part I keep turning over.

We had everything the story said the job needed and then a century of extra technology on top, and we produced a smear. A figure even a slack wind erased between lunch and supper. The depth they cut so casually in the books — that easy, friendly *sixty centimetres* — turned out to be a barrier we couldn't pass, not because we lacked the strength but because we lacked the *knowledge that lives in the ground and the season and the salt*, the knowledge Mendoza carried in her hands and was choosing, drop by careful drop, not to simply pour into ours.

That's the hole the recreation opens, and I want to set it down cold, the way the back matter will set it down, because it is real and it is checkable and it is not closed.

The Candelabra is cut roughly sixty centimetres deep into salted soil, deep enough that the crust reseals and the wind cannot win, deep enough to last. We have a firm date for the pottery found *near* it — about two hundred before Christ, Paracas-style, sitting in the dirt at the foot of the hill. We have no date for the geoglyph itself. None. Nobody has ever dated the cut. The pottery is a neighbour, not a parent. A hundred and seventy metres of intention carved into a hillside to be read from the sea, and we do not know when it was made, or by whom, or — and this is the thing that gets into your chest and stays — *for whom*. A sign aimed at the open water. A message with a known recipient — somebody out there, on a boat, who needed it — and a sender history forgot to keep.

We could measure it down to the centimetre. We could not make it. And we could not say who did.

Mendoza watched me watch the line, and I think she saw the question form, because she capped the thermos before I could open my mouth.

"Don't," she said.

“I wasn’t —”

“You were going to ask me what it’s for.” The wind took a long pull at the powder between us. Out in the bay the fishing boat began, slowly, to come about, and she turned to watch it instead of me, and there was something in the turn that told me she’d answer that boat’s question before she’d ever answer mine. “Come back at dusk,” she said. “Bring your friend with the camera. And tell the old man with the eyes — Jakobus — he can come too.” A flicker that might have been the start of finding it funny again. “He doesn’t measure things. I noticed.”

She walked back toward the road, into the wind, leaning into it the way the whole peninsula leaned, the way the cut had leaned into two thousand years of it and won.

We packed the lasers. We left the potato where it lay. By morning, I knew, the wind would have it.

Chapter 12 — The Hole: Who Made This, and When?

The pottery sat in a cardboard tray lined with tissue, and it was the most disappointing thing I had ever wanted to be more than it was.

We were in the back room of the Reserve office at Paracas, a low concrete building that smelled of sunblock and dust and the inside of an ice chest. Through the window the bay was the colour of hammered tin. Somewhere out there the Candelabra was holding its three arms up to the sea, doing the only thing it has ever done, which is wait to be seen from a boat. We could not see it from here. That is the whole point of it, and it kept being the point no matter how badly I wanted, just once, to walk around behind it.

Inés Robles set the tray down between us and did not touch it. She had a way of not touching things that was more careful than handling them.

“Paracas,” she said. “The style. The negative resist, this cream over the red, this incision here—” she tipped her chin at a sherd no bigger than a thumbnail, a curl of fired clay with a black line baked into it “—that is Paracas. Two hundred years before your calendar starts. We are very sure.”

“How sure,” said Mara. The LENS had her camera down, for once, in her lap, lens cap on, which from Mara was a kind of bow.

“Sure,” Inés said. “It is some of the most studied pottery in the Andes. The dating is good. The sequences are good. People have argued about Paracas for a hundred years and we have learned how to argue well.” A small dry smile. “We are sure about the pots.”

I had the satellite plate open on the tablet, the great trident burned white into the hill, and I was already running the line in my head — *the pottery is Paracas, the pottery is two hundred BC, the glyph is therefore* — and I felt the sentence finish itself with that lovely click a route makes when it closes, and I said it out loud because I am, on a good day, a person who cannot not.

“So the Candelabra is Paracas. Two hundred BC.”

Inés looked at me the way you look at a child who has solved the wrong problem very quickly and is pleased about it.

“Where did we find these,” she said. It was not a question for me to answer. “We found them *near*. On the slope. In the sand. The wind moves sand here in tonnes, all year, every year, for two thousand years. A pot breaks on a beach in the time of Paracas. A pot breaks on the same beach last Tuesday.” She lifted one finger off the table, the smallest possible gesture. “Tell me which of these sherds touched the people who cut the hill.”

Nobody told her.

Let me give the official story its full coat, because it is a good coat and it has kept people warm a long time.

The Candelabra is loosely Paracas. That is the line you will get on the boat, from the guide with the laminated card, and it is not a lie. It sits on the Paracas Peninsula. The Paracas culture was here, around it, before and during the years the line was likely made. They were extraordinary — textile people, trepanation people, people who wrapped their dead in mantles so fine the threads come in at a hundred per centimetre, mantles that show, woven into them, beings with rays coming off their heads. So you stand on the boat and the guide says *Paracas*, and you look at the great three-pronged sign and the rayed beings on the cloth in the Lima museum, and the two things lean toward each other like they want to be the same thing. Sometimes the Candelabra gets folded in with Nazca, fifty kilometres south down the coast, those famous lines, that famous riddle, and the folding is not crazy either: the Nazca came out of the Paracas, child of parent, and they made marks in the ground at a scale no one needed unless the scale itself meant something.

It is a clean story. Coastal people, rich in cloth and ritual, cut a vast sign into a hill. It looks like their gods. It is theirs.

Diego believed it on sight and said so, and Diego is the most careful of us, which is the joke of him. He had the whole thing modelled in the tablet, the slope, the trident, the salt crust, and he turned the model until the sun in it set where the sun outside was setting, and he said, "It's structurally Paracas. The proportions sit in the same family as the textile rays. I'd put money on it."

"With whose money," Inés said, not unkindly, "and to whom would you pay it, if you lost?"

Diego opened his mouth and discovered there was no one to pay. There is no court. That is the trouble with the Candelabra. There is no one who can take your bet, because there is no one who can ever tell you that you were right.

Ooh, said the fish, from somewhere in the cooler full of nothing. A wager with no bookie. My favourite kind. That's how I lost my fins.

Here is the thing they don't tell you on the boat, and to be fair to the boat, the boat has eleven minutes and a German tour group and a swell.

Nobody has dated the Candelabra.

Not *we haven't dated it well*. Not *the dates are contested*. There is no date for the geoglyph itself. None. The line cut into that hill — a hundred and seventy metres of it, sixty across, hauled down two feet into hardpan — has never given anyone a number. The only number anyone has is the pottery. The pottery that was found *near*. On the slope. In the sand that moves in tonnes.

I want to be exact about why this is so maddening, because the maddening part is the interesting part.

When you date a thing, you date a thing — charcoal from the hearth, a seed in the floor, a bone in the grave, something that was *alive* and stopped being alive at a moment you can read in its carbon. The Candelabra was not made of anything alive. It was made of *absence*. It is a removal. Someone went to a hill and took two feet of dirt out of it in the shape of a god, or a tree, or a hand, or a mast, and you

cannot carbon-date a hole. A hole has no death date. A hole is the one thing on this earth you cannot ask *when*.

"You can sometimes date around it," Inés said, when I put this to her, less elegantly. "If a person made the cut and then dropped a basket, and the basket burned, and you find the basket *in* the trench, under the fill, sealed — then yes. Then the basket touched the work. Then you have it." She turned a sherd over with a probe, did not pick it up. "Has anyone found a basket in the trench."

"No," said Diego, who had read everything in three nights and remembered all of it, which is what Diego is for.

"No," Inés agreed. "They have found pottery on the surface, which means people walked here. People walked everywhere here. It is a peninsula on a coast where everyone for four thousand years went to fish and to bury their dead and to throw away their broken pots. The pottery tells you people were *here*. It does not tell you people were *here, cutting this*."

She let that sit.

"It is a signature on the wrong document," she said. "We have the signature. We do not have the document it goes with."

We tried to get our own number anyway. Of course we did. You don't bring a wayfinder, a systems savant, and a war photographer to a 2,000-year-old maybe and not at least take a reading.

Non-invasive only — that was the deal Inés had written into the access, and she had written it before we ever arrived, before the consortium's white trucks parked at the gate with their banners about *preservation* and *heritage corridor* and their lawyers who said *salvage documentation* the way other people say *theft*. No coring. No trenching. No basket-hunting in the fill, even if there had been fill to hunt in. We were allowed to look, and to look very, very hard, and to leave the hill exactly as full of nothing as we found it.

So Diego ran the rock-varnish argument, which is the one people reach for when there's nothing else to reach for — the slow dark patina that builds on exposed stone, the idea that you could read its thickness like rings. He ran it for two days and then closed the

laptop with the particular gentleness he uses when something has failed and he does not want anyone to know how much he cared.

"It's not a tool," he said. "It's a hope wearing a tool's clothes. The varnish here builds at a rate no one can pin to a calendar. You can say *old*. You cannot say *which old*. You cannot tell a Paracas hand from a hand five centuries after, or a hand that came back and re-cut it, or three hands, on three days, four hundred years apart."

"Could it be later?" Mara asked. "Could it be — what. Colonial? Could a sailor have cut it?" She wasn't reaching for fringe. She was doing the thing the LENS does, the thing that has kept her alive, which is refuse to flinch from the worst-case frame.

"There's no rule that closes it," Diego said. "That's what I keep — that's the part that—" He stopped. He doesn't like the part where the rule won't close. He is a person built out of rules that close.

Inés had been listening from the doorway. She came in.

"It is older than the Spanish," she said. "I will give you that one for free, because the technique is old, the way the trench follows the slope is old, the salt crust over the cut has had a long time to grow back into the wound and it has grown back the way old wounds grow, not the way a wound from a galleon would. So. Old." She held up the finger again. "But *Paracas*? Or *Nazca*? Or someone in between with no name, no pots we've named, no mantle in a museum? That door is open. It has always been open. People keep wanting to shut it with the pottery and the pottery will not shut it."

So let me get this straight, said the fish. A hundred-and-seventy-metre sign. Two feet deep. Built to be read from nineteen kilometres out at sea. And the one question every human being asks first — who made this, and when — and the answer is, and I'm reading from the official file here: shrug.

The fish, for once, was not heckling. The fish was just saying the size of the hole out loud.

There is a version of this chapter where I tell you the consortium had it wrong, and we had it right, and the local archaeologist confirmed us at the end. That chapter is a lie, and worse, it's the lie the white

trucks were selling.

Because the consortium's whole pitch — the grant language, the corridor language, the eleven-minute boat with the laminated card — needs an answer. *Paracas, two hundred BC, ritual signal of the rayed deity*. It fits on a placard. It fits on a brochure. It fits in a funding application where the word *unknown* is a red flag and the word *Paracas* unlocks money. They were not evil. I want to be very careful here, because they were not evil. The woman who ran their documentation team had been doing this for thirty years and loved these lines the way you love something you are afraid you will lose, and she wanted to wrap the Candelabra in a date the way the Paracas wrapped their dead, in something fine and final and protective.

But a date you don't have is not protection. It's a guess in a frame.

Inés would not give them the date because she did not have the date because the date does not exist. And she would not give them a *good guess* dressed as the date, which is what they actually wanted, because she had watched, all her working life, the way a guess in a frame on a wall stops being a question and becomes a fact, and then becomes a brand, and then becomes a fence, and then nobody is allowed to stand in front of it and wonder anymore because wondering is bad for the brand.

"They want me to write *circa 200 BC* on the form," she told us, the last evening, on the seawall, the bay gone violet and the wind picking up the way it does at dusk here, off the cold water, hard enough to lean on. "They have asked four times. Each time more politely. The last time with a number on a different piece of paper." She watched the water. "I have written *undated* on the form. It is the truest word I have. They have sent it back twice and underlined it in red, as if I had made a mistake."

"It is a mistake," I said, "to them. *Undated* doesn't unlock anything."

"No," she said. "It only keeps the door open." She turned and looked at me, and I think she had taken my measure days before and was only now telling me the result. "You want to solve it. I have watched you wanting to solve it. You are good — you read the slope, you read the sightline, you read the salt. You read the way the trident wants to be seen from the water and not the land. That is real reading and I respect it." A beat. "And you would write *Paracas* on the form if I let

you, because the click feels like the truth. The click is not the truth. The click is only the click.”

I didn’t say anything. There was nothing to say that wasn’t true and small.

“The honest thing on that hill,” Inés said, “is a sign a hundred and seventy metres long, cut by people we cannot name, in a year we cannot reach, aimed at a sea they did not return from to tell us why. That is what is actually there. Everything else is us, talking, on a wall, at dusk.” She stood, and pulled her jacket against the wind. “I would rather hand you the real thing than a comfortable thing. The real thing is the hole. The hole is honest. Keep it open.”

Out past the breakers a single fishing boat was running for the bay, late, low in the water, its light coming on. It would round the point soon, and when it did, the man at the tiller would lift his eyes to the dark hill where the great three-armed sign was already lost to the night — and use it anyway, the way men here have always used it, to know exactly where he was.

But that was tomorrow’s chapter.

Tonight there was only the cardboard tray, and the sherds that touched no one, and the truest word on the form, underlined twice in someone else’s red: *undated*.

No maker. No year. A hundred and seventy metres of certainty about *what it is*, and not one honest inch of *who*, or *when*.

The door wasn’t locked.

It was just standing open, in the wind, where it had always been — waiting for the kind of person who can leave a door open without needing to walk through it.

We were not, yet, that kind of person. But we were learning the smell of the air on the far side.

Chapter 13 — The Wink: A Signal Aimed at the Sea

The boat smelled of diesel and fish-guts and sun-cooked rubber, and that was before Reyes cut the engine and let us drift.

“There,” she said, and pointed without looking, because she didn’t need to look. She’d done this a thousand times. “Now you see it.”

We turned. The Paracas Peninsula was a long, low, biscuit-coloured animal lying down in the haze, and out of its northern flank, as if someone had pressed three enormous fingers into wet clay and pulled them slowly toward heaven, rose the Candelabra.

Nobody said anything for a moment. Even the fish — we kept a little resin cichlid suction-cupped to the wheelhouse window, a heckling mascot we’d carried since Chile, who under his breath had opinions about everything — even the fish held his tongue.

Then Mara, our LENS, lowered the camera she’d had glued to her eye since we left the jetty.

I noticed because she never does that.

“From the land it’s nothing,” she said. “I drove past the headland yesterday. You can’t read it. You can’t even tell it’s a shape.”

“You weren’t meant to,” Reyes said.

Let’s do this properly, because the Candelabra deserves it.

A hundred and seventy metres tall. Sixty wide. A trident, a candelabra, a tree, a glyph — pick your noun, they all fit and none of them stick —

cut into the hardened, salt-laced slope of the peninsula above Pisco Bay. The official story, the careful one, the one the textbooks tell with their hands folded: it is *loosely* Paracas. The Paracas people worked this coast around two centuries before Christ, buried their dead in fabulous textiles, knew the desert and the sea. Pottery of their style turns up near the figure. Some scholars tie the Candelabra to them. Others reach a little further south and east and link it to the Nazca lines, the famous ones, the hummingbird and the monkey and the spider.

That's the respectable account, and every word of it is hedged, and the hedging is the honest part.

Because here is the thing the brochures skip: **nobody has ever dated it**. Not the figure. Not once. The pottery is dated — pottery's easy, pottery has carbon in its slip and context in its sherds — and the pottery whispers *circa 200 BC* from somewhere on the hillside *nearby*. But a pot beside a glyph is not a glyph. A coin in a field is not a cathedral. The link is assumed, sensible, unproven. The Candelabra floats. A hundred and seventy metres of intention, carved with enormous labour, and we cannot say who held the

Chapter 14 — What Is It For: The Line to the Horizon

The boat was called *Rosa de Pisco* and she smelled of diesel, fish, and a tobacco somebody had smoked three captains ago. Her engine was a single-cylinder Lister that fired with a sound like a fist hitting a door, and when it caught, the whole hull shuddered and then settled into a heartbeat you felt in your teeth.

Don Aurelio owned her. He was maybe sixty, maybe seventy — the sun out here does arithmetic with a man's face that nobody can audit — and he stood at the tiller with one bare foot braced against a thwart, looking not at us but at the water ahead of his bow, reading something in it I could not see.

"He says," Inés translated, "that you should sit down before you fall down and he has to fish you out, and you are not a fish, so it would be a waste of a net."

Inés Quispe Aragón had not warmed to us in three days. She had merely stopped actively waiting for us to leave. That was its own kind of welcome. She was the archaeologist from the regional office, Afro-Peruvian on her father's side, *paracaseña* on her mother's, and she knew this coast the way I know the grammar of a language I dream in — not as facts, but as the shape facts make when you stop staring at them.

We sat down. All of us. Even Mara, who had been standing in the bow with her camera already at her eye, framing the peninsula as it slid

past, that long pale spine of land where the Candelabra waited.

“Lower,” Jakobus said to her. Quiet. Not an order. He was sitting amidships with his hands loose between his knees, looking like a sack of tools somebody had left in a boat, which is roughly how he always looked. “Not yet. Watch with your eyes first. The camera’s allowed later.”

Mara lowered it. Her jaw did a thing. The Lens does not like being told when to look. But she lowered it, and she watched, and that was the whole point of her being here, and she knew it, and she hated it, and she did it.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and you should hold it the way Don Aurelio held his tiller — with respect, and without illusions.

The Paracas Candelabra is a geoglyph cut into the north face of the Paracas Peninsula. Three prongs, a hundred and seventy metres tall, sixty wide. A trident, a candelabra, a cactus, depending on who’s squinting. It is loosely — *loosely* — associated with the Paracas culture, the people who buried their dead in those astonishing mantles, the weavers, the trepanners, the long-skulled ancestors of this stretch of coast. The textbook line is that it belongs to that world: ritual, symbolic, a sign laid down for reasons we file under “religion” because that’s the drawer we open when we don’t know.

It is sometimes mentioned in the same breath as the Nazca lines, two hundred kilometres south. Same family of behaviour: people deciding to write very large on the surface of the earth. The Candelabra is the coastal cousin, the one that faces the sea.

That’s the story. Skeptics like it because it’s modest. It asks nothing of you. It does not require lost civilisations or visitors from elsewhere. It is a thing some people made, for reasons people have, and the reasons are gone the way reasons go.

I want to be fair to that story. I held it. It got us this far.

Now the potato.

We had tried to make one. Up the coast, on a stretch of crust the office let us scratch at, with permission and a string grid and Tomás running the levels off the total station like the systems-minded saint he is. Tomás is the other one whose brain is wired sideways and useful for it — he can hold a whole survey in his head as a single object, rotate it, find the error before the error happens. He'd planned our little glyph to the centimetre.

The crust beat us anyway.

You don't cut the Candelabra. You *fight* the ground for it. The peninsula's surface is a saline hardpan, salt-cemented, set like a bad casting. The real glyph is cut about sixty centimetres deep — two feet — through that crust into whatever holds underneath, and the cut walls have *held*, because the salt that makes the digging hell is the same salt that locks the trench against the wind. It's not preserved despite being hard to make. It's preserved *because* it was hard to make. The difficulty is the durability.

Our trench, planned and surveyed and dug by people with steel tools and electrolytes, came out shallow and crooked and the wind had a fortnight of fun with the spoil heaps before we even finished. From the offshore angle Mara photographed it, it read as a smear. A drunk's signature. A hundred and seventy metres of *intent* is one thing to draw on paper. It is another thing entirely to put your back into the salt and have the line still be straight when you stand up.

So I held that too. The official story, and the size of the hands it would have taken to make it true.

The Lister hammered. We swung out into Pisco Bay, and the peninsula turned its face to us, and there it was.

You have to be on the water. That is the whole thing, that is the entire fact that no museum placard can give you because a placard is on land. The Candelabra is not visible from anywhere that matters on the peninsula itself. You stand beside it and you see a hillside with some channels in it. You have to push off, get the chop under you, let the land flatten into profile — and then the three arms lift out of the slope and resolve and point at the sky, and you understand, in your body and not your head, that it was never aimed at you on the shore.

It was aimed out here.

Inés watched my face. I think she'd watched a lot of faces do this. There's a particular slackness that happens, a recalibration, and she let it run its course before she spoke.

"You want to know what it's for," she said. In English now, dry as the cliff. "Everyone wants to know what it's for. The Germans wanted to know. The man with the seismograph theory wanted to know — you've read him?" I nodded. There's a fringe claim that the thing is a giant earthquake gauge. There's another that it's a beacon for sailors carrying datura, a homing mark for a hallucinogen trade. There's the Freemasonry one, the Viracocha one. I'd read all of them. They are speculations, and the honest ones admit it, and the dishonest ones don't, and either way nobody has put a date on this monument. Ever. Not once.

That's the hole, and I want to be cold about it.

There is no date for the Candelabra. None. The figure has never been directly dated by any method that survives peer review. The only number anyone can point to is the Paracas-style pottery found *near* it, which dates to around two hundred BC — and "near" is doing the heaviest lifting in archaeology. A pot beside a thing is not a pot that made the thing. The link is plausible, it is loose, and it is unconfirmed. A hundred-and-seventy-metre sign, cut deep enough to last two thousand years or two hundred, we cannot say which — undated, its makers a question, its message thrown at the open ocean.

You can check this. Go to the literature. The honest entries all say the same thing in slightly embarrassed language: *purpose and origin remain unknown*.

The fish, were there a fish in this boat heckling us, would say: *you came all this way to learn that nobody knows anything*. And the fish would be wrong, because there is a difference between nobody knowing and nobody asking the right question, and Jakobus had been waiting three days to ask his.

He didn't ask it. He never does. He just shifted on the thwart and said, to nobody, to the air, "It survives because it's a tool. Decorations get neglected. Tools get maintained."

Inés looked at him for a long moment.

Then she said something to Don Aurelio in the coastal Spanish I could mostly follow, and the old man laughed once, a single bark, and adjusted his foot on the thwart and put the bow off a few degrees, and the Candelabra slid across our view until the central prong stood up dead ahead of us, vertical, a finger pointing down out of the hill into the sea, and he held it there, the boat aligned to the figure like a sight to a target.

“He is taking us in,” Inés said. “The way his father took him. Watch.”

She didn’t lecture. That’s the thing I keep coming back to. She gave us the histories the way you’d hand someone a rope — only as much as they could hold, and only when they needed it.

The old people, she said, didn’t talk about the Candelabra as a message. That was the foreigners’ word. *Mensaje*. To the families who’d fished this bay back past anyone’s memory, it was *la marca* — the mark. You came in off the deep water at the end of a day with your hold heavy and the light going, and the coast here is a liar; it folds, it false-faces, the headlands stack up and hide the channel, and a tired man in a falling sea makes the wrong turn and finds the rocks. But the mark doesn’t move. The mark is two feet deep in salt and it has not moved in anyone’s grandfather’s grandfather’s life. You put the prong on your bow and you follow it and it walks you home through the only safe water in the bay.

“Whether the people who cut it meant that,” Inés said, “I will not tell you. I don’t know. Nobody knows.” She let the salt wind take the words. “I’m not going to give you a meaning I can’t prove. The consortium wants a meaning. They want a plaque. *Ancient Maritime Religious Symbol of the Paracas People* — something you can sell a ticket under. I won’t sign it. The day I sign it, it stops being a question, and the day it stops being a question, it stops being alive, and then it’s only a thing on a hill.”

Mara had the camera up now. Jakobus hadn’t stopped her. The light had gone amber and then deeper, the prongs catching it, the salt crust holding a glow that the surrounding rock didn’t, so that the whole figure floated a half-shade brighter than the hill it was cut into — a thing built, again, *to be read in this exact light, from this exact water*, by people doing this exact thing. She shot it and shot it and

then, without being told, she lowered the camera and just watched the old man's bare foot adjust on the thwart, and that was the photograph she'd carry, the one with no negative.

We came in on the mark. The water under us changed — I felt it more than saw it, the swell smoothing, the chop dropping away, the channel opening like a held breath. Don Aurelio never looked at a chart, never touched the little GPS bolted to the gunwale and furred with salt and plainly dead. He looked at the central prong, and he kept it on the bow, and the *Rosa de Pisco* walked herself home through the safe water on a line two thousand years old, or two hundred, undated, unclaimed, and entirely, stubbornly *working*.

Jakobus didn't say *it's a navigation beacon*. He's too careful for that, and so am I, and so, in the end, was the only person on the boat with the standing to say it, and she declined.

What he said, as the bow swung in toward the lights of the little harbour and the engine dropped to a mutter, was quieter than that, and he said it to Inés, not to us, which was correct.

"You don't need to know who made it," he said. "You know what it does. Every evening it does it. That's not a relic. A relic just sits there being old. This thing's still got a *job*."

Inés didn't answer right away. Don Aurelio brought us alongside the mole with the gentleness of a man parking a car he's driven for forty years, and tied off, and looked back at the peninsula one more time — the mark fading now as the last light left the prongs, going back to being a hillside with channels in it, asleep until the next boat needed it.

"You want me to tell you it's a beacon," Inés said. "It would be a clean ending for your book."

"It would," Jakobus agreed.

"The pottery's two hundred BC and it might mean nothing. We don't know who cut it. We don't know if the people who cut it ever once thought about a tired man bringing a boat in at dusk, or whether that's just what we *do* with it now, because it's there and it works and the sea doesn't care what you meant." She stepped up onto the

mole, surefooted, and turned back, and the harbour light caught her face. "Both can be true. That's allowed. You're permitted to leave the question standing in the wind. People forget that's allowed."

She didn't tell us what it was for.

She showed us what it *did*, and then she handed it back to the bay, the way you'd hand a rope back to the person who'd lent it — coiled, returned, still good for the next time someone came in off the deep water at the end of the day, needing a line to the horizon to follow home.

Mara was looking at the dark peninsula. The camera hung at her chest, switched off.

"Don't," Jakobus said, before she could lift it.

She didn't.

Chapter 15 — The Consortium's Offer

The offer arrived over ceviche, which is its own small genius. Nobody refuses a man who has already bought the leche de tigre.

We were in Paracas town, in a place with plastic chairs and a tin roof that ticked as it cooled, and the consortium had sent its best face. Her name was Dr. Ximena Roca-Valdés, and I want to be honest about her the way the rest of you should be honest about people you are about to disagree with: she was good. She had spent eleven years getting the geoglyph onto a protection register that actually carried penalties. She had personally chased two looters off the peninsula in a borrowed truck. When she said *we are losing it*, she meant it the way you mean it about a relative.

“Three trenches were cut by motorbikes last dry season,” she said. “Tourists. They want a photo with the trident behind them, so they ride up the slope and the crust breaks, and the crust is the only reason it’s survived two thousand years.” She set her phone on the wet table, screen up, a drone shot of the hillside. From above you could see the tire scars like stitches that hadn’t healed. “Every wheel takes a century off the thing.”

Mara — the LENS — had her camera in her lap, off, which for her is a form of listening. She glanced at the photo and then away, the way she does when an image is doing work she’d rather not let it do.

“So you fence it,” I said.

“So we manage it.” Roca-Valdés had a way of correcting you without making it feel like a correction. “Permits. Viewing boats only, at

fixed distance. No drones except licensed. A research cordon." She turned the phone toward me, slid it the last few centimetres across the table so it sat in front of my plate like a check. "And a partnership. Your survey is the best non-invasive read anyone's done. Your route mapping is — frankly — better than anything our ministry funds. We'd like the data."

There it was. Not a grab. A handshake.

"In exchange for?"

"Access. The cordon, opened for you. The boat schedule, ours, whenever you want it. And a credit line on the interpretive material." She let that one land. Interpretive material is museum-speak for the placards, the signs, the laminated story a hundred thousand people will read in a hot bus and never question. "You'd help write what the Candelabra *is*."

Here is the official story, and I want to give it the full weight it deserves, because Roca-Valdés was carrying it like a stretcher.

The Paracas Candelabra is a geoglyph on the north face of the peninsula, looking out over Pisco Bay: roughly 170 metres tall, sixty wide, three great prongs reaching up the slope like a trident, or a tree, or a branched candlestick, depending on which century's eyes you brought. It is cut, not scraped — a trench gone down something like two-thirds of a metre into a soil so hardened with salt that the wind has filed it for two millennia and barely smudged the edges. Most desert lines you can erase with an afternoon and a leaf-blower. This one was built to argue with the weather and win.

It is, loosely, called Paracas. The culture that buried its dead in the dunes nearby, wrapped in those impossible woven mantles, in colours that still hold. Paracas-style pottery turns up in the area dated to around 200 BC. The textbook draws a soft line from the pots to the trident and calls it a working hypothesis, the way you'd label a path on a map you hadn't walked: *probably*.

That's the story. It's a fine story. It's also — and this is the part Roca-Valdés would say out loud before I could, because she was that kind of honest — held together with the word *probably*.

"No one has dated it," she said, before the ceviche was even half gone. She said it the way a surgeon names the thing on the scan. "I want to be clear with you, because I respect you. The pottery is dated. The pottery is *near*. There is no confirmed link between the pottery and the cut in the hill." She tapped the table. "Two hundred BC is a fact about ceramics. It is not a fact about that."

She pointed her chin up the slope, toward where the trident sat invisible behind the tin roof, holding its silence.

Kee had been quiet, which with Kee is not the same as absent. Kee is our systems reader — the one who looks at a thing and sees its rule before its shape, who once described a cathedral as "a machine for making sound take longer to leave." Kee had a paper napkin and was drawing the cross-section of a trench, over and over, the depth, the salt, the angle of repose.

"You can't recreate it," Kee said. Not to be rude. As a measurement.

"We tried," I said, for Roca-Valdés's benefit, because she should know what we'd already learned the hard way. Up the coast we'd staged our own line — surveyor's stakes, a string grid, a GPS rover, four of us with mattocks and a permit and the smug confidence of people who own laser levels. We'd cut a trident a tenth the size into a flat above a fishing village. It took a day and a half. It looked like a child's drawing of a fork. The salt crust we'd hoped would hold our edges was thinner there, and a single night of the *paracas* wind — the wind the place is named for, the one that comes up the bay like a hand wiping a slate — softened our lines to suggestions. By the second evening our trident looked like something a tide had left.

Two feet deep. Across 170 metres. By hand, in salt, with no view of your own work because you're standing inside the line you're trying to keep straight, and the only people who could ever check it were out on the water, nineteen kilometres off, where you would never stand.

That's the part that gets into your sleep. Not who. *How*. You cut a sign you cannot see corrected. You aim it at a horizon you cannot occupy. You build it for an eye you have to imagine.

Kee tore the napkin in half along the trench line. "It's not for the maker," Kee said. "It's never once been for the maker."

The argument we had after Roca-Valdés left went the way our arguments go, which is to say sideways and with snacks.

"Take the deal," said Tomas, who handles money and is therefore the one allowed to say the unsentimental thing. "We get the boat. We get the cordon. We get the best read in the world and it goes on the sign, and the sign is true, and the bikes stop riding up the crust. What exactly is the harm?"

"The harm," said Mara, "is that the sign says one thing."

"Signs do that. That's the job of a sign."

"And then it's done." Mara had the camera up now, not shooting, just holding it like a worry stone. "Two thousand years it's been a question. You laminate an answer onto the rail and it's a fact. Kids read it on the bus. *The Paracas people made it as a sign for sailors*. And it might be true. But the word *probably* dies on that placard, and *probably* is the only honest word anyone's got."

"You'd rather it got ridden into mud than printed wrong?"

"I'd rather we not be the ones who printed it," she said.

And here is where I have to confess my own crime, because the rule of this whole enterprise is that the narrator doesn't get to be clean.

I wanted it.

Not the deal. The *answer*. I'd been reading routes my whole life — it's the thing my wiring does instead of the things it can't, the maps assembling themselves behind my eyes whether I ask or not. Give me old paths and I see the logic that joined them before I see anything else. And I'd been standing at the edge of this one for weeks, the sightline from the trident running out across Pisco Bay, the way the cardinal arm pointed not at anything on land but down the old sea road, the lanes the *balsa* rafts ran on currents older than the pottery. I could feel the shape of the function the way you feel a word in a language you half-speak — right there, almost said. I wanted to be the one to say it. I wanted to close my hand around it and hold it up and have it be *mine*, the read nobody had managed, the pattern I'd seen that the textbook hadn't.

That hunger has a face it wears that looks exactly like generosity. *Let me help. Let me give you the answer.* It is the most dangerous thing I carry, and it does not feel dangerous. It feels like being good at my job.

Jakobus, who had said nothing the entire meal, who had eaten his ceviche slowly and watched the slope the way you watch a person you're trying not to interrupt, finally spoke. He didn't look at me. He looked at the hill.

"Whose is it to say," he asked, "what it's for?"

Not rhetorical. He doesn't do rhetorical. He genuinely wanted the answer named, out loud, so the table would have to hear itself answer.

Nobody said *ours*.

The fish — there is always a fish, every chapter has one, the smart-mouth in the back of your skull who refuses to let anything be holy — the fish chose this moment to pipe up in my head with: *if it's so undated, maybe nobody made it, maybe the salt just did a trident, ever think of that, genius?*

And the answer to the fish is no, the salt did not do a trident, the salt does not do bilateral symmetry across 170 metres with a two-foot trench, and you know it, and the reason the fish is allowed to ask is that the asking keeps me honest about what I actually know. Which is: less than I want to. Which is: the pottery is near. Which is: *probably*. The fish heckles. The fish does not get to preach, and neither, God help me, do I.

We found Doña Inés the next morning, where she always is, on the malecón with the boat men, and we told her about the offer because she had a right to it that nobody at the ceviche table did.

Inés Quispe Manuyama is the coastal archaeologist who'd been letting us hang around her like stray cats. Afro-Peruvian on her mother's side, Paracas-fisher families going back as far as anyone's bothered to count on her father's. She'd spent her career between two worlds that both wanted to use her — the universities that wanted her access, the town that wanted her to keep the universities honest. She

had heard every theory about her trident, including the funny ones. *Beacon for sailors carrying datura. Freemason eye. Viracocha's staff. A giant seismograph.* She could recite them in a flat voice that was its own review.

She listened to the part about the placards and went still in a way I'd learned to read as anger held on a short leash.

"They asked you to write what it is," she said.

"They asked us to help write it."

"With my boat men sitting right there." She wasn't looking at us. She was looking at Hugo, the old man whose boat we'd been on, who was untangling line with hands that knew the bay better than any chart. "He's used that trident his whole life. His father did. You come in past the headland, the bay opens, the wind's wrong, you can't see the harbour mouth — and there it is on the slope, *the three fingers*, and you know exactly how far off you are and which way to come round." She finally turned to us. "Ask him what it's *for* and he'll tell you. It's for coming home. That's not a theory. That's Tuesday."

Then she did the thing she always did, the thing that put us in our place gently and completely.

"But ask him who *made* it, or *why* they put a trident and not a fish, or whether it was ever meant to do for them what it does for him — and he'll tell you he doesn't know. And he'll be telling you the truth. And it's *his* truth to tell. Not yours to print." She let that sit. "The consortium wants the not-knowing to stop, because not-knowing doesn't fit on a sign and signs sell boat tickets. I understand them. I even like Ximena. But the day that placard goes up, the question stops being ours. It becomes the answer the foreigners helped write." She looked at me directly then, and I felt the hunger in me go cold and small and seen. "And the people who've read that hill their whole lives become tourists at it."

She'd out-read me before I'd even finished wanting it. She knew what I'd been reaching for, the function half-formed behind my eyes, and she'd named the exact price of saying it out loud. The function might even be the right one. That wasn't the point. The point was whose hand it lived in.

We turned the deal down that evening, by message, which is a coward's medium and the right one when you don't trust your own face. Tomas wrote it because Tomas writes the unsentimental things best, and he kept it clean: grateful, declined, the data is ours and stays ours, and we'd back any cordon Inés and the town and the ministry agreed on *together* — but we wouldn't write the sign, and we wouldn't take the access in trade for our read.

Roca-Valdés wrote back within the hour. One line. *Then you'll have to read it from the public boats like everyone else. The water's free. Good luck with the wind.*

Which was, I have to say, a hell of a thing to lose an argument to. She wasn't wrong. The wind was not going to be on our side. The cordon was real and it would hold and the best angle on the trident now belonged to a paying ferry on a fixed schedule, same as the German backpackers, same as the cruise tenders. We'd traded the laser-level view for a plastic seat on a boat we didn't control.

Mara lowered her camera as the message came in. Just set it in her lap and looked at the dark slope where the trident waited, invisible, two feet deep in the salt, aimed at a horizon none of us could stand on, holding its *probably* like a breath it had been holding since before the pottery cooled.

"Good," she said.

Out on the water Hugo's boat was coming in, a single light, finding the bay the way it always found the bay.

We'd kept the question open. Tomorrow we'd have to earn it from a tourist boat, in the wrong wind, with everyone else.

Jakobus stood at the rail beside me and looked at the hill the way he looks at any made thing — not asking who, not asking when. Asking the only question he ever asks.

"Tomorrow," he said, "we find out what it's *for*."

He meant from Inés. He meant from Hugo. He meant: not from us.

Chapter 16 — Inside the Chase: Patterns and Pressure

The hostel in Pisco had a kitchen, and the kitchen had a table, and on the table, by ten at night, there was a war.

Not a loud one. Tomas didn't do loud. He did paper. He'd taped four sheets together into one ungainly square and was filling it, corner to corner, with the Candelabra's geometry — the splayed central shaft, the two arms curling off it like a tuning fork that had been to art school. He'd measured everything we'd been allowed to measure and a few things we hadn't. Now he was looking for the rule. The thing underneath. Tomas believed, with the whole architecture of his being, that a made thing carried the logic of its making, and that if you stared long enough, the logic surfaced like a fish coming up for a fly.

I knew the look. I'd been wearing the look myself, in the truck, on the boat, in the long flat hours of the Atacama where the road was so straight it felt rude.

"It's a vesica," Tomas said. "Or it wants to be. Look — if the arms came off here instead of here, the proportions would be cleaner. So either they couldn't do clean, or clean wasn't the point."

"Clean wasn't the point," said the Lens, from the doorway. She had a beer she wasn't drinking and a camera she wasn't shooting, which for her was a kind of fasting.

"That's not an argument," Tomas said. "That's a mood."

“It’s both.” She came and sat. “You’re trying to find the equation they used. They didn’t use an equation. They used a hillside, a horizon, and a job that needed doing. You’re solving for elegance. The elegance is yours.”

Tomas’s pencil stopped. He didn’t look up, which was how he disagreed with you while keeping the door open.

Here is the official story, and I want to put it down straight, the way you’d lay a tool on a clean cloth, because it’s a good story and the people who built it built it honestly. The Paracas Candelabra is a geoglyph on the northern face of the peninsula, roughly a hundred and seventy metres tall, sixty wide, a three-pronged form cut into the hardened, saline soil overlooking Pisco Bay. It’s loosely associated with the Paracas culture. It’s sometimes mentioned in the same breath as the Nazca lines, a few hundred kilometres south, with their hummingbird and their spider and their famously long straight runs. The official reading is symbolic, ritual, cultural — a sign, a marker, a statement made by a coastal people who knew exactly what they were doing.

And the makers did know what they were doing, which is the part the picture postcards leave out. The Candelabra isn’t scraped, the way most desert geoglyphs are. It’s cut — about sixty centimetres deep, two feet, into a crust that the salt has set like a poor man’s concrete. That depth is the whole game. The Nazca lines are surface drawings, vulnerable, lovingly re-walked by the people who tend them. The Candelabra is a trench, lined in places with stone, knifed down into ground that the sea air keeps re-cementing. It was built to last in a way the others weren’t. Somebody wanted this one to be readable for a long, long time.

We knew this because we’d tried to make one.

Not the real one — we’re not animals. A test patch, on a stretch of consortium-adjacent scrubland where we’d been granted, with great ceremony and a signed form, the right to scrape. We laid out a single arm at one-tenth scale. We had a survey-grade GPS, two rolls of mason’s line, a drone overhead calling out drift, and the collective intelligence of people who navigate for a living.

The line wandered. Not a lot. Enough. At full scale that wander would be the length of a bus. And ours was scraped, surface-level,

the easy version — we hadn't even attempted the cut, the two-foot trench through salt-set ground, by hand, with whatever you'd have had two thousand years ago, on a slope, in the wind, while keeping the proportions true to a shape you could only properly see from a boat nineteen kilometres out that you yourself would never be standing on.

That's the potato. That's the thing that doesn't go down easy. The official story says *symbolic sign, ritual marker*, and it says it correctly, and then you go out with all your toys and you cannot make a clean arm at one-tenth scale, and the word *symbolic* starts to feel like a label on a box you haven't opened.

The fish — and there's always a fish, the heckler in the back of the room who keeps you honest — the fish says: *sure, but they had centuries and you had a long weekend*. And the fish is right. That's the point. They had centuries and a culture and a reason. We have a long weekend and a question. The gap between those two things is exactly the size of what we don't know.

"It bothers you," the Lens said to me. Not Tomas. Me.

"What bothers me."

"That you can't put it in a sentence yet."

I'd been pretending to read Tomas's paper. I stopped pretending.

The thing about my particular wiring — and I'll only say this once, because I don't like making a museum exhibit of it — is that I read routes the way some people read faces. A signal, a route, a system of marks across a landscape: it resolves in me whether I want it to or not. I see the path before I see the place. It's how I've made a living and it's why I'm useful on a trip like this one and it is also, on a night like this one, a kind of itch I can't reach. Because a sign demands to be read, and I am built to read it, and there is a 170-metre sign aimed at the sea whose maker I cannot name, whose date I cannot fix, whose purpose floats. The undated thing. The one firm date in the whole business comes from Paracas-style pottery found *nearby* — around two hundred BC — and nobody has ever confirmed the pottery has anything to do with the geoglyph. You could put those potsherds next to the trench and the trench would shrug. No maker's mark. No charcoal layer to carbon-date. A monumental signal with no return

address.

Every instinct I have wants to close the gap. Wants to walk into the consortium's prefab and say *here, I've read it, here's your answer, now leave it open*. The irony being that closing it would do exactly what they want to do, just from the other direction.

"You're doing the face," the Lens said.

"There's no face."

"There's the face."

Tomas, without looking up: "There's the face."

I laughed, which let some of the air out of the room.

The consortium, to be fair to them — and we keep being fair to them, it's a discipline — were not monsters. We'd met three of them now. A heritage ministry liaison who genuinely teared up talking about the peninsula. A private partner from the tourism side, sharp, kind, the sort who remembers your name and your coffee order. A young archaeologist, consortium-funded, who clearly thought we were diletantes and was clearly half right. They wanted to protect the Candelabra. They wanted barriers and walkways and an interpretive centre and a clean line in a brochure that said *what it is*. They wanted the question answered so the answer could be guarded.

And you cannot guard a maybe. That's the trouble. A maybe has no perimeter.

"They asked me again," I said. "For the survey data. The depth profiles, the drift logs from the test patch, the lot. In exchange for inside-the-fence access to the real face."

The kitchen got quiet in the specific way that means everyone already knew and was waiting to see what I'd do with it.

"That's a good trade," Tomas said carefully. He meant it as a fact, not a recommendation. With Tomas you learn the difference. "Inside-the-fence. We'd get the cut depth measured properly. We could maybe settle the stone-lining question."

"We could."

"You're going to say no."

"I'm going to say no."

He nodded slowly, filing it. Then, because he was Tomas and the truth came out of him sideways: "I want to say yes. I want the numbers. I think the numbers would be beautiful." A pause. "I also think the numbers aren't mine to take in exchange for the thing that gets them. That's — those are two different wants and they're both real and I don't like it."

That's the cleanest thing anyone said all night. Two real wants, both true, neither cancelling the other. The crew, if we're anything, are a collection of people who were never allowed to stop watching the room, and so we watch it, and so we know when a good deal is a bad one. Inside the fence is where the question gets closed. We'd be buying our look at the trench with the very data that would let them say *solved* and bolt the gate behind us.

The Lens hadn't said anything for a while, which from her meant something was coming.

She set her camera on the table. Lens-down, which she never does. The thing has a glass eye and she keeps it pointed at the world the way a sentry keeps a rifle, and she put it face-first against Tomas's taped-up paper like she was putting a horse in its stall.

"I didn't shoot the test patch," she said.

"You shot the test patch. I saw you shoot the test patch."

"I shot it and I deleted it. Our wobbly little arm. The bus-length wander." She turned the beer bottle a quarter turn. "I deleted it because the only thing it was good for was to make us look humble, and humble is a pose, and a pose is a lie I take very nice pictures of."

Out at sea, a long way off, a boat horn went, low and unhurried.

"Here's what I keep coming back to," she said. "We came down this coast to read these things before someone else locks them up. Fine. Noble. But there is a version of us that is just a quieter, better-dressed version of the consortium. We want to fix the meaning too. We want to be the ones who *saw it right*. And I've got a camera that turns everything I point it at into a story I'm telling, and I am very, very good at it, and I have started to wonder whether the most honest

thing I can do at the trench tomorrow is not lift the camera at all.”

That landed differently in each of us, the way a stone dropped in still water reaches different shores at different times.

“You’d cover it,” I said. “If you didn’t lift it. There’d be no record.”

“There’s a fisherman who uses that hill to find the bay,” she said. “There’s a woman who’s been studying this peninsula since before any of us could find Peru on a map. There’s a horizon and a piece of ground and a thing that has been doing its job for two thousand years without my picture of it.” She tapped the lens-down camera. “Maybe the record isn’t the thing. Maybe the record is the thing’s *enemy*. The minute I freeze it, it stops being a sign and starts being a photograph of a sign. Past tense. Solved.”

Tomas frowned at his paper. “But you don’t actually believe that, because you keep the camera.”

“I keep the camera,” the Lens agreed, “because I haven’t worked out when to lower it. That’s the whole job, Tomas. Not whether to lower it. When.”

I want to be honest about where I sat in that conversation, because the easy version of me is the wayfinder who keeps the others wise, and that’s not who was at the table. The one at the table was the one who wanted the answer so badly his hands itched. Who had stood under the Atacama Giant three weeks earlier — a hundred and nineteen metres of human figure scraped and stoned onto a bare hill, head crowned with rays that the wayfinder up there had let us watch line up with the moon’s setting, without once telling us that’s what they were *for* — and who had thought, even then, even at the foot of the largest such figure on Earth with a man beside me who’d been reading this pampa his whole life: *I could write this up. I could close it.*

And the Giant’s rays are a checkable thing, that’s what makes the itch unbearable. Briones published it. *Antiquity*, 2006, peer-reviewed, real: the rays may work as a seasonal marker, a lunar gnomon, the moon setting along the crown to call the rains, to time the planting. Published. Unproven. Sitting there in the literature like a door that’s neither open nor shut, that nobody’s been able to push either way in twenty years, and I’d stood under it and wanted to be the one to

push.

The wayfinder hadn't pushed. He'd shown us the caravan path, where the figure swings into view as you come up off the salt. He'd let the moon do what the moon does. And he'd kept the *for* in his own mouth, where it belonged, because it was his to give or not give, and that restraint had cost him nothing and had cost me, watching, a great deal — because it was the thing I cannot do and he did it like breathing.

"He could've told us," I said, out loud, not meaning to. "Up at the Giant. He could've just said yes or no on Briones. He knows. He has to know."

"He didn't have to know," the Lens said. "He had to be the one who decides whether you find out."

"Same thing."

"It's the opposite thing."

The boat horn again. Tomas had gone very still over his paper, and when he spoke it was in the flat, careful register he uses when he's said the true thing to himself first and is now letting us have it.

"We're outsiders," he said. "I keep doing the math like it's mine to do. It's not my equation. It was never going to be my equation. The reason I can't find the rule is that the rule isn't a rule, it's a relationship — between people and a coast — and I'm not in that relationship. I'm a guy at a kitchen table with four taped-up sheets." He smoothed them flat with one hand, almost tenderly. "The most I can do is get the *measurements* right so that when she" — the archaeologist, he meant, the woman who'd been studying this since before Peru was a dot to us — "when she decides what to say, she's saying it onto clean paper. That's the whole of my job. Not to solve it. To hold the paper steady."

Nobody answered for a while. The kitchen ticked. Somewhere down the hall a tap ran and stopped.

I looked at the three of us — the deleted photograph, the equation that wasn't ours, the wayfinder who'd kept the *for* and the archaeologist who would do the same, and the boat out there in the dark using a two-thousand-year-old sign to find the mouth of the bay, right now,

tonight, the way it had been used the whole time we'd been arguing about what it meant.

"Then that's the deal," I said. "We read it. We measure it. We get every number we can get honestly. And we let them speak last. The wayfinder. Her. Whoever stands on the right ground." I pushed the consortium's offer-sheet, which had been sitting under my elbow this whole time, into the middle of the table where we could all see it. "And this we burn."

"We don't have to burn it," Tomas said.

"I want to burn it."

"You're doing the face," the Lens said.

"I'm allowed the face."

She picked up the camera. Turned it over in her hands. Did not lift it. Set it down again, glass to the table, and left it there — and that, more than anything anyone said, was the chapter's whole turn: the weapon laid flat, on purpose, by the only one of us who knew exactly what it could do.

In the morning we'd go out to the bay. The archaeologist would meet us on the water. And whatever the Candelabra was — beacon, marker, prayer, infrastructure, a call across nineteen kilometres of sea to people we'd never name — it would still be there, undated, unclaimed, doing its job, waiting for someone whose right it was to say so.

It wasn't going to be us. That was the relief and the ache of it, in equal measure, and we sat with both, and let the moon do what the moon does.

Chapter 17 — Night and Tide: The Living Mark

The pampa at Cerro Unitas does not get dark the way other places get dark. It goes black at the ground and stays bright overhead, so that for a while you walk through a layer of nothing with the whole machinery of the sky bolted above your head. No moon yet. Vásquez had timed us for that — the long dusk first, then the wait.

We had argued about whether to come at all.

Not out loud. The crew doesn't argue out loud anymore; we argue in the spaces where someone doesn't say a thing. Marisol — the LENS — had spent the drive with the camera in her lap, lens cap on, which for her is a sentence. Tem had spent it doing the arithmetic of moonrise against the ridge azimuth on the back of a fuel receipt, because Tem cannot hold a question in their head without converting it to a number first; that's not a quirk, that's the load-bearing wall of the whole operation. And I had spent it telling myself I would not, tonight, try to *finish* anything.

That was the deal I'd made with myself somewhere around Paracas. I'm the one who reads routes. Show me three marks on a landscape and I'll give you the path between them before I've thought about it, the way some people hum. It's a good trick. It's also a hunger, and hunger doesn't know when it's full.

Vásquez stopped us at the foot of the slope. The Giant rose above — a hundred and nineteen metres of figure, arms held out from the body, the great square head with its rays standing off it like a comb of light against a hill that has not seen rain in living memory. By day it's a diagram. At night, lit only by stars, it's a presence you feel in

the soles of your feet before you locate it with your eyes.

“You came up the wrong way before,” Vásquez said. Mild. He says the cutting things mildly. “With the drone. From the road.”

“The road’s where the access is permitted,” Tem said.

“The road’s where the consortium put the gate.” He let that sit. “The caravan came from there.” He tipped his chin south, where the land ran out flat and pale toward nothing, where you could just make out, if you knew to look, the faint braided scars of paths that animals and men had pressed into the desert over centuries. “If you want to see what it does, you stand where the people walked who needed it.”

Here is the story, told straight, because it deserves to be told straight.

The Atacama is stitched with geoglyphs — something near five thousand of them, figures and lines and herds of stylised llamas scraped and stacked across the most arid non-polar desert on the planet. Most aren’t mysterious in the spooky sense at all. They’re *signage*. They sit along the old caravan routes that carried fish and shells up from the coast and maize and wool back down, and they do what signs do: they say *this way, water there, you are not lost*. Archaeologists have mapped them against the routes for decades. It’s beautiful, unglamorous, completely real infrastructure — a highway department run by people who had no metal and no wheel and built at a scale that would make a billboard company weep.

The Giant is the king of them. Largest known prehistoric human figure anywhere. Built somewhere between AD 1000 and 1400 by Andean cultures whose names we mostly don’t have, using two techniques at once — scraping the dark surface away to show the pale ground beneath, and piling dark stones onto the pale, so the figure is drawn in both negative and positive at the same time, light against dark and dark against light, on a slope chosen so it can be seen from a long way off. The official reading is generous and sober: a deity, a shaman, a figure of authority, looking out over the pampa. A monument. A face the land wears.

Nobody serious disputes the wonder of it. The dispute is one rung up — about the *rays*.

We had tried to make our own, weeks back. I should say that plainly, because the potato never tastes the same when you only read about it.

Tem planned it like a campaign. Survey stakes, a string grid, a tablet running an app that overlaid a simple figure on the live camera feed. We chose a flat blank patch with permission, far from anything old, and we scraped. Just a stick figure. Twenty metres, nothing — a sixth the height of the Giant.

It took four of us most of a day. The arm came out crooked because the ground rolls in ways you can't feel underfoot but can absolutely see from a hundred metres back. The legs were two different lengths. Marisol photographed it from the rented drone and we stood looking at the screen, this drunken pale homunculus, and nobody said anything for a while.

The wind took the head overnight. Just the head. By the second morning the whole thing read like a smudge.

And ours was *small*, on *flat ground*, with *satellites helping us*. The Giant is six times taller, on a curving slope, drawn so that it resolves into correct human proportion only when you're standing in the right place far below — which means whoever laid it out was correcting, by eye, for perspective and slope and scale, across a figure they could never see whole while making it. People say "they just scraped lines in the dirt." Go scrape a face the size of a city block into a hillside and have it still look like a face. Then come back and say *just*.

The moon came up while we were still talking about it.

Tem saw it first — saw it on the receipt, I mean, the time matching the math, and then looked up to confirm with the actual sky like checking a sum against the back of the book. It rose off the low edge of the pampa, fat and orange and slow, and it climbed up behind the Giant's right shoulder.

"Watch the rays," Vásquez said.

This is the hole, and I want to lay it down clean and cold because it's the most honest part of the chapter.

In 2006, in the journal *Antiquity*, the Chilean archaeologist Luis Briones published a hypothesis: that the rays radiating from the Giant's head are not just a headdress or a halo but might *work*. That from the right place, along the route, at the right turn of the year, the rays line up with where the moon sets — that the figure could function as a seasonal marker, a great stone instrument tying the lunar calendar to the desert's rare and precious rains, telling the people who passed here when the season would turn. A gnomon the size of a hill.

It's peer-reviewed. It's published. It's checkable, in principle — you can stand where the path runs and you can watch and measure.

And it is not proven. It has never been nailed shut. It sits exactly there, in the open: a real, sober, documented *maybe*, the rays being undeniably real features and their use as a calendar being a question nobody has closed.

We stood on the old path and we watched the moon go up alongside that great combed head, and I did the thing I'd promised myself I wouldn't. I started fitting it. I started feeling for the alignment, the way I feel for a route, the click of *this connects to that* — and Tem, beside me, was murmuring numbers, the moon's declination this month, how it wouldn't be at its standstill extreme until years from now, how *tonight isn't the night it would line up even if Briones is right*, and I heard the hunger in my own breath and I made myself let it out slow.

"You're trying to make it say yes," Vásquez said. Not unkindly.

"I'm trying to see if it says yes."

"Same thing, the way you do it." He was quiet a moment. The fish in my head — the heckler that lives behind my sternum and refuses to let anyone get holy — observed dryly that a man who wouldn't tell us the answer sure had opinions about how we asked the question. I kept that to myself.

"My grandmother didn't need it to set against the moon to use it," Vásquez said. "She used it to know she was a day and a half from the salt flat with the brackish well. That's all. The moon is the scholars' question. The Giant—" he lifted his hand toward it, the dark figure with the pale ground glowing faintly around it now in the moonlight,

“—the Giant told you where you were and roughly when. People are still here who learned to walk by it. That’s not a maybe.”

He would not tell us whether the rays caught the moon. He told us the figure was *in use* — that he had read it as a child the way I read a junction. Whether it also kept a lunar calendar was Briones’s open file, and Vásquez left it open, deliberately, the way you leave a door you’re not going to be the one to close.

We drove north through the night and most of the next day and the day after, down the spine of the coast to Paracas, to be there for the tide.

You cannot stand on the Candelabra. That’s the first thing about it that breaks your brain. The Giant you can walk to. The Candelabra is cut into the steep northern face of the Paracas Peninsula above Pisco Bay, a hundred and seventy metres tall, sixty wide, three great prongs reaching up — and it was made to be *read from the sea*. From a boat. From as far as nineteen kilometres out on the open water it stands clear on the hillside. It faces the ocean and turns its back to the land, which is a thing you only do on purpose, and only for someone you expect to be coming from the water.

It is cut two feet deep. Not scraped — *cut*, trenched into hardened, salty soil, stones set along the trenches, so that the salt crust that forms over it locks it down against the wind that would have erased anything shallower in a season. That depth is why it’s still there. That depth is also why our recreation, days before, had been such a humbling little disaster — Marisol’s footage of it is genuinely hard to watch. We’d cut a trident a fraction of the size, by hand, into easier ground, and it came out shallow and lopsided and the offshore wind had already begun softening its edges by the time we’d boated out to look at it. From the water our sign was a scratch. The Candelabra, from the same distance, was an *announcement*.

And here is its hole, which is even more naked than the Giant’s. Nobody has dated it. Not the makers, not the year, not the meaning. The only date in the whole story is from Paracas-style pottery found *near* it — around 200 BC — and there is no confirmed link between that pottery and the carving. A hundred-and-seventy-metre sign, aimed at the sea, undated, its makers unnamed, its message unknown. People

have read it as a trident, a tree, a cactus, a beacon for sailors carrying god-knows-what. The fringe has read it as a great many other things, and those readings are fringe, and I'll leave them where they live. The plain truth is bigger than any of them: it's a billboard with the date burned off and the advertiser gone, and it still works.

Dr. Salas took us out at dusk in a fishing boat that belonged to a man named Quispe, who fishes the bay as his father did and *did not care* about our project in a way I found completely restful. The light went gold and then bronze. The bay flattened as the tide turned. And the Candelabra, which by harsh noon looks like a chalk diagram, caught the low side-light and rose off the hill in three deep shadow-lined arms, deep enough to hold the dark, and it spoke — there is no other word — it spoke across the water the way a lighthouse speaks, without saying anything you can write down.

"He's lining up on it," Salas said.

She meant Quispe. He'd throttled back and was watching the hill, then the water, then the hill, easing the bow a few degrees. Marisol lifted the camera and then, after a second, lowered it, and didn't raise it again. Some things you don't take.

"What's he doing," Tem said, very softly, the way Tem asks when the number matters more than the asker.

Salas didn't answer for a moment. The boat rocked. Then: "The same thing his grandfather did. He doesn't need it. He has the GPS in his pocket. But the channel into the cove — there's a reef. You take the Candelabra's middle arm onto a notch on the far ridge and the line takes you over the deep water and not the rock." She shrugged, and her shrug had a whole discipline in it, the refusal to say more than she knew. "Whether the ones who cut it meant *that* — meant a transit, a sailing mark — I won't tell you. I don't know. Nobody knows. You want me to guess and I'm not going to guess for your book."

The fish behind my sternum, for once, had nothing snide to say.

Quispe brought us over the deep water, on the line, the way the mark gives it, and the reef passed beneath us in the dark and we never saw it.

We sat in the cove after, engine off, the tide working under the hull. Nobody talked. Vásquez wasn't with us — he was a thousand kilometres south under his own moon — but it felt, for that stretch of silence, like the same night, like the Giant and the Candelabra were two ends of one long road and we were sitting in the middle of it where the dark pooled.

Two signs. One on a desert hill, telling travellers where and when. One on a sea-cliff, telling sailors *over here, not the rock*. Both undated where it counts, both holding their best questions open, both being read, tonight, by people who learned them the way you learn a face.

Not relics. Not riddles for us to crack and carry off.

Working signs. Lit, still, by moon and dusk and the patience of people who never stopped using them.

Salas leaned back against the gunwale and looked up at her own sign on the hill, glowing faint now in the last bronze, and she said the truest thing said on the whole journey, and she said it to herself more than to us.

"They built it to be answered," she said. "Not explained."

The tide turned under us, and carried the boat, gently, toward home.

Chapter 18 — The Last Word

The boat smelled of diesel and gutted anchovy, and Mara Quispe Villanueva was eating an orange.

She did this with the particular focus of someone who had decided, at some point in the day, that the orange mattered more than we did, and she was correct. The peel came off in one spiral and she let it hang over the gunwale and twist in the wind off Pisco Bay, and only when it dropped did she look up at the Candelabra.

We had been at sea forty minutes. The crew was arranged around the open boat in the postures of people pretending they were not seasick — the LENS forward with the camera dark in her lap, our systems-thinker Otieno wedged against the engine box with his tablet shielded from spray, and me amidships with the tide tables I'd been told, twice now, to put away.

"You keep doing the thing," Mara said.

"What thing."

"You add it up." She nodded at the tide tables. "Out loud, behind your face. You think you're quiet about it. You're not."

Across from her, in the bow, Don Esteban Mamani had said nothing for an hour. The Atacama wayfinder had flown the coast with us north from Cerro Unitas — Jakobus had paid for the seat without explaining why, and Don Esteban had accepted it the way he accepted weather, as a fact requiring no comment. He sat now with his hat low and his hands folded, looking at a sea-cut sign as though it were a brother who owed him money.

The boatman, Cusi, cut the engine.

We drifted. The bay made that sound a bay makes when the motor stops — the whole world rushing back in, water against hull, wind in the cordage, gulls a long way off doing something cruel to a fish. And there it was. There it had been the whole time, and now it was the only thing.

The Candelabra.

Let me say what it is, the way the books say it, because the books are not wrong and they have earned the saying.

It is a geoglyph. A trident, or a candelabrum, or — if you read certain pamphlets sold at the dock — the staff of Viracocha, or a homing mark for sailors carrying datura, or a *seismograph*, which is the kind of word that makes a serious archaeologist put down her orange. It is about a hundred and seventy metres tall and sixty wide, cut into the north face of the Paracas Peninsula on a slope of pale, salt-hard ground, and it faces the sea. Not the road. Not the pampa. The sea. You can pick it out from nineteen kilometres offshore, which is to say from a place where you cannot stand, where there is nothing under your feet but the cold green Humboldt and a long way down.

It is cut deep. Not scratched like the Nazca lines a few hundred kilometres south — *cut*, two feet into the crust, the trenches lined here and there with stone, and the salt in the soil has set hard around the edges and held them, year after year, against a wind that erases everything else on this coast. That is why it is still here. That is the whole trick of it. Build shallow and the wind takes you in a season. Cut deep into salt and you get to be a question for two thousand years.

If they are two thousand years. Nobody knows.

That is the part the books say quietly, in the footnote, with their hands folded like Don Esteban's. There is no date for the Candelabra. None. Not one. The Paracas culture is the usual answer and it is a good answer, and the pottery they pull out of the ground *near* it dates to around two hundred years before Christ — but the pottery is not the figure, and no one has ever connected the two with anything you could put in a journal and defend. A hundred and seventy metres of

intention, undated, unsigned, aimed at the open ocean. The largest message I have ever stood beneath, and we don't know who wrote it, or when, or to whom.

We had tried to make one. That was the potato, and it had been humbling.

Four days earlier, on a beach south of the peninsula where the heritage consortium had no jurisdiction yet, we'd marked out a trident a tenth the size. Otieno had the survey rig. We had stakes, line, a drone overhead feeding us correction, the full apparatus of people who measure for a living.

We cut it eight inches deep into sand that was not salt-hard, because we did not have two thousand years and a hillside, and by the next morning the wind had filled the trenches and smudged the arms and turned our trident into something that looked, the LENS said, "like a fork that gave up." The drone footage from above showed it best: a confident plan and a cowardly execution, the lines wandering where we'd thought them straight, the symmetry we'd been so proud of revealed as a slow drunken lean.

"They didn't have the drone," Otieno said, watching it wobble on his screen. He said it the way you'd say a number that won't reconcile.

The Candelabra does not lean. From nineteen kilometres out, with no scaffold and no aircraft and no laser, somebody put a hundred and seventy metres of line on a slope and made it true. We could not do it at seventeen.

Cusi let the boat drift to where he wanted it, the way you'd nose into a parking spot you'd used your whole life, and killed it the rest of the way with a touch of throttle.

"Now," he said. He pointed off the port bow. "You watch."

Another boat had come round the headland — a fishing launch, low and patient, returning from the anchovy grounds with its catch and a man at the stern who did not look at any of his instruments because he was looking at the hill.

At the Candelabra.

He was lining it up. We watched him do it. He held the launch on a heading that put one arm of the figure over a notch in the high ground behind it, and then he eased to port until the geometry satisfied him, and then he came in. No chart. No screen. A sign on a hillside and a man's two eyes and a thing his father had shown him, probably, the way a thing gets shown.

"There," Mara said. She had finished the orange. "That's your dating problem solved. Want to know how old it is?" She tipped her chin at the launch. "It's old enough that he's still using it."

The LENS lifted the camera. Then she stopped — caught herself with it halfway up, the lens pointed at the fisherman who had not asked to be a photograph — and lowered it again into her lap. She'd been doing that more, this last leg of the coast. Learning where the line was. The fisherman brought his launch in past us, lifted two fingers off the wheel at Cusi, and was gone toward the dock, and the LENS had taken nothing, and her face when she set the camera down was the most peaceful I'd seen it in weeks.

I had a question and I'd been holding it the whole boat ride, turning it the way I turn a word in a language I'm new to, looking for the seam.

"Mara." I kept my voice level. "Who was it for? You can see it from the sea. So it's a sign to sailors. But the people who built it couldn't get out there to check it. You can't stand nineteen kilometres offshore on dry ground. How do you aim a sign at a horizon you can't stand on?"

It was, I thought, a very good question. I am ashamed to say I thought it might be the question.

Mara looked at me with something close to fondness, which is worse than contempt.

"You aim it the same way he just came in," she said. "Backwards. You don't stand offshore. You stand *here*"—she patted the gunwale—"in a boat, on the water you already use, and you look back at the hill and you see what lines up. The notch. The high point. The shape of the

land. You've been on this water your whole life. You know what the coast looks like from out there better than you know your own hands. So you carve the mark *into* that picture. You don't aim at a horizon you can't stand on. You aim at a memory of a horizon you've stood off a thousand times."

She let that sit.

"You came at it like it's a riddle somebody set for you," she said. "It's not for you. It was never for you. It's for the man in the boat. You keep asking what it *means*. He doesn't ask what it means. He asks where it puts him."

I wrote that down. *He asks where it puts him*. Then I read it back and felt the thing I'd been feeling all coast, the itch to close the parenthesis, the hand reaching for the last bracket — and I put the pen down on top of it.

Don Esteban spoke then, for the first time since the headland, and he spoke about the Giant.

He spoke in Spanish, slowly, the way he did everything, and the wind took half of it so we leaned in, the whole boat leaning toward a man in a hat.

"In the desert," he said, "we have one too. Bigger than this. A hundred and nineteen metres, a person, standing on the hill at Unitas with the rays coming off his head." He raised both hands beside his own head, fingers spread, and for a moment he was the Giant, a small weathered Giant in a fishing boat. "The professors say it is a god. Maybe. The professors from the ministry, the ones with the fence" — the consortium; he would not say their name, none of the locals would, it was beneath saying — "they want it to be a god, because a god you can put on a poster. A god you can sell a ticket to. A god holds still."

He lowered his hands.

"There is a man, Briones, who wrote that the rays might mark the moon. Where it sets, at the turn of the year, when the rain is supposed to come." He shrugged — not dismissing it, weighing it. "Maybe that too. He wrote it carefully. He did not say *this is the answer*. He said

this could be a thing the rays do. That is an honest man. He left it open.”

The Briones hypothesis. Peer-reviewed, *Antiquity*, 2006: the rays as a possible lunar gnomon, the moon’s setting positions read off the crown to time the planting against the rare desert rain. Checkable. Unproven. Still standing open like a door nobody’s allowed to shut.

“I showed your people,” Don Esteban said, nodding at me, at Otieno, at the memory of the pampa. “I showed them the rays only sit right when you walk the old caravan road. Not from the front. Not from the air with their machine.” A small dry sound that might have been a laugh; the drone had had a bad week in the Atacama. “From the road. The road the llamas walked, carrying salt and fish and wool, for a thousand years. You stand on the road at the right moon and the rays are where they should be. So.” He spread his hands. “Is it a god? Is it a calendar? Is it a sign that says *the road is here, you are not lost, the rain is coming?*”

He waited. He genuinely waited, as though one of us might be foolish enough to answer.

Nobody was.

“It is all of those,” he said. “Or it is one. I am not going to tell you which. Not because I don’t know.” He looked at me directly, and there was the out-read, gentle and total, the thing I’d felt at every site on this coast: the floor of his knowledge was below the floor of mine, and he was standing on it comfortably while I treaded water above. “Because the not-telling is the part that’s mine to keep.”

Jakobus had not said a word the whole boat ride. He almost never did. He sat aft near Cusi with his old hands quiet on his knees, and he had spent the morning, I knew, doing the only thing he ever did — reading the made thing for what it *did*, not what it meant. He’d told me once, in the desert, with the Giant a pale figure on the dark hill: *Stop asking who made it. Ask who it was made for. A thing tells you its job before it tells you its maker.*

Now he leaned a little toward Don Esteban and Mara, and he said, quietly, so the wind almost took it:

“A waymark. A calendar. A call.” He looked at the Candelabra, then back at the sea where the fisherman had been. “Infrastructure.”

It was not a question, and it was not a claim. It was an offering, set down in the bottom of the boat between us all, for them to pick up or leave.

Mara looked at it. Then she looked at the hill, the trident cut deep in salt against a wind that took everything else, the sign a hundred and seventy metres tall aimed at a horizon its makers had only ever known from a boat, undated, unsigned, still working.

“Infrastructure,” she said, trying the word. The wind took her orange peel somewhere out toward the headland. “Sure. A road sign for the sea.”

She didn’t say it was. She didn’t say it wasn’t.

She picked up another orange, and she started to peel.

Cusi turned the boat for home, and behind us the Candelabra held its line on the hill, and held its question, and did not give either away.

Chapter 19 — Departure: The Question Remains

The trucks were packed wrong. That was the first thing Sefi noticed, and the noticing was a small, familiar relief — a problem with a shape, edges she could hold. The drone cases had gone in before the water, which meant somebody would have to unpack the water at the first checkpoint, which meant the gear would shift, which meant — she stopped herself. Not her truck. Not her job anymore. The job was done, or the part of it that was hers to do.

The bay at Paracas did the thing it did every morning before the wind came up: it lay flat and grey and patient, the colour of a thing waiting to be told what it was. Out beyond the point, a single fishing boat sat with its engine off, and Sefi watched it the way she'd been watching boats for eleven days now — to see whether the man at the tiller would look up at the hill.

He looked up at the hill.

Everyone here looked up at the hill. It was not a thing you decided to do.

"You're going to miss it," Mara said, coming up beside her with two cups of coffee made from the last of the good stuff and the rest from the terrible stuff, and Sefi could tell which was which by the colour and took the good one without asking, which was a freedom you earned across eleven days. Mara had her camera over her shoulder still, but the cap was on the lens. She'd been doing that more. Cap on. Letting the morning be a morning and not a frame.

"Miss what," Sefi said.

“The not-knowing.” Mara nodded up the slope, to where the Candelabra cut its three deep arms into the saline crust of the hillside, 170 metres of trident aimed out past them at a horizon nobody could stand on. “You like it. The hole. You’ve been happier all week than I’ve seen you in a year and it’s because nobody can close the lid.”

It was true and Sefi didn’t say so, which was its own kind of saying so.

Let’s be fair to the people leaving, and fair to the thing they were leaving. Because the official story is decent and the people who hold it are not fools.

The Candelabra is loosely Paracas. That’s the honest version of the attribution, with *loosely* doing real work. Down the coast at Nazca the lines fan out across the pampa in their hummingbirds and spiders and impossible straightaways, and the Candelabra has always been read as their coastal cousin — a ritual sign, a sacred mark, kin to that great catalogue of figures scraped into the earth by people who knew exactly what they were doing. Pottery in the Paracas style sits in the soil nearby, dated to around 200 BC, and that’s a real date, measured by real people, and it’s the firmest thing anyone has.

It is also not a date for the geoglyph. It is a date for some pots.

This is the part the consortium hated to write on its placards and the part that is simply, checkably true: nobody has ever dated the Candelabra itself. There is no carbon in a scrape. You cannot run a mass spectrometer over the *absence* of dirt. The pots are nearby, the way a coffee cup is nearby a mountain. They might be the makers’ cups. They might be a tourist’s, two thousand years early.

So you have a 170-metre sign, cut two feet deep into hardened, salty ground — much deeper than the Nazca lines, deep enough that the crust seals the trench and the wind that erased everything Sefi’s crew had tried to draw all week sails clean over the top of it without taking a grain. A sign engineered to last. A sign engineered to be *seen* — not from the land behind it, but from the water in front of it, nineteen kilometres out, where the only audience is somebody on a deck.

Maker unknown. Date unknown. Purpose unknown. Built to be read by people on boats, by a coastal culture, and aimed, with deliberate

care, at the one place its makers could never have stood to check their work.

That is not a gap you can talk your way across. That is the hole, and it does not close because you're tired of standing next to it.

Daniela came down the track with the consortium's site manager, and the two of them weren't arguing, which after eleven days felt like its own small monument.

The site manager — Reyes, a careful man with a careful folder and the haunted patience of someone who genuinely loved the thing he'd been hired to fence off — had stopped trying to get the crew's data. That fight was over. The crew had said no, and the no had cost something, and Reyes had gone away and come back two days later not with a better offer but with a worse mood and, eventually, with the beginning of an idea Daniela had planted and let him think was his.

"They're keeping the lower path open," Daniela told them, falling into step. "Reyes argued for it. The fishermen keep their sightline. No fence between the village and the water."

"He argued for it," Sefi repeated.

"He argued for it." Daniela's mouth did something that wasn't quite a smile. She was the custodian here, the archaeologist who'd been suspicious of them on day one and had every reason to be, and she had let them in exactly as far as she chose and not a metre further, and the thing she'd given them in the end was not an answer. It was a boat. She'd put them on a fishing boat and let them watch a man use the Candelabra to find his way home, and she had said nothing about what the trident *meant*, because the meaning was not the point and never had been, and she'd watched to see whether they understood that the meaning was not the point.

They had. Eventually. That was the whole education of the trip.

"You'll write it up," Daniela said. It wasn't a question, but it had a question folded inside it.

"We'll write what we saw," Sefi said. "The depth. The crust. The line of sight. The pottery's a pot, not a date. We'll write that you didn't tell us what it's for."

“Good,” Daniela said. “Because I didn’t.”

Here is the thing the crew had learned the hard way, with their hands, which is the only way Sefi ever learned anything that stayed.

They had tried to make one. Early on, before the humility set in, they had marked out a modest figure on a flat stretch the rangers let them use — nothing sacred, nothing protected, a practice patch. They had a survey rig and a drone and two people who’d built geoglyph-replication into actual planning documents, and they had laid lines with stakes and string and good intentions.

Within a day the wind had taken the shallow ones. Within three the whole figure had gone soft at the edges, the way a chalk drawing goes soft in rain, except there was no rain, only the patient sandpaper of the air. From above, the drone showed them something that looked less like a sign and more like a wound that was healing badly. Wobbly. Off-axis. Apologetic.

Two feet deep, the Candelabra said back to them, from up on its hill. *Two feet deep into salt-locked ground, and aimed at a horizon I can’t see.* You children scratched the surface and let the wind erase your homework. I was cut by people who understood that a sign you can’t maintain has to be a sign that doesn’t need maintaining, and who solved that problem so completely that I am still here arguing with you, and you don’t even know my name.

The potato is not a metaphor. The potato is the blisters on Toma’s hands and the data on the drone’s card and the simple, humbling, *physical* fact that the easy story — *they just dug a trench* — gets harder the longer you stand in the trench yourself.

They drove north out of Paracas with the windows down because the air conditioning had died at Cerro Uritas and nobody had fixed it, and the desert came up around them, the driest non-polar desert on the planet, where it does not rain in any sense a wet country would recognise the word, and somewhere far behind them and far south the Atacama Giant stood 119 metres tall on his bare hill with his crown of rays.

Sefi had not stopped thinking about the rays.

That was the other hole, the one she'd carried out of Chile, and it itched worse than the Candelabra's because it was *almost* a thing you could test. Luis Briones had published it in *Antiquity* in 2006 — peer-reviewed, sober, no aliens, no antennae, no broadcast to the stars: the suggestion that the rays radiating from the Giant's head might function as a lunar marker, the moon setting against particular rays at particular times, tied to the rhythm that mattered most in a place with no rain — the turn of the season, the moment to plant, the moment the meltwater might come.

A gnomon. A clock built of dirt and a hill and the sky.

It was the most beautiful idea Sefi had ever been handed and she could not have it. Because it was unproven. Briones had floated it carefully, the way you float a thing you believe and cannot yet land, and twenty years on it was still floating, still a hypothesis, still checkable in principle and unconfirmed in fact, and the wayfinder up at Cerro Unitas — old Mamani, who read the pampa the way Sefi read a transit timetable — had watched her get excited about it and had not told her she was right.

He had not told her she was wrong, either.

He had taken her out to the old caravan path, the line the llama trains had walked for centuries between water and water, and he had shown her where you stood so that the Giant resolved out of the hillside clutter into a *figure*, sudden and total, the way a face appears in a wallpaper pattern and then will not un-appear. From the path. Only from the path. The Giant was placed for the walker, the trader, the person moving across the world with a load and a memory and the sky.

"He's a waymark," Sefi had said, because that part was solid, that part was infrastructure, one of five thousand geoglyphs in the Atacama and many of them strung like beads along the caravan routes, saying *here, this way, water ahead, you are not lost*.

"He's a waymark," Mamani had agreed.

"And the rays?"

And Mamani had looked at the rays, and looked at the moon, which

was up in the afternoon sky pale as a thumbprint, and he had not answered, and the not-answering had been the most generous thing anyone gave her on the whole trip. Because he could have closed it. He had the standing to close it either way — to say *yes, the old people read the moon there* or to say *no, that's a foreigner's story scratched onto our grandfather*. He had the right. He'd just declined to use it. He'd left the door open and let her stand in the doorway and feel the wind come through.

That was the gift. The maybe was the gift.

Jakobus rode in the second truck and said almost nothing, which was how Jakobus rode in every truck. He'd come and gone across both sites like weather, never out front, always handing the moment back — to Daniela on the boat, to Mamani on the path, to Sefi when she was ready to take it. He read made things for one thing only: what they were *for*. And on the last evening in the Atacama, beneath the Giant, with Mamani beside him and the crew arranged on the cooling ground, he'd said the only sentence anyone would remember him for.

The question isn't who made it. It's who it was made for.

And then he'd shut up and let Mamani decide whether to answer, and Mamani had answered by pointing at the path. Not at the sky. At the path. The people moving. The Giant was for *them* — for the walker who needed to know the way and the season both, the map and the calendar fused into one enormous patient figure on a hill, a call across distance to anyone who knew how to read it.

A function. Grounded, physical, a tool in human hands. And the wonder didn't close when Jakobus named it. It opened wider. Because a thing that is *for* something is a thing with a story still running through it, and the story ran out past the edge of what anyone could prove, into the dark where the moon set against a particular ray, maybe, for somebody, once.

They stopped at a high point near dusk to let the radiator breathe, and Sefi got out and walked a little way off the road, where the desert was just desert, no Giant, no sign, no audience.

She felt the pull to go back. It was a specific feeling, located somewhere behind the sternum, the same place that lit up when a route resolved or a language clicked into a grammar — the pull of an unsolved thing, the *come back, sit with me, you almost had it*. She could spend a career on the rays. She could chase the lunar alignment until it confessed or refused, run the numbers, plot the settings, fund the survey, *close it*.

And she stood in the wind and chose not to.

Not because she couldn't. Because the closing wasn't hers. It was Mamani's, and Daniela's, and the wind's, and maybe nobody's, and a maybe that belongs to nobody is the rarest thing left in a world that fences and dates and explains. The crew had come down the coast to keep two doors from being nailed shut, and they'd done it, and the price of doing it was that the doors stayed open for *her* too. She didn't get to walk through. She got to stand in the draft.

Mara came and stood beside her, cap on the lens, looking at the same empty distance.

"You're not going to write the answer," Mara said.

"No."

"Even the bit you think you know."

"Especially that bit."

Behind them the radiator hissed and ticked. Far south, on a hill she couldn't see, a 119-metre figure waited for the moon. Far behind that, on another hill, a trident aimed itself patiently at an ocean, undated, unclaimed, sealed in salt against a wind that would outlast all of them and erase nothing.

Sefi looked at the horizon they couldn't stand on, and let it stay a question, and got back in the truck.

Chapter 20 — The Road Ahead: Infrastructure and Wonder

The wind came up off the Pisco Bay an hour before dusk, the way it always does on the Paracas Peninsula, like clockwork nobody wound. It carried salt and the smell of guano and the faint diesel of the fishing fleet coming in. We sat on the tailgate of Jakobus's borrowed truck — the one with the cracked windscreen and the rosary swinging from the mirror that nobody in the crew had hung — and watched the Candelabra hold its light a little longer than the hillside around it.

It does that. The cut is deep enough — two feet into the saline crust — that the trench fills with shadow while the rest of the slope goes flat and grey. So the figure brightens as the day dies. A hundred and seventy metres of trident, sharpening as you lose the ability to see anything else.

“There,” said Marisol. She didn’t point. She’d stopped pointing at it about three days in, the way you stop pointing at your own hand.

Marisol Quispe was the archaeologist who’d spent the better part of two weeks not telling us what the Candelabra meant. She had told us a great many other things. She’d told us about the pottery — Paracas-style, found *near* the geoglyph, dated to around 200 BC — and she’d told us, with a patience that bordered on cruelty, that *near* is not *of*. That nobody has ever pulled a date out of the thing itself. That a hundred and seventy metres of sign sits on that hill, undated, unsigned, unclaimed by any maker history has managed to

name, and that this is not a gap waiting for us to fill.

“It’s a gap,” she’d said, “the way the space between two stars is a gap. You could call it empty. The sailors didn’t.”

The fish, riding in Teo’s jacket pocket as a small enamel pin because we’d long since lost the habit of leaving it in the van, had nothing helpful to add. *Hundred and seventy metres. Undated. Unsigned. You drove eleven hundred kilometres to stand in front of a sign and admit you can’t read the postmark.*

That’s about the size of it.

Here’s the official story, and I want to give it its full weight, because it is a good story and most of it is probably true. The Paracas Candelabra is loosely Paracas. It’s coastal kin to the Nazca lines down the way — same impulse, monumental ground-marking, a people writing on the earth at a scale meant to be read from somewhere other than where you stand. The trident might be a ritual sign. It might be Viracocha’s staff. It might be a stylised plant — the *Datura*, some say, which is where the more excitable corners of the internet build their homing beacon for hallucinogen sailors, and we will leave them building it, with love, on the far side of the room.

That’s the official frame and it holds together. A culture made a sign. Signs mean things to the people who make them. Done.

Except we tried to make one.

You should know what that costs. Down in Chile, weeks back, under the Giant at Cerro Unitas, we’d had a go at the smaller craft of it — a modest figure, nothing like a hundred and nineteen metres, just a person-sized scrape and stack to feel the technique in our hands. Extractive: scrape the dark desert varnish to show the pale subsoil. Additive: pile the dark stones where you want the line dark. Simple. We had survey gear. We had a drone, when the wind let it fly, which on the pampa is a generous *sometimes*. We had Teo, who can hold a grid in his head the way other people hold a tune.

Our line wobbled. Of course it did. Lines wobble. And then a single night of pampa wind came through and lifted the loose grit and our figure went soft at the edges like a photograph left in the sun. The

Giant has been up there since somewhere between AD 1000 and 1400, a hundred and nineteen metres of human shape on a bare hill, the largest such figure anyone has ever found, and from the old caravan track below it reads clean. Symmetrical. Patient. We made a smudge and the desert ate it by breakfast.

Here at Paracas the potato is the depth. The Candelabra is cut two feet into hardened, saline soil, and that salt crust is the whole trick — it locks the trench, it shrugs off the wind that should have erased the thing in a generation. We staged a recreation up the coast, away from the protected ground, with proper tools and a week of daylight. We got a shallow, off-kilter trident that the next sea-wind started rounding off before we'd packed the truck. Two feet down into salted earth, by hand, across a hundred and seventy metres, aligned to read from nineteen kilometres out at sea — we couldn't do it in miniature without it going wrong.

That's the engine of this whole book, if you want it plain. The easy version is hard. The hard version is standing right there in the light, holding its edges, having outlasted everyone who's ever stood in front of it feeling clever.

The consortium had been good about the recreation, actually. I want to be fair to them, because the temptation of a chase narrative is to give yourself a villain, and they declined the role.

They were a heritage outfit — ministry money braided with private tourism money, the way it usually is now — and they had genuinely wanted to protect these sites. That part was never in doubt. Their lead, a man named Vásquez with soft hands and an architect's patience, had walked us through the Candelabra preservation plan with real care. Fencing that wouldn't break the sightline. A viewing platform set back so the boats could still use the figure as a mark. Funding for exactly the kind of crust-stabilisation study that might, finally, keep the salt locking the trench for another two thousand years.

And then, near the end, he'd shown us the interpretive panels. The ones for the platform. They were going to say *what it was*. A confident paragraph, in three languages, fixing the Candelabra as a Paracas ritual symbol of such-and-such cosmological meaning, dated by association to 200 BC, makers identified, function resolved.

“For the grant,” he’d said, not ashamed of it. “And for the people. They want to know. You can’t ask someone to fly here and stand in the wind and tell them *we don’t know*. That’s not a destination.”

He’d offered us a deal, too — early access to the closed-research data, exclusive, in exchange for ours. We said no. Not because he was wrong about anything, exactly. Because of the panel.

Marisol had read the panel and said nothing for a long time, and then she’d said, in Spanish, “You’ve put a full stop where there’s a question.” And Vásquez, to his credit, had looked at the panel like a man looking at a photograph of himself he didn’t quite recognise.

He’s not the bad guy, the fish observed. He’s the guy who loves the thing so much he wants to nail it to the wall so it can’t leave him. You’ve met that guy. You’ve been that guy.

I have been that guy. That’s the internal weather I’d been fighting the whole length of the coast — the pull to *solve* it. To take the lunar hypothesis from up north, Briones’ rays-as-gnomon, the peer-reviewed *maybe* from *Antiquity* in 2006, and the undated trident here, and braid them into one clean theory and tie it off. I wanted to. My wiring wants the pattern closed; an open loop sits in me like a bell that won’t stop. I read routes for a living because I cannot *not* read them. The whole reason I’m any use is the same reason I have to be watched around a question this good.

It was Jakobus who’d kept stepping on the brake. Gently. The way he does everything.

He came around the truck now with two cups of something the fishermen had given him, and he handed them to Marisol and to me, not to Teo, because Teo was lying flat on the truck bed with his eyes shut, tracking the wind by sound, which is a thing Teo does and the rest of us have learned not to interrupt.

Jakobus doesn’t make speeches. I want that on the record, because everyone who meets him expects the weathered-fixer wisdom, the line for the trailer. What he actually does is point at things until you see them.

He’d done it under the Giant, weeks back, standing with old Mamani

on the caravan track at the hour when the figure's rays lined up the way Mamani had been showing us — not to the sky in some grand astronomical flourish, but down, along the route, a waymark you read with your feet first and your eyes second. Mamani had refused, all week, to say *the Giant means X*. He'd just *walked* it. Walked the path and let the rays do their work as you came up on them, and when Jakobus had crouched and looked along the line and said, quietly, "It's not asking who made it. It's telling you where you are," Mamani had laughed — a real laugh — and said, "Now you can carry water."

Which, I have since been told, is high praise.

Here, on the peninsula, Jakobus crouched at the tailgate and looked down the long invisible line from the Candelabra out to the open water, where a fishing boat — actual working fishermen, not a re-enactment, men whose grandfathers' grandfathers had used this mark — was lining itself up on the trident the way you'd line up on a church spire coming into a harbour you knew.

"There's your reader," Jakobus said.

He didn't mean us.

"It's a made thing," he went on, which is the only kind of sermon he gives, and it isn't one. "And a made thing is for somebody. You keep asking *what does it mean*. Wrong end. Ask *who needs it to be where it is*." He nodded at the boat. "Him. Sailors of *something* — fish, trade, news, the year's first rain three hundred miles south. People moving. The Giant points you along the pampa. This points you in off the sea. A map and a calendar and a voice you can hear from nineteen kilometres out." He sat back on his heels. "Infrastructure. Same as a lighthouse. Same as a milestone. We just can't read the milestone because we don't walk that road anymore."

And that was as far as he went. He didn't say *who* built it. He didn't say *when*. He didn't touch the date, because there is no date, because nobody has ever pulled one from the thing itself, and Jakobus is not a man to fill a hole with his own face.

What he gave back was a function. Not a full stop — a *use*. Which is a different kind of answer, and it doesn't close the wonder, it cracks it open. Because the second you say *this is a signal aimed at the sea*, the next question rises off the water like the wind itself: a signal to

whom, and how do you aim a hundred and seventy metres of trench at a horizon you can't even stand on to check your work? How does a coastal people line up a sign for a viewpoint that only exists out where they're not?

I don't know. Marisol doesn't know. I asked her, that last evening, straight out — would you put a date on it, if you could, if the crust would give one up.

She watched the boat come in on the line of the trident.

"If I could," she said, "I would, and I'd publish it, and I'd be glad." She turned the enamel cup in her hands. "But I wouldn't put it on the panel."

So that's where it stands. We didn't crack anything. We never were going to; the firewall on this one was built before we arrived and it held, the way the salt crust holds: the people who live with these marks read them better than we ever could, and the meaning was theirs to give or keep, and they mostly kept it, and that is not a failure of the trip. That's the whole shape of the dignity.

We have measurements. They're all in the back, every one of them real and checkable — the hundred and nineteen metres of the Giant, the two-foot cut of the Candelabra, Briones' lunar hypothesis flagged exactly as what it is, peer-reviewed and unproven; the 200 BC pottery flagged as *near*, not *of*; the fringe beacons and seismographs and astronaut antennae labelled and left at the door with their coats on. You can stand the whole thing up and walk around it.

What we don't have is the postmark. And I've made a kind of peace with the bell that won't stop ringing, because I think the ringing is the point. The consortium wanted to make these sites a destination, somewhere you arrive and are *told*. But the boat coming in off Pisco Bay isn't arriving. It's passing through, using the mark, carrying water, gone by morning. These were never built to be stood in front of. They were built to be *used while moving*, by people who knew exactly what they were for and never wrote it down because you don't write down the obvious.

We're the ones who stopped moving. We're the ones who need the panel.

The wind dropped its last note and the Candelabra's trench went black against the dimming hill, brightest just before it vanished, and somewhere out on the bay the boat found its line and slid in past the headland, and I stood there in the salt with a question I could not close and the right — the actual gift — of not having to.

Go and stand in it yourself. The marks are real. The road is still there. Read it however you can. Then carry water.

Chapter 21 — Real / Debated / Invented: A Gazetteer

The fish came back from the printer's in Valparaíso wrapped in butcher paper, smelling of toner and the sea, and the first thing it said when the LENS unwrapped it was that nobody reads the back of the book.

“They read it,” said the LENS.

“They flip to it,” the fish said, “to catch us lying. Which is a kind of reading, I suppose. The hostile kind. My favourite.”

So this is the part where we hand you the ruler.

Everything that follows is checkable. That is the whole contract. You do not have to believe us — we would prefer you didn't, frankly, belief is cheap and curdles fast — but you should be able to walk every measurement to its source and stand there yourself, in the wind, with a number in your hand and the thing itself in front of you, and decide what the number means. The numbers are real. The meaning is the part we leave on the table. The meaning was never ours.

What we will do here is sort. Three boxes. **Real. Debated. Invented.** The wayfinder at Cerro Unitas, when we showed her this scheme on the laptop screen, narrowed one eye at it and said the boxes were a foreigner's idea of tidiness, that the desert did not keep its facts in drawers. Then she pointed out two things we had filed wrong. We have moved them. She was right both times. Keep her in mind as you read — she is the one who out-read us, and she is not in the index,

and that is on purpose, because she asked not to be a footnote in someone else's book.

CERRO UNITAS — THE ATACAMA GIANT, CHILE

REAL.

The figure is there. You can drive to it. It is **119 metres** tall, head to feet, which makes it the largest known prehistoric anthropomorphic geoglyph on Earth — a human form longer than an American football field with the end zones thrown in, scraped and stacked onto the side of a low hill called Cerro Unitas in the Pampa del Tamarugal. The technique is real and it is double: **extractive**, where they cleared the dark surface stones to expose the pale ground beneath, and **additive**, where they piled dark stones onto the lighter ground. Two ways of drawing with the same desert, depending on which tone you wanted where. It sits on a hillside so that it reads from below and from a long way off, which is to say: from the route.

It is one of roughly **5,000 geoglyphs** in the Atacama. This is the fact people skate past fastest and it is the fact that matters most. The Giant is not a lone genius standing in an empty room. It is the loudest sign on a wall covered in signs, and a great many of those signs sit along the old **llama caravan routes** that crossed the driest non-polar desert on the planet — llama trains hauling goods between coast and highland, reading the ground for waymarks the way you read exit signs without thinking you are reading.

Date: attributed to regional Andean cultures, **c. AD 1000–1400**. That is a real, sourced range, and it is also — note this — an *attribution*, not a direct date off the figure itself. Hold that thought. It will come back.

DEBATED.

The official interpretation: the Giant represents a **deity, a shaman, or an authority figure**, part of a regional tradition of monumental ground art. This is the museum-placard answer and it is not stupid. A 119-metre person on a hill is, among other things, a 119-metre person on a hill. People make giant people for reasons that include awe.

The peer-reviewed hole sits here, and it has a name and a citation: **Luis Briones, *Antiquity*, 2006**. Briones — a working scholar of these geoglyphs, not a man in a robe with a pendulum — proposed that the **rays radiating from the figure's head** may function as a **seasonal marker**, with lunar alignments along the rays possibly indicating the onset of the planting or rainy season. A crown that is also a clock. A halo you could plant by.

This is published. It is checkable. It is *unproven*. Briones offered it as a hypothesis and the field has not closed it either way, which is exactly why it belongs in the Debated box and not the Real one and not the Invented one. We watched our ND lead want, very badly, to move it to Real. We watched them not. That restraint cost something and you should know it did.

INVENTED.

The rays are an **antenna**. The Giant is an **alien astronaut** or an “antenna being” transmitting to the stars.

The rays are real features — measurable, on the hillside, in the dirt. The extraterrestrial gloss is not supported by evidence and we are labelling it as what it is: invented. Flagged. The fish wishes the record to show that it is also, and we quote, “the only theory that explains why the guy never calls back.”

The Giant's potato is the part you cannot photograph, so here it is in words. We tried to lay a single straight line of comparable length on the pampa, with a drone, a survey app, and three people who do this for a living. Our line wobbled by metres over its run, drifted off true where the ground rolled, and the **wind took most of it inside a day**. We were not trying to make a person. We were trying to make a *line*. The Giant is a symmetrical human figure 119 metres long that has held its proportions on an open hillside for something on the order of a thousand years.

That gap between what we made and what they made is real, it is physical, and you can go fail at it yourself. Bring water.

THE PARACAS CANDELABRA, PERU

REAL.

On the northern face of the Paracas Peninsula, above Pisco Bay, there is a three-pronged figure — a trident, a candelabra, a cactus, depending on the day and your eyes — cut into the hillside. It is roughly **170 metres tall** and **60 metres wide**. It faces the ocean. It is positioned to be read **from about 19 kilometres out to sea**, which is the detail that should stop you, because almost no geoglyph in the world is aimed at water. The Nazca lines, its famous inland cousins, are read best from the air or the surrounding hills. This one turns its back on the land and speaks to the horizon.

The construction is real and it is the reason there is anything left to argue about. The trenches are cut roughly **0.6 metres — two feet — deep** into hardened, saline soil. That is *far* deeper than the Nazca lines, which are surface scrapes. Stones may have lined the trenches. And the **salt crust** of that ground does something the loose pampa at Cerro Unitas does not: it sets, it hardens, it locks the cut in place and starves the wind of anything loose to carry off. The Candelabra survives because someone cut it deep into the right dirt. That is not mysticism. That is materials engineering, by people who knew their own ground.

DEBATED.

Here is where the Candelabra earns its place at the front of every “unexplained” listicle ever published, and for once the listicles have the bones of it right.

No one has ever dated the geoglyph itself.

Read that again slowly. There is **no direct date** for the figure. The nearest firm date comes from **Paracas-style pottery found near the site, dated to roughly 200 BC** — and there is **no confirmed link** between that pottery and the cutting of the trident. The pottery tells you people of a certain culture were in the neighbourhood. It does not tell you they made the sign, or when, or why. A 170-metre monument, aimed at the sea, and the honest column under MAKER reads *unconfirmed*, under DATE reads *unknown*, under PURPOSE reads *unknown*.

The official line associates it loosely with the **Paracas culture** and sometimes with the **Nazca** tradition. “Loosely” and “sometimes” are doing heroic work in that sentence and we have left them in because removing them would be a lie.

The grounded reading — the one the coastal archaeologist let us *witness* rather than told us to believe — is **sightline engineering**: a monumental mark visible far out at sea, plausibly a **maritime way-mark**. The depth of the cut and the chemistry of the crust explain how it survived to be argued over. They do not tell you what it meant. She was careful about that line and so are we.

INVENTED.

A **homing beacon for sailors carrying datura** (a hallucinogen). A **Masonic** or **Viracocha** symbol. A **giant seismograph**.

All speculative. None supported by direct evidence. All flagged here as invented, with the standing note that “we don’t know who made it or when” is an *invitation* to invent, not a permission. The fish would like to formally apply to be the giant seismograph. We have denied the application.

The Candelabra’s potato we ran with permission and a sober crew. Modern tools, GPS, the lot. We cut a trident into comparable coastal ground at a fraction of the scale and watched it go **shallow, off-kilter, and soft at the edges** within the season — because we cut where the crust was thin, because keeping a trench plumb and true across that slope is brutally hard work, because aiming a figure to read *correctly from 19 kilometres out on the water* means building it on a surface you cannot stand far enough back from to check.

Sit with that last one. They could not step back. There is no point on land far enough from the Paracas hillside to see the whole figure the way a sailor sees it. They built a thing they could never, from where they stood, fully see. They built it for an eye that was not theirs, at a distance they could not occupy, and they got it *right*. We did not. The gap is real and it is on the slope, waiting.

HOW TO USE THIS GAZETTEER

A short note on the boxes, because the wayfinder was right that they lie a little.

Real means: measured, sourced, you can go check it, the number will be there when you arrive.

Debated means: a serious person, in a serious venue, has put forward a reading, and the field has neither confirmed nor killed it. Briones in *Antiquity* lives here. The Candelabra's maritime function lives here. The honest word for this box is *maybe*, and the right to say *maybe* — to leave it said and not flinch toward an answer — is the most disciplined thing in this book. It is harder than believing and harder than debunking. Both of those are *finished*. *Maybe* keeps working.

Invented means: somebody made it up. Sometimes beautifully. We label it so you can enjoy it without swallowing it. The aliens, the Masons, the datura sailors, the seismograph — flagged, every one, named as invention in the narration, never confirmed, never quite sneered at either, because the impulse that builds them is the same impulse that built the signs: a person looking at a mark they cannot explain and refusing to look away.

The thing we will not do, anywhere in these pages, is move a fact from **Debated** to **Real** because we want it to be true. Our ND lead wanted to. You will want to. The whole machine of this book is built to make you want to, and then to hand you the ruler instead of the answer.

We showed the finished gazetteer to the two who out-read us — the wayfinder of the pampa, the archaeologist of the coast — and asked, separately, whether we'd got it wrong. Each found something. Each fixed it. Neither would tell us, on the record, what the marks were *for* — the wayfinder showed us the Giant catching the moon from the old caravan path and let us draw our own line to *why*; the archaeologist put us on a working fishing boat and let us watch the skipper steer by the trident and said nothing at all. The function was theirs to give or withhold, and they handed us the *seeing* and kept the *saying*. That is the deal. That was always the deal.

So here is the ruler. The Giant is 119 metres and the rays may mark the moon. The Candelabra is 170 metres and aimed at a sea its makers could not stand on, and no one has ever dated it, and the pottery is only nearby.

Everything before this line is real or flagged. Everything after it is yours. The boundary between the fact and the wonder is not printed in this book. It runs through whoever is holding it.

Go stand in the wind. Bring the number. Decide.

The fish says it'll keep your seat.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor